

LG, CM Rekha attend Ambedkar University convocation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday attended the 14th annual convocation ceremony of Dr BR Ambedkar University Delhi. On the occasion, LG and the Chief Minister urged graduating students to use education as a tool for social responsibility and nation-building.

Addressing students on the university campus, the Lieutenant Governor said a degree should be viewed not only as an academic achievement but also as a commitment to society and the country. He said universities must prepare young people

to face future challenges through innovation, research, and social engagement.

The convocation ceremony was attended by Education Minister Ashish Sood, university officials, faculty members, researchers, students, and guests. The programme began with an NCC guard of honour for the dignitaries.

Degrees were awarded to undergraduate, postgraduate, and doctoral students from different faculties. Research work in areas such as Development Studies, Human Ecology, Archaeology, Social Design, and Urban Studies was specially recognised during the event.

The university also released its newsletter and

research compendium highlighting academic and research achievements. Officials said the institution completed uploading degree scrolls to DigLocker as part of efforts to strengthen digital governance.

Speaking at the ceremony, Lieutenant Governor Sandhu said the university had established a strong identity in social sciences, humanities, and public engagement during the last 17 years. He noted that the institution started in 2008 with only a diploma programme and had now developed into a multidisciplinary university offering a wide range of courses. He said convocation ceremonies represent an important turning point in stu-



dents' lives, marking the completion of one phase and the beginning of another filled with greater responsibilities.

The Lieutenant Governor praised the university's work in implementing the National Education Policy and pro-

logical changes across the world, including artificial intelligence and evolving economic conditions, Sandhu said India's youth population remained the country's greatest strength. He urged universities to encourage multidisciplinary learning, entrepreneurship, vocational training, and industry collaboration. He also advised students to build qualities such as leadership, integrity, empathy, and public service while pursuing professional success.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta congratulated students receiving degrees and medals and described the ceremony as a recognition of years of hard work, discipline, and perseverance. She said convocation ceremonies are not

limited to academic success but also represent a new responsibility towards society and the nation.

The Chief Minister noted that the university began with only 19 students and has now grown to more than 6,000 students. She said the institution has continued to promote the ideals of Babasaheb Ambedkar by encouraging social awareness, equality, and national consciousness among students.

The Chief Minister also referred to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's public appeals related to resource conservation and self-reliance. She said small efforts made by citizens in daily life could strengthen the country's economy and

support the vision of a developed India by 2047.

Education Minister Ashish Sood said education remains one of the strongest forces for transforming individuals and society. He said students must move beyond degrees and continue learning throughout their lives, especially at a time when technology and artificial intelligence are reshaping the world.

Sood also spoke about responsible citizenship, honesty, patience, and empathy. Referring to the Prime Minister's call for energy conservation and greater use of public transport, he said nation-building depends on meaningful contributions made by ordinary citizens.

Female teacher arrested in Janakpuri school assault case

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

A fresh arrest in the alleged sexual assault of a three-year-old girl inside a private school in West Delhi's Janakpuri has intensified the investigation, with Delhi Police arresting a female teacher in connection with the case and securing her one-day police custody remand.

Police said they had sought a two-day custody remand of the teacher for further investigation. However, after hearing the arguments, the

court granted a one-day remand in police custody. Officials said the teacher was arrested based on evidence gathered during the probe and that a "thorough investigation" was underway. Earlier, the Deputy Commissioner of Police (West), Darade Sharad Bhaskar, told *The Pioneer* that the police were in the process of filing an appeal in the High Court against the bail granted to the accused caretaker.

Taking to their official X handle, the Delhi police shared updates in this case. They wrote, "In the incident of

sexual assault with a minor in the Janakpuri police station area, an FIR under Section 64(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and Section 6 of the POCSO Act was registered on May 1 immediately on the complaint of the victim's mother after the child was medically examined."

The police also dismissed certain media reports alleging harassment or intimidation of the complainant and the child during the course of the investigation and called such allegations "false and baseless."

According to the police's state-



ment, the child and her mother were provided with a "comfortable, child-friendly environment" during the inquiry proceedings. They were approached only for lawful inquiry and counselling. The statement also noted that police arrested the

accused caretaker immediately after the child identified him on the same day the complaint was lodged. Statements from the child and her mother were recorded before a judicial magistrate, while CCTV footage, DVR recordings and other exhibits were seized as part of the investigation.

A court in Dwarka had granted bail to the 57-year-old man on May 7 after observing that the child's medical examination did not reveal any signs of injury or redness. The court had also

taken note of CCTV footage, which allegedly showed the caretaker leaving the junior wing of the school in the morning and not returning during the period when the assault was alleged to have taken place.

The Delhi Police's statement also noted that the Joint Commissioner of Police of the range had been directed to meet the victim's parents and submit a report within 24 hours. The alleged incident took place on April 30, the toddler's second day at the school.

Metro to launch hydrogen-powered buses in Central Vista area

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) will launch a hydrogen-powered shuttle bus service in the Central Vista area from Friday to promote public transport use among Government employees in view of the Centre's energy-saving measures.

The shuttle service will provide last-mile connectivity between Central Secretariat and Seva Teerth metro stations

and key government offices in the Central Vista region, the DMRC said in a statement. According to it, IOCL has provided two hydrogen-fuelled buses, each with a seating capacity of 35 passengers. The buses are equipped with GPS tracking and CCTV systems.

The service will operate on all working days from Monday to Friday, excluding gazetted holidays, during peak office hours between 8.30 am and 12.30 pm and from 3.30 pm to 6.30 pm, the statement said.

PUNE MUNICIPAL CORPORATION

CHIEF ENGINEER DEPARTMENT

NOTICE INVITING TENDERS (N.I.T) YEAR 2025-26

Tender Sale Date:- 15-05-2026 to Date 08-06-2026 upto 02:30 PM

Bid Submission Start & End Date :- 15-05-2026 to Date 08-06-2026 upto 02:30 PM Technical Envelope Opening Date :-09-06-2026 03:00 PM

Tender NO.	Name of Department	Name of Work	Cost of Tender Document (Rs.)	Estimated Cost (Rs.)	EMD Amount Rs.	Work Period (Month)	Concern Contact Person
PMC/ELECTRICAL/2026/20	Electrical	Providing MSBDCL Supply to 127 MLD Naidu Sewage Treatment Plants of Pune Municipal Corporation Funded by JICA project	Rs. 17879/-	Rs. 52893908/-	Rs. 264469.5/-	12	Sandeep Sapkal 9689931068

A) All details of Terms & Conditions of above works are incorporated in tender documents which is available on website www.mahatenders.gov.in. Sale acceptance is available by online system only. Tender needs to be submit in two envelope format.

B) If sales or submission not been available on last day also & it is not been submitted will be sole responsibility of tenderer.

C) Online tender process information will be available at Water Supply, Pune Municipal Corporation.

D) As per office order No. 32, dated 22/04/2016 EMD deposit amount will be acceptable through ECS/RTGS/NEFT Online Banking only.

Ashok Kedari

कार्यकारी अभियन्ता

कायालय (विद्युत)

पुणे महानगरपालिका

Advt.No. : 3/125

Date : 14/05/2026

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM

OFFICE OF THE PRINCIPAL CUM CHIEF SUPERINTENDENT

JORHAT MEDICAL COLLEGE & HOSPITAL, JORHAT (Under Society for Medical Education Jorhat)

No. SMEJ/JMCH/2721 /2023/Pt- 3/2026/ 1806

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

(For e-Procurement of Plumbing, Sanitary, AC, Hardware, Refrigerator Items)

Online bid(two bid systems) are invited from experienced Supplier for supply of "Plumbing, Sanitary, Hardware, AC, Refrigerator Items" on rate contract basis for Jorhat Medical College & Hospital, Jorhat-Assam as per following schedule:

NAME OF Activity	Estimated Value (In Rs.)	Date and Time of Publishing of E-Bid Document	Date and Time of Pre-Bid Meeting	Date and Time of Start of Bid Submission	Date and Time of End of Bid submission	Date and Time of Opening of E-Technical Bid
Supply of Plumbing, Sanitary, Hardware, AC, Refrigerator Items etc. on rate contract basis for JMCH, Jorhat	Rs. 10,00,000.00	2.00 P.M of 14/05/2026	1:00 P.M of 20/05/2026	12:00 P.M of 21/05/2026	12:00 P.M of 05/06/2026	1:00 P.M of 05/06/2026

Instructions for e-tendering:

1. The complete e-tender document may be obtained from the e-tender portal: <https://assamtenders.gov.in/> & our official website: <https://jorhatmch.assam.gov.in/> (reference only).

2. The bidder **MUST** be submit a hardcopy of their tender document (technical bid) to the o/o. the Principal cum Chief Superintendent, JMC&H, Jorhat after successful submission of their tender through online on or before **05/06/2026 upto 12.00 P.M.**

3. A Pre-Bid Meeting will be held on **20-05-2026 from 1.00 P.M** onwards. The address for the Pre-Bid Meeting is **College Council Hall, Administrative Building, Jorhat Medical College, Jail Road, Jorhat (Assam).**

4. The bid will be opened online on the e-procurement portal as per the schedule mentioned aWive.

5. The TIA reserves the right to accept or reject any bid/tender, and to cancel/afcnul the bidt/jfrg process and reject all bids at any time prior to contract award

Sd/-

Principal cum Chief Superirident,

Jorhat Medical College & Hospital, Jorhat

DIPR/C/PIO/45/15-May-26

PUBLIC NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given that Lalit Kumar and Kumari Sonu are the owners and in possession of Property No. 247, Sector-05, Ansal Chiranjiv Vihar, Village Mehrauli, Mehrauli Harsoon, Ghaziabad, UP (hereinafter called the said property) by virtue of Sale Deed dated 27.05.2022 executed by Amit Kumar bearing Doc. No. 2713, as per the current owners the Sale Deeds dated 28.02.2006 and 25.07.2006 bearing Doc. Nos. 1399 and 5237 in respect of the said property have been misplace and same are not traceable and accordingly an information report have been filed with Lucknow, U.P. Police on 13.05.2026 vide LR No. 20260000441811 with regard to loss of said document, any person/s in possession of the above mentioned document or having claim against the said Property, are hereby intimated to notify the same in writing to us at the address mentioned below.

Vishal Diwan (Advocate)

Diwan & Company

Ho.No.2 (LGF), NRI Complex, N.D-19

Mobile No. 9818399999

PUBLIC NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given that Ashok Kumar Dua claims to be owner and in possession of Second Floor of Prop. No.791, Sec-31-32A, Gurugram, Haryana (herein after called the said property) by virtue of Sale Deed dated 28.02.2020, Document No. 19319 having purchased from Sachin Taneja who was the owner by virtue of Transfer Deed dated 08.09.2015 Document No. 14107 r/w Sale Deed dated 17.10.2011 Document No. 20735 & said Ashok Kumar Dua has agreed to sell the said Property to Tanmay Gupta & Neha Gupta and said Tanmay Gupta & Neha Gupta agreed to create a mortgage in favour of our clients IDFC FIRST BANK LTD, Rajendra Place Branch, any person/s having claim against the said Property, or any part thereof, by way of sale, exchange, mortgage (equitable/registered or otherwise), gift, trust, inheritance, lien or otherwise however, are hereby intimated to notify the same in writing to us with supporting documentary evidence at the address mentioned below within 7days from the date hereof, failing which the claim or claims, if any, of such person or persons will be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned and our client shall proceed with the disbursement of loan and subsequent creation of mortgage in respect thereof.

Vishal Diwan (Advocate)

Diwan & Company

Ho.No.2 (LGF), NRI Complex, N.D-19

Mobile No. 9818399999

NORTHERN RAILWAY

OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE

The Sr. Divisional Engineer-III, Northern Railway, Delhi Division invites E-Tender for the following work.

Name of work	Replacement of steel girder by PSC slab of Br. No. 8UP & DN GAL of (3x12.35m) clear span steel girder bridge on Ind BR-SBB section at KM 9.856 under SSE/W/NDLS/Line in the section of ADEN/NDLS
Approx cost of work	1,55,51,970.72 (Rupees One Crore Fifty Five Lakh Fifty One Thousand Nine Hundred Seventy and Seventy Two Paise Only)
Earnest Money to be deposited	Rs. 3,11,000.00/- (Rupees Three Lakh Eleven Thousand Only)
Cost of tender document	Rs. 0.00/-
Date & Time of submission of tender bid and opening of tender	15.06.2026 @ 15:00 Hrs.
Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen	www.ireps.gov.in

* The tenderer/s must be registered on the Indian Railway E-Procurement system (IREPS) site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for participating in the e-tender system. * For all terms and conditions please refer tender document. * No manual offers are acceptable. * Cost of tender document and Earnest money will be acceptable through net banking or payment gateway only.

No. 128-W/280/e Tender Notice/NIT/19/2026-27/W-3

Dated:- 13.05.2026

1603/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER, PWD (ROADS), CACHAR CIRCLE, SILCHAR

No:-T/C/ETN/SIL/2025-26/1 (T)

PRESS NOTICE INVITING RE-TENDER (e-Procurement)

The Superintending Engineer, PWD (Roads) Cachar Circle, Silchar on behalf of Governor of Assam, re-invites bids against this office earlier press notice no. T/C/ETN/SIL/2025-26/1348(T) Dtd. Silchar, the 07th March/2026 for 1 (One) No. of package for Construction of Roads under **Balance work of Chief Minister's Special Package for Barak Valley During 2013-14** within Cachar District of Assam (under Katigorah LAC) amounting to approximately Rs. 167.44 Lakh (Rupees One Crore Sixty Seven Lakh Forty Four Thousand) only including GST etc. within the jurisdiction of P.W.R.D. Borkhola and Katigorah Territorial Road Division, Katigorah from approved and eligible contractors registered with Public Works Department (Roads), Assam.

Details may be seen at website www.assamtenders.gov.in and also in the office of the undersigned during office hours from 16/05/2026, 10:00 hours onwards. Amendment /Addendum to the SBD, if any, and further notifications shall appear in this website and also at the office of the undersigned during office hours. The contractor/bidder must be registered with the Electronic Tendering System (ETS) of PWRD, Assam website www.assamtenders.gov.in .

Note:- N.I.T. Value is inclusive of GST (12%), Labour cess(1%) etc.

Sd/-

Superintending Engineer, PWD(Roads)

Cachar Circle, Silchar.

DIPR/C/PIO/44/15-May-26

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER: PWD BUILDING::ASSAM::GUWAHATI-3.

No. CE-TB-III(B)33/2025/16

PRESS NOTICE

It is for general information to all concerned that the bid invited earlier vide Press Notice No. CE-TB III(B)33/2023 Dated 13-03-2023 is hereby cancelled and the Bid is invited by the Chief Engineer, P.W.D.(Building), Assam on behalf of the Chief Engineer to invite eligible Firm/Contractor of reputed having requisite experience in similar nature of works for the following work through Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC) Mode of bid may be seen at e-procurement portal www.assamtes.gov.in. The bidders must be enrolled on www.assamtes.gov.in.

Sl. No.	Name of work	Approx value of work (in Rs.)	Bid Security	Bid Processing Fee	Completion period
1	Development of Mahapurush Sri Sri Anirudha Dev Janakhmatra at Naranaypur, Lakhimpur, Assam	Rs. 13,51,34,751.00	Rs. 27,02,695 for General Category and Rs. 13,51,347.00 for Reserved Category	Rs.20,000.00	20 (twenty month)

Note:

(i) Value of work may vary according to the detail NIT.

(ii) All terms and conditions will be as per the Bidding Documents.

(iii) The Press Notice will be a part of the Bidding Documents.

Sd/-

Chief Engineer, PWD (Building)

Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3.

DIPR/C/PIO/47/15-May-26

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER PWD BUILDING ASSAM:: GUWAHATI-3

No. CE/TB-II(Bldg.)3/37/2025/5

PRESS NOTICE

The Chief Engineer, PWD (Building), Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-03 on behalf of the Governor of Assam, invites Bid through Engineering Procurement and Construction (EPC Mode- I of contract for the work detailed in the table below, from eligible Firm/Contractor or reputed having experience in similar nature of work. Details of bid may be seen at e-procurement portal i.e. www.assamtenders.gov.in

The Bidders must be enrolled with e-tendering web portal www.assamtenders.gov.in.

Sl. No.	Name of work	Approx. Value of work	Bid Security	Bid Processing Fee	Completion period
1	Construction of Additional New Judicial Court Building, Sivasagar	11,02,03,758.00	2 % for General category or 1 % for Reserved category on value of work	20,000.00	24 (Twenty Four) Months

Note:-

(i) Value of work may vary according to the detail NIT.

(ii) All terms and conditions will be as per the Bidding Documents.

(iii) The Press Notice will be a part of the Bidding Documents.

Sd/-

Chief Engineer, PWD (Building)

Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3.

DIPR/C/PIO/46/15-May-26

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA

TENDER NOTICE

SR NO.	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	PWD B&R, HISAR	UPGRADATION OF ELECTRIC SUB STATION AT CIVIL HOSPITAL DABWALI IN DISTT. SIRSA.(PDG. ELECTRICAL APPLIANCES ONLY).	13.05.2026 19.05.2026	6.23 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01662225651 pwd-eeed-hissar@hry.nic.in
2	PWD B&R, HISAR	WIDENING AND STRENGTHENING OF ROAD GORCHI TO BARWA ROAD RD 0.00 TO 8.080 (ROAD ID 11567) IN HISAR DISTRICT. (PDG. SHIFTING OF HT/LT LINES UNDER S/DIVN DHBVN SIWANI) + 1 WORKS	13.05.2026 22.05.2026	67.19 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01662225651 pwd-eeed-hissar@hry.nic.in
3	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, PANCHKULA	SUPPLY, ERECTION AND COMMISSIONING OF 02 NO. 06 DIRECTIONAL EOT CRANE APROVED MAKE OF 05 TONNE CAPACITY BY CONVERSION OF EXISTING MANUAL HOT TO EOT (ELECTRIC OPERATED TRAVELLING CRANE) FOR MECH. DIVISION FARIDABAD OF IRRIGATION DEPARTMENT.	14.05.2026 28.05.2026	14 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	0172-2582542 xenproc@gmail.com
4	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, PANCHKULA	SUPPLY OF ELECTRICAL ITEMS PERTAINING TO WORKSHOP DIVISION, CHARKHI DADR	14.05.2026 28.05.2026	49.34 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01272582542 xenproc@gmail.com
5	PANCHAYATI RAJ, CHARKHI DADR	CONSTRUCTION OF PARSHURAM BHAWAN AT VILLAGE BJINA HOJHU KALAN + 3 WORKS	11.05.2026 18.05.2026	129.75 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9582622008 xenprcharkhidadr@gmail.com
6	CIVIL SURGEON, KATHAL	REFRESHMENT & LUNCH	15.05.2026 21.05.2026	EMD 10000	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	7988672699 drugstorekti@gmail.com
7	CIVIL SURGEON,FARIDABAD	SUPPLY OF PMSMA DIET FOR DHFWS FARIDABAD	15.05.2026 29.05.2026	18 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9990443268 damfaridabad@gmail.com
8	CIVIL SURGEON,FARIDABAD	HIRING OF E-RICKSHAW FOR URBAN AREA IMMUNIZATION PROGRAMME	18.05.2026 01.06.2026	90 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9990443268 damfaridabad@gmail.com
9	PUBLIC HEALTH ENGINEERING,MANDI DABWALI	KALANWALI TOWN:- DNIT FOR DE-SILTING OF MANHOLE CHAMBERS IN THE NARROW STREETS OF KALANWALI TOWN BY USING A JETTING CUM SUCTION MACHINE HAVING A CAPACITY OF SUCTION TANK ABOVE 4500 LTRS., INCLUDING THE COST OF DIESEL, DRIVER AND 2 NOS. HELPERS FOR OPERATING THE MACHINE, AND DISPOSAL OF THE EXCAVATED MALBA/SILT OUTSIDE THE MUNICIPAL COMMITTEE LIMITS, COMPLETE IN ALL RESPECTS.	13.05.2026 21.05.2026	4.95 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	8730000001 ee.mandidabwali@gmail.com
10	CIVIL AVIATION DEPARTMENT, HARYANA	RENEWAL OF COMPREHENSIVE INSURANCE OF ONE NEW TWIN ENGINE STATE VIP HELICOPTER, VT-HRY	12.05.2026 01.06.2026		www.haraviation.gov.in	01722709386 cavation@hry.nic.in

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT www.etenders.hry.nic.in

RO 45195-I-27-7

NIA files 7,500-page chargesheet in Red Fort bomb attack

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Thursday submitted a voluminous 7,500-page chargesheet against 10 accused in the devastating Vehicle-Borne Improvised Explosive Device (VBIED) blast near the Red Fort that killed 11 people and injured several others on November 10 last year.

The high-intensity explosion tore through the national Capital's historic precinct, leaving mangled vehicles, shattered glass and widespread property damage in one of the boldest terror strikes in recent years.

The NIA, which took over the case from Delhi Police, has described the attack as the chilling result of a meticulously planned 'Jihadi

Conspiracy' by members of Ansar Ghazwat-ul-Hind (AGuH), a banned offshoot of the Al-Qaeda in the Indian Subcontinent (AQIS).

AQIS and its manifestations were declared terrorist organisations by the Ministry of Home Affairs in June 2018. All 10 accused, including the main perpetrator, Dr Umer Un Nabi, an ex-assistant professor of medicine at Al-Falah University in Faridabad, Haryana, were deeply linked to the outfit.

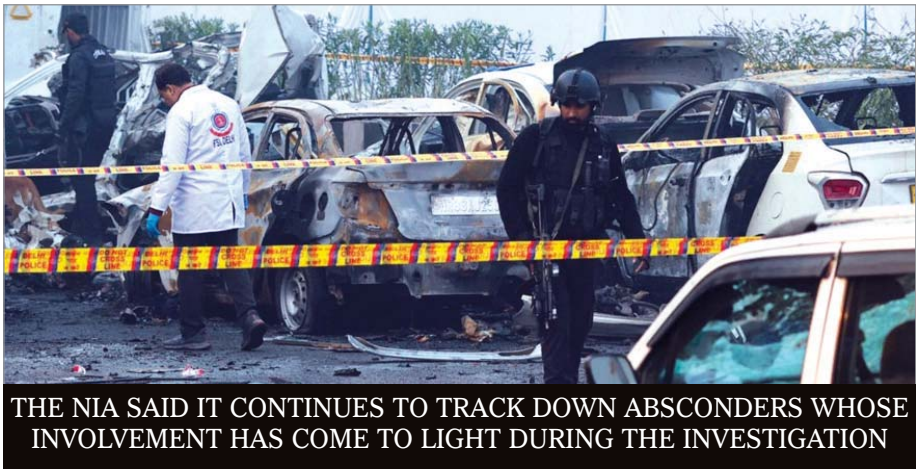
Dr Nabi, who died in the blast, had his charges proposed for abatement. The other nine named are: Aamir Rashid Mir, Jasir Bilal Wani, Dr Muzamil Shakeel, Dr Adeel Ahmed Rather, Dr Shaheen Saeed, Mufti Irfan Ahmad Wagay, Soyab, Dr Bilal Naseer Malla and Yasir Ahmad Dar. Several are radicalised

medical professionals, the agency said. The NIA's forensic probe exposed a sophisticated terror module spanning multiple states.

The chargesheet, filed before the NIA special court at Patiala House Courts, reveals the accused secretly reconstituted AGuH as 'AGuH Interim' at a clandestine Srinagar meeting in 2022 after a failed migration attempt to Afghanistan via Turkey.

They then launched "Operation Heavenly Hind" to overthrow India's democratic Government and impose Sharia rule. Driven by this ideology, the group recruited members, propagated violent jihadi propaganda, stockpiled arms and manufactured explosives on a large scale using commercial chemicals.

The Red Fort blast used



Triacetone Triperoxide (TATP), a powerful homemade explosive, which the accused produced after procuring ingredients and perfecting the mixture through repeated experiments.

The module also fabricated

and tested various Improvised Explosive Devices, including rocket- and drone-mounted versions aimed at security targets in Jammu and Kashmir and elsewhere.

They illegally procured an AK-47 rifle, a Krinkov rifle

and country-made pistols with live ammunition. Specialised lab equipment, such as Mixed Metal Oxide (MMO) Anodes, electrical circuits, and switches, was sourced online and offline to aid bomb-making.

Plans existed to expand operations nationwide. The probe agency said the terror module planned to expand its operations across India.

The investigation covered Jammu and Kashmir, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, Gujarat and Delhi-NCR. It rests on 588 oral testimonies, over 395 documents and more than 200 seized exhibits. Dr Nabi's identity was confirmed via DNA fingerprinting.

Forensic analysis of blast-site evidence and linked locations, including Al-Falah University and Jammu and Kashmir hideouts, included voice analysis and other scientific tests.

The chargesheet invokes the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, 1967; Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023; Explosive Substances Act,

1908; Arms Act, 1959; and Prevention of Damage to Public Property Act, 1984. Eleven people have been arrested so far. The NIA is pursuing absconders whose roles have surfaced. The NIA said it continues to track down absconders whose involvement has come to light during the investigation.

The mammoth chargesheet highlights the rising sophistication of home-grown terror networks inspired by global jihadist groups. By dismantling 'Operation Heavenly Hind', the NIA has sent a clear signal that such plots will be decimated through relentless, evidence-driven investigation. Once the designated NIA court takes cognisance of the chargesheet, the trial of the Red Fort terror attack will commence.

CM reduces official convoy to 60%

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta has reduced her official convoy size by around 60 per cent, with the carcade now comprising only four vehicles, including two Electric Vehicles (EVs), as part of a series of fuel-saving measures amid the ongoing conflict in West Asia.

Officials said both Gupta and Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu used EVs on Thursday while operating with reduced security convoys. The move comes in response to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal to citizens to support energy conservation and reduce fuel consumption.



The initiative aims to promote responsible governance, reduce fuel consumption, and encourage environmentally sustainable practices in public life

— REKHA GUPTA, CHIEF MINISTER

port, carpooling and electric vehicles wherever possible, saying such collective efforts could strengthen energy security and help build a greener and cleaner Delhi for future generations.

The Chief Minister directed ministers and Government officials to give preference to electric vehicles, Metro services, and public transport for official work. In a symbolic gesture, the Chief Minister travelled to the 14th convocation ceremony of Dr BR Ambedkar University in an electric vehicle with minimal security arrangements.

The Delhi Government said the initiative aims to promote responsible governance, reduce fuel consumption, and encourage environmentally sustainable practices in public life. Officials said the decision also reflects an effort to move away from what the Government described as excessive VIP culture.

Addressing the issue, the Chief Minister said small individual efforts can collectively create a large impact on the country's economy and environment.

The Government said public transport systems in Delhi and the NCR are capable of supporting such a shift. Delhi Metro and DTC bus services already connect major residential, commercial, and industrial areas across the city and surrounding regions. The latest move also comes amid a broader campaign by the Delhi Government to support fuel conservation measures in line with the Prime Minister's public appeal.

The CM also used the occasion to respond to criticism from Opposition parties over the decision to scale down official convoys. She said Opposition leaders had earlier demanded that Governments themselves adopt such measures before appealing to the public.

The Delhi Government is expected to issue further guidelines to departments regarding reduced vehicle use and greater reliance on public transport and electric mobility systems in the coming weeks.

Ashish Sood shifts meetings with Govt school heads to virtual mode

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood has decided to conduct his ongoing interaction programme with heads of Government schools entirely through virtual mode following Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal to adopt measures aimed at reducing avoidable travel and promoting efficient governance practices.



The interaction programme, organised by the Directorate of Education (DoE), is aimed at strengthening the school education system through direct discussions with heads of schools on academic planning, implementation of educational initiatives, learning outcomes, infrastructure, administrative coordination and student welfare.

According to a statement, the first interaction session, covering East Delhi Zones 1 and 2, was held on May 12. Sood travelled to the venue by Delhi Metro and later by battery-operated rickshaw to underscore the importance of sustainable and

accessible public transport. Subsequently, the remaining meetings under the programme will now be conducted online, it said.

Interaction sessions totalling 11 have been planned to cover all 28 education zones in the national Capital. The next session, covering zones 24, 26, 27 and 28 of South, Central and New Delhi districts, will be held online on May 15, the DoE said. The Directorate has directed all regional directors of education and deputy directors of education to ensure participation of heads of Government schools

under their jurisdiction. The statement also laid down guidelines for participation, including punctual login, use of official designation and school names, maintaining professional decorum and safeguarding confidentiality of meeting links and proceedings.

On Tuesday, Sood launched an 11-day district-wise drive covering around 1,000 schools to review academic standards, infrastructure, administrative issues and student welfare through interactions with heads of schools and education officials.

Delhi gang rape horror: Woman raped in bus, two arrested

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A routine day turned into a nightmare for a woman in Outer Delhi after a bus driver and his helper allegedly gang-raped her inside a private bus, police officials said. Following the report of the incident, police arrested the two accused and seized the bus used in the crime for forensic examination. The two accused, Umesh and Ramendra, were identified and arrested shortly after the incident was reported. Ramendra was allegedly driving the bus at the time of the crime.



Police said, the woman is married and has three children. While returning home after work, she reached the bus stand in Saraswati Vihar and allegedly approached a man near the door of a private bus to ask for the time. The man allegedly pulled her inside the bus, after which the vehicle moved towards Nangloi. Police said the driver and conductor then allegedly raped her in turn.

Police said the two accused, both residents of Uttar Pradesh, had allegedly planned to pick up passengers from Nangloi. A PCR call regarding the incident was received from the Nangloi area around 4.45 am on Tuesday, following which a police team launched an immediate operation and apprehended the accused.

The victim underwent a medical examination, and an FIR was registered at the Rani Bagh police station under Sections of rape, gang rape, and common intentions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). Police said they are investigating the case from multiple angles.

Centre removes IAS officer Padma Jaiswal from service

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Padma Jaiswal, a 2003-batch IAS officer of the Arunachal Pradesh-Goa-Mizoram (AGMUT) cadre, has been removed from service by the Centre. The Union Ministry of Home Affairs, as the cadre-controlling authority, imposed the major penalty of removal after a prolonged disciplinary inquiry. The order was issued on 12-13 May 2026 with final approval from the President on the recommendation of the Department of Personnel and Training, Government of India.



The case stems from her tenure as Deputy Commissioner of West Kameng district in Arunachal Pradesh during 2007-2008. She was accused of misappropriating and misutilising public funds, abusing her official position, and diverting government money. A CBI chargesheet filed in late 2024 alleged the misappropriation of around 728 lakh, with some of the funds used to acquire properties in the names of her relatives. She was also charged with violating the All India Services (Conduct) Rules by failing to maintain absolute integrity and devotion to duty.

Key timeline: February 2008: Residents filed a complaint alleging misappropriation of government revenue. **April 2008:** Placed under suspension (revoked October 2010). **2009-2010:** Charge memoranda issued by MHA under the All India Services (Discipline & Appeal) Rules.

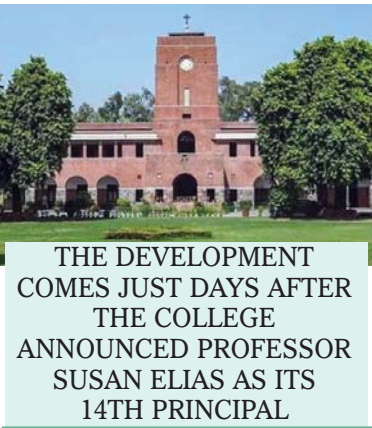
DU tells St Stephen's to halt principal's appointment

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

The University of Delhi has asked St Stephen's College not to proceed with the appointment of its newly named principal. The university wrote to the college's Governing Body on Thursday to state that the selection committee constituted for the appointment was not formed in accordance with UGC Regulations 2018, and that the recommendations of such a committee cannot be acted upon.

The letter, bearing reference number CB-II/Apptt.Principal/SSC/2026/835 and dated May 14, 2026, was addressed to the Chairman of the Governing Body of St Stephen's College and signed by the University Registrar. It was issued with the approval of the Competent Authority.

The Registrar's letter states clearly, "It appears that the Selection Committee for the appointment of a new principal in the college has not been constituted in accordance with the provisions of UGC Regulations 2018." It further states, "Accordingly, the



recommendations of such a committee cannot be implemented." The university has asked the college to convene a fresh meeting of a properly constituted Selection Committee as per the provisions of UGC Regulations 2018 before proceeding further.

Under UGC Regulations 2018, the Selection Committee for the post of college principal must include, among others, two nominees of the Vice-

Chancellor who are Higher Education experts, three Higher Education experts nominated by the Governing Body from a panel of six experts approved by the university's relevant statutory body, and an academician representing SC/ST/OBC/Minority/Women/Differently-abled categories if any candidate from those categories is an applicant.

The Registrar's letter notes specifically that the university was never approached for the nomination of experts as required under these provisions. For minority educational institutions such as St Stephen's College, the regulations carry additional specific requirements regarding the composition of the panel from which subject experts are nominated, including a preference for persons from minority communities recommended by the Vice-Chancellor.

The development comes just days after St Stephen's College announced Professor Susan Elias as its 14th principal and the first woman to head the institution in its more than 145-year history.

Digital profiling finds structural deficiencies in 359 Govt schools

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Shortage of drinking water taps, lack of dedicated toilets for children with special needs and inadequate classroom facilities, besides structurally unsafe buildings in 359 Government schools, have been identified so far during the Delhi Government's digital profiling exercise, with Education Minister Ashish Sood saying a white paper on school infrastructure will be prepared after completion of the audit.

Sood said the large-scale assessment exercise, launched earlier this year, had brought to light multiple infrastructure-related issues in schools. He said the Government is working to strengthen monitoring and accountability mechanisms to address the shortcomings as the 360-degree digital profiling is providing a com-

prehensive summary of schools, and the structures and amenities they lack.

Describing the exercise as a "first attempt" towards improving school infrastructure management, he said discussions were underway to resolve the issues, and a post-audit white paper will be prepared. The minister said students from these 359 schools have been shifted to temporary campuses as the buildings were considered "dangerous" for running schools.

He said the students will be shifted back once the infrastructure audit and repair works are completed. "It will take around two-and-a-half months to complete the audit of all government schools, after which the required repair works will begin," he added.

One of the schools assessed under the exercise — CM SHRI School at Dariyapur Kalan in north-

west Delhi — showed major deficiencies in basic facilities despite having adequate classroom capacity and sufficient toilet seats overall.

According to an "At a Glance Report" prepared by an audit agency hired by the Delhi education department, the school has 1,194 students and 56 classrooms with a seating capacity of 2,558 — well above the prescribed requirement. The classroom-to-student ratio stood at 1:22 against the norm of 1:40. However, the report found only five drinking water taps against a required 24, with a shortfall of 19 outlets. The school also had 62 urinals against a requirement of 120. Eleven additional dustbins and nine more chalkboards were also needed. The assessment highlighted severe gaps in facilities for Children with Special Needs (CWSN). No dedicated CWSN toilet seats or urinals were



found on the campus, despite prescribed requirements of 30 toilet seats and 60 urinals. Only four CWSN-related facilities were available against the required 30, according to the report.

The infrastructure review further found that out of 13 blocks in the school, six were in good condition, six were partially dilapidated and one

was under construction.

A separate structural safety assessment of the same school found that only four blocks were structurally adequate for continued use, while the remaining blocks were categorised as dilapidated and requiring repair, retrofitting or further evaluation. The report prepared through visual inspection

and non-destructive testing, recommended immediate remedial action for two classroom blocks.

It said the stable blocks showed no major cracks, exposed reinforcement or structural sagging, though dampness and peeling paint were observed in some areas. The structurally safe blocks covered 124 rooms, all of which were found to be in good condition. The report recommended waterproofing treatment, repair of damaged plaster and plumbing leakages and periodic structural inspections every three to five years. A classroom furniture assessment conducted at the school pointed to uneven distribution of basic facilities across classrooms.

The report found that several classrooms lacked essential items such as desks, teachers' chairs and tables, boards and dustbins. Class 1A, with 18 students, reportedly

had no desks, boards, cupboards, teacher chairs or tables, cupboards or display boards. Similarly, different sections of Class 7 had no desks and boards. Several secondary-level classrooms lacked teacher chairs and tables, it read. The school also had limited sports and recreational facilities and only six fire extinguishers across all classrooms, the report noted.

Under the project, all classrooms and school buildings are being digitally documented through 360-degree imaging, drone-based surveys and GIS-based mapping.

According to official documents, the exercise aims to create digital profiles of 1,086 Government schools functioning from 799 premises across Delhi. Official said the collected data would help identify infrastructure gaps, prioritise repairs and support long-term planning.

IN FOCUS



A purple sunbird perches on a royal poinciana flower, commonly called Gulmohar in New Delhi, Thursday

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

At least 111 people were killed and 72 injured after a strong storm and heavy rain pounded several districts of Uttar Pradesh, uprooting trees and damaging houses, an official statement said on Thursday.

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath took cognisance of the loss of lives and damage caused by the unseasonal rain, thunderstorms and lightning on Wednesday and directed officials to ensure relief reaches the affected families within 24 hours.

In a statement, the Relief Commissioner's office said, "Due to bad weather on May 13, including storms, rain, hailstorm and lightning, reports of 111 deaths were received from 26 districts. 72 persons were injured, 170



Injured victims admitted in a hospital after a strong storm and heavy rain caused damage to the pontoon bridge in Bhadohi

PTI

livestock losses and damage to 227 houses have been reported in the state."

It said Adityanath has directed all divisional commissioners and district magistrates to verify the incidents "with full sensitivity" and ensure financial assistance is distributed to affected families within 24 hours while establishing direct communication with them and extend-

ing other necessary help. The commissioner's office said it is continuously monitoring the situation through direct coordination with district officials, and necessary funds are being made available to districts.

According to a list issued by the Prayagraj district administration, till morning, 17 deaths were reported due to the storm and rain. As

reports pour in from other areas, the district administration said that a total of 24 deaths have come to the fore in Wednesday's incidents. In Bhadohi, district administration sources said at least 16 people died in storm-related incidents. Additional District Magistrate Kunwar Virendra Kumar Maurya said trees and electric poles were uprooted in several areas, while many houses were damaged in the storm.

Fatehpur Additional District Magistrate Avinash Tripathi said nine people were killed and 16 were injured in storm-related incidents in the district. "Eight people, including five women, died in Khaga tehsil, while a woman died after a wall of a house collapsed in Sadar tehsil," he said.

In Pratapgarh, four people died in separate incidents of

PUTIN CONDOLES LOSS OF LIVES IN STORM

MOSCOW: Russian President Vladimir Putin on Thursday expressed condolences over the heavy casualties and damage caused by a storm that hit India's Uttar Pradesh. At least 89 people were killed on Wednesday after the strong storm and heavy rain pounded several districts of Uttar Pradesh, uprooting trees and damaging houses. In a message sent to President Droupadi Murmu and Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Putin conveyed sympathy to the families of those killed in the natural disaster and wished speedy recovery to the injured and affected people, the Kremlin said in a



statement. "Please accept my deepest condolences over the heavy loss of life and large-scale destruction caused by the cyclone in Uttar Pradesh," he said.

"Please convey my sympathy and support to the families and friends of the victims, as well as my wishes for a speedy recovery to all those affected by this natural disaster," Putin added.

wall and cemented shed collapses and lightning strikes amid strong winds and rain, officials said. SP Deepak Bhukar said Bhim Yadav (25)

died after he was trapped under the debris of a cemented shed that collapsed in Ojha Ka Purwa village in the Lalganj Kotwali area.

Iran's 'Minab168' message lands in Delhi as BRICS talks begin

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi arrived in New Delhi on Wednesday for the BRICS Foreign Ministers' Meeting aboard an aircraft carrying a symbolic and politically charged message — "Minab168." The inscription, prominently displayed on the fuselage, refers to the 168 schoolchildren Iran claims were killed in a US strike on a school in Minab on February 28, an incident that has become a powerful symbol of the civilian toll of the ongoing conflict in West Asia.

Images released from Tehran showed Araghchi boarding the aircraft marked with the hashtag



"#Minab168," signalling Tehran's intent to keep international attention focused on the humanitarian impact of the conflict even as diplomatic engagement continues through multilateral plat-

forms like BRICS. Araghchi's visit comes at a sensitive moment for the region, with escalating tensions involving Iran, the United States and Israel expected to dominate discus-

sions at the two-day BRICS gathering in New Delhi. The Iranian minister is also expected to hold bilateral talks with Indian External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar, where issues such as regional stability, maritime security, energy supplies and connectivity are likely to feature prominently.

According to Iranian authorities, the Shajareh Tayyebah primary school in Minab, located in Iran's southern Hormozgan province near the strategically important Strait of Hormuz, was struck during the opening day of the US-Israeli military campaign against Iran on February 28. Tehran says the attack killed 168 children

between the ages of 7 and 12, making it one of the deadliest incidents involving civilians in the conflict.

The incident drew international attention after UNICEF described it as a stark reminder of the devastating consequences of war on civilians. The school's proximity to an Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) facility also raised questions over whether the strike was aimed at nearby military infrastructure. Reports later indicated that the Pentagon launched a higher-level investigation into the incident amid concerns that faulty or outdated intelligence may have contributed to the attack.

Supreme Court weighs in on appointment of CEC, EC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday said free and fair elections are a part of the basic structure of the Constitution, and this cannot be ensured unless the Election Commission of India (ECI) is independent and also appears to be independent.

A Bench comprising Justices Dipankar Datta and Satish Chandra Sharma made the observations during the final hearing on a batch of six petitions challenging the constitutional validity of a new law governing the appointment of the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) and the Election Commissioners (EC). The law replaces the Chief Justice of India with a Union Cabinet Minister on the three-member selection committee for CEC and ECs.

The Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023, which came into force on January 2, 2024, mandates that the CEC and the ECs are appointed by the President on the recommendation of a selection committee consisting of the Prime Minister, a Union Cabinet Minister, and the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha.

While hearing the submissions of Attorney General (AG) R Venkataramani



on behalf of the Union Government, Justice Datta said, "It is not sufficient for the Election Commission to be independent; it has to appear to be independent." The AG mounted a robust defence, asserting that Parliament has the absolute right to legislate and is not bound to follow the "stop-gap" arrangement suggested by a five-judge bench in the Anoop Baranwal judgment. The Baranwal judgment was an exercise of Article 142 (discretionary power to do complete justice) and did not constitute a binding law under Article 141 that could override an Act of Parliament. The

Government's counsel said the Bench should not strike down a law based on hypothetical bias.

"We have to eat the pudding to know if it is bad. Unless the ECs demonstrate a lack of independence in their actual functioning, the law cannot be held invalid," Venkataramani said. He cautioned the Bench against "entering the legislative arena" or acting as a "second chamber of Parliament."

Justice Datta said independence of the ECI is a facet of the "basic structure" of the Constitution, as free and fair elec-

tions depend on it. "The level of confidence must be to that degree (that it must appear) as if there had been a third neutral person in the selection committee. Why should it be a minister from the cabinet?" the bench asked.

Referring to the attorney general's submissions on judicial overreach, Justice Datta emphasised the mutual respect between the organs of the State. "Parliament may attribute anything to the judiciary, but we know our <Lakshman Rekha> </>. We will never do that," he said.

"Their (the petitioners') first prayer is against the validity of the law. If that fails, no other prayer survives," the AG submitted. "The question whether the Election Commission is independent cannot be answered in the abstract. It is a question of fact and evidence," he argued, "If the court decides what the best manner to appoint election commissioners is, then the court enters the legislative arena."

As the hearing progressed, the bench discussed the possibility of referring the matter to a larger five-judge constitution bench under Article 145(3), noting that the case involves a "substantial question of law" regarding the interpretation of Articles 14 and 324.

The hearing remained inconclusive and is set to continue.

DELHI SIZZLES HEATWAVE WARNING ISSUED

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi recorded its hottest day of May on Thursday as the maximum temperature climbed to 40.6 degrees Celsius, prompting weather officials to warn of rising heatwave conditions across the national capital in the coming days.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), the temperature was one degree above normal for this time of the year. The city also witnessed intense sunshine and dry winds through the afternoon, making outdoor conditions uncomfortable for residents. The weather department has warned



Pedestrians shield themselves from the heat

PANKAJ KUMAR

that isolated heatwave conditions are likely to develop in parts of Delhi from May 16 onwards. Similar conditions are expected in neighbouring states, including Haryana and Punjab, as temperatures continue to rise across north India. While Thursday's temperature did not officially qualify as a heatwave under IMD criteria, the combination of high daytime temperatures and dry weather led to oppressive conditions in many parts of the city.

The IMD had earlier issued a yellow alert for Delhi-NCR, cautioning residents about changing weather conditions.

Jamia Hamdard signs MoU with NDTL



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Jamia Hamdard has signed a MoU with the National Dope Testing Laboratory (NDTL) to promote collaborative research, training, and human resource development in the specialized and emerging area of doping science.

The MoU aims to strengthen academic-scientific cooperation in areas such as anti-doping research, development of reference materials, advanced analytical methods, gene doping detection approaches, and capacity building to serve national and global needs.

The signing ceremony was hosted by Dr PL Sahu, Director, National Dope Testing Laboratory, along with officials and scientific staff of the laboratory.

The Jamia Hamdard delegation was led by Prof (Dr) M. Afshar Alam, Vice Chancellor, Jamia Hamdard. The signing ceremony was followed by a visit to the NDTL facilities, where the Jamia Hamdard delegation was briefed about

the laboratory's advanced analytical infrastructure and its important role in promoting clean and fair sport. Speaking on the occasion, Sahu said this MoU will open new opportunities for structured training, skill development, and scientific exposure of students and young researchers to the highly specialized field of anti-doping science.

"Jamia Hamdard has a strong academic and research foundation in pharmaceutical sciences, biomedical sciences, toxicology, pharmacology, and allied disciplines. Through this collaboration, Jamia Hamdard will provide access to its research infrastructure, academic expertise, and technical knowledge to support innovative work in doping science.

The MoU will encourage collaborative research in areas such as development of reference materials, gene doping methods, and advanced analytical approaches, while also contributing to the training of skilled human resources," said Prof Alam. T

SIR Phase 3 ordered in 16 States including Delhi

The Governments of West Bengal, Kerala, and Tamil Nadu approached the Supreme Court, challenging aspects of the process. While the revision exercise has now concluded, the matter remains under judicial consideration. Unlike the Bihar SIR, this phase did not require every elector to resubmit documents. The SIR exercise also triggered strong political reactions, particularly from opposition-ruled states.

Requesting all political parties to appoint Booth Level Agents (BLAs) for each polling booth in order to ensure full participation of political parties so that SIR is conducted with complete transparency and full participation of political parties, the ECI said, SIR is a participative exercise involving all stakeholders including electors, political parties and election officials.

During SIR Phase 3, over 3.94 lakh Booth Level Officers (BLOs) will go house-to-house to 36.73 crore electors assisted by 3.42 lakh BLAs appointed by political parties during the Enumeration Phase, the ECI said in a press statement.

Trump, Xi find common ground on Iran

Rubio said Trump and Xi found "common ground" on Iran's nuclear ambitions, with both sides agreeing that Tehran must not acquire nuclear weapons.

Trump has repeatedly maintained that preventing Iran from obtaining a nuclear weapon remains a top foreign policy priority for his administration amid continuing regional tensions. Rubio also defended Trump's recent remarks

dismissing concerns over domestic political pressure linked to rising energy costs during negotiations with Iran. "What the president is making clear is, if the Iranians think they are going to use our domestic politics to pressure him into a bad deal, that's not going to happen," Rubio said.

China has consistently called for a diplomatic resolution to the conflict, which began escalating sharply on February 28.

LeT commander gunned down in Pakistan

He shared the stage with senior LeT Balochistan chief Hafiz Idrees Mughal at what was described as a pro-Pakistan Army programme, underscoring the group's continued public activities in the region despite its designation as a terrorist organisation by several countries, including India and the US.

Raisani was a prominent operative in LeT's Balochistan network, widely regarded as a key architect of the group's recruitment, radicalisation, and terror training infrastructure. He played a central role in identifying and indoctrinating vulnerable youth, channelling them into LeT's militant operations. After the outfit floated a political wing, Raisani was appointed deputy general secretary for the Quetta region, reflecting LeT's strategy of blending armed jihad with political influence.

The killing comes amid growing speculation about internal fractures within militant networks, possible separatist involvement, or covert operations against LeT leadership in Balochistan. The province has witnessed a surge in targeted assassinations, separatist violence, and clashes between security forces and militants. In recent months, several other high-ranking LeT commanders, including Sheikh Yousuf Afridi, Amir Hamza,

and others, have been eliminated in similar unidentified gunman attacks.

LeT, founded by Hafiz Saeed, remains one of the most active Pakistan-based terror groups focused on India. It was responsible for the 2008 Mumbai attacks and continues to operate training and propaganda networks despite international pressure on Pakistan to dismantle such outfits. Analysts view Raisani's elimination as a potential setback to LeT's cadre-building efforts in Balochistan, though the group's deep roots in the region suggest resilience.

PM Modi meets Russian foreign minister

PM Modi also asked Lavrov to convey his warm greetings to President Putin.

Prime Minister Modi also joined visiting ministers and delegates for the official BRICS family photograph, bringing together representatives of member countries and partner nations participating in the high-level summit.

PM Modi on Thursday also met several foreign ministers attending the BRICS Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi, including Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi, South African Foreign Minister Ronald Lamola, and Brazilian Foreign Minister Mauro Vieira on the sidelines of the BRICS Foreign Ministers Meeting.

Delhi pushes Metro, WFH to cut fuel use

Offices will also install sensors and master switches to prevent unnecessary electricity consumption. The chief minister has also cut

down on her convoy by 60 per cent. Her convoy now has only four vehicles, including two EVs. Appealing directly to Delhi residents, the Chief Minister urged citizens to observe one 'No Vehicle Day' every week by voluntarily avoiding the use of private vehicles for a day. She also announced that the Delhi Government will not purchase any new petrol, diesel, CNG or hybrid vehicles for the next six months.

To further encourage the use of public transport among employees, the government has introduced an incentive scheme for Grade-I to Grade-8 staff and officers. Employees, who spend at least 25 per cent of their transport allowance on public transport, including Metro services, will receive an additional 10 per cent transport allowance from the government.

Indian vessel sinks after suspected drone strike...

According to reports, an unidentified explosive object — suspected to be a drone or a missile — struck the ship, causing a massive fire and severe structural damage. The impact destabilised the vessel, which later sank.

The Oman Coast Guard launched an emergency rescue operation and safely evacuated all 14 Indian sailors to Deeba port. As flames spread rapidly across the ship, the crew members acted swiftly, sending out a distress signal before abandoning the vessel in lifeboats.

Authorities have not yet identified who was responsible for the strike, and Omani officials are currently investigating the incident. Several livestock animals being transported on the vessel were reportedly swept away after the ship sank. The Indian Sailing Vessels Association also confirmed the safety of the

crew and stated that their travel and identity documents had been secured. General Secretary Adam Bhaya urged the Indian Government to facilitate the sailors' return home at the earliest and intensify diplomatic efforts to ensure their safe passage.

The sinking of Haji Ali marks the second incident involving a Gujarat-linked vessel within a week. Earlier, another Salaya-registered vessel, Al Faiz Noor Suleimani-1, reportedly sank in the Strait of Hormuz after being caught in crossfire linked to the ongoing regional conflict.

The back-to-back maritime incidents have heightened concerns among ship operators and traders in Gujarat's traditional shipping sector, many of whom depend heavily on Gulf trade routes for cargo transportation.

VD Satheesan appointed Kerala CM

The resolution was moved by KPCC chief Sunny Joseph and seconded by senior party leader Thiruvanchoor Radhakrishnan. Senior Congress leader Ramesh Chennithala was absent from the meeting, but he gave a letter supporting Satheesan.

Former LoP in the State Assembly, Satheesan (61) was a student leader and is an MLA from 2001. He is a lawyer.

A decision on the next CM had been pending since May 4 when the Congress-led UDF bagged 102 seats out of the 140, which is more than a two-thirds majority. The Congress has 63 MLAs in the 140-member Kerala Assembly. Its allies Indian Union Muslim League (IUM) has 22, Kerala Congress (KEC) has eight and the Revolutionary Socialist Party (RSP) three.

CBI arrests 2 more accused in NEET-UG 2026 paper leak case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has arrested two more accused persons in connection with the alleged irregularities in NEET-UG 2026. The arrests come as part of a nationwide probe into the paper leak scandal that led to the cancellation of the medical entrance test. The CBI conducted searches at 14 locations across the country during this period, intensifying its efforts to uncover the full extent of the network behind the leak.

The case was registered by the CBI on May 12, 2026, following a complaint from the Department of Higher Education, Ministry of Education, Government of India. The NEET-UG 2026 exam, held on May 3, 2026, was officially cancelled by the National Testing Agency (NTA) due to credible evidence of a paper leak, affecting lakhs of aspirants aspiring for medical seats. The agency cited the need to preserve the sanctity of the examination process and assured candidates that



fees would be refunded and a re-examination would be conducted.

Earlier, on May 13, the CBI had arrested five accused: three from Jaipur (Mangilal Biwal, Vikas Biwal, and Dinesh Biwal), one from Gurugram (Yash Yadav), and one from Nashik (Shubham Khairnar).

These arrests were made in coordination with state police, and the accused were produced before a Delhi court. In continuation of the operation, the latest arrests include Mr Dhananjay Lokhanda (also referred to as Lokhande in some reports)

from Ahilyanagar (Rahuri area, Maharashtra) and Smt. Manisha Waghmare from Pune. According to reports, Manisha Waghmare is a beautician by profession, while Dhananjay Lokhanda has ties to Ayurveda practitioners who assist students with admissions. Maharashtra Police detained them and handed them over to the CBI. Incriminating material and electronic devices were reportedly seized during raids.

The CBI has stated that several other suspects are under interrogation. The probe is focusing on a multi-

state network allegedly involved in circulating the leaked paper, with students reportedly paying between ₹2 lakh and ₹5 lakh for access. Investigators are examining money trails, technical evidence, and connections between coaching centres and intermediaries.

The CBI has reiterated its commitment to a comprehensive, impartial, and professional investigation, assuring that all leads will be pursued vigorously to ensure justice and restore faith in the examination system. As the probe expands, it raises serious questions about the role of local networks in compromising national-level tests.

The incident has sparked protests by student groups such as ABVP and calls for stricter security protocols for future exams. Parents and aspirants await the re-examination schedule, hoping for a fair and transparent process. The NEET-UG 2026 paper leak case serves as a stark reminder of the need for robust safeguards to protect the future of India's young medical aspirants.

BCI seeks West Bengal Bar Council report on Mamata's practice status after HC appearance

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Hours after former chief minister Mamata Banerjee appeared in advocate robes in the Calcutta High Court, the Bar Council of India on Thursday asked the West Bengal Bar Council to furnish a detailed report within 48 hours regarding her enrolment and professional practice status.

Banerjee, accompanied by senior Trinamool Congress leaders Chandrima Bhattacharya and Kalyan Banerjee, appeared before the High Court to argue a case in connection with alleged post-poll violence and attacks on party offices.

According to prevalent practice, a person, who was holding a constitutional post or gainfully employed, has to get the bar licence suspended during the service and for practising law again, the same has to be revived.

In a letter, the Bar Council of India (BCI) directed the secretary of the West Bengal Bar Council to furnish within two days complete records relating to Banerjee's enrolment as an advocate, if any, and her practice status during



Former West Bengal chief minister and TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee appeared before the Calcutta High Court to argue a case in connection with alleged post-poll violence and attacks on party offices in Kolkata PTI

and after her tenure as chief minister from 2011 to 2026.

The communication, issued by BCI Principal Secretary Sriramanto Sen, stated that the Council had taken note of "various media reports" claiming that Banerjee appeared in court in legal attire, including white advocate bands.

"Mamata Banerjee served as chief minister of West Bengal from 2011 to 2026. Having regard to the constitutional public office held by her during the said period, and without expressing any opinion at this stage on the permissibility or otherwise of such appearance, the Bar

Council of India requires the factual status of her enrolment, practice, suspension, if any, and resumption, if any, to be verified from your records," the communication said. The apex bar body asked the West Bengal Bar Council to furnish Banerjee's enrolment number and the date of her enrolment with the State Bar Council.

"Whether her name presently continues on the State Roll of Advocates maintained by the State Bar Council of West Bengal," the BCI asked. It also asked the state bar body whether Banerjee, at any point during her tenure as the chief minister, "given any

intimation of voluntary suspension / suspension of practice / cessation from practice".

"If any such intimation was given, the date on which it was received by the State Bar Council, along with a copy of the relevant application / intimation and order / noting, if any," it asked.

The BCI has also asked whether any application for resumption of practice was filed subsequently, and whether any valid Certificate of Practice currently exists in her favour.

Additionally, the West Bengal Bar Council has been directed to provide certified copies of all relevant records, including enrolment registers, State roll entries, inward registers, correspondence files, suspension or cessation records, resumption records, and file notings.

The BCI further instructed that all original records connected with the matter be preserved in their present form pending submission of the reply, cautioning against any alteration, overwriting, interpolation or reconstruction except in accordance with law and after due intimation to the Council.

J&K DGP vows decisive war on Pak-sponsored terror and narco-terror

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Director General of Jammu and Kashmir Police (DGP) Nalin Prabhat on Thursday said the force is waging a decisive battle against Pakistan-sponsored terrorism and narco-terrorism. He warned cross-border drug syndicates and their handlers to expect strict action.

Addressing a press conference at PCR Kashmir, the DGP said that "Nasha Mukht Abhiyan" has significantly intensified anti-drug operations across Jammu and Kashmir.

Reading out a detailed note, DGP said J&K Police has shown "consistent performance" in the war against narcotics since 2023, particularly in property attachments, preventive detentions and seizure of contraband substances.

"There has been a sustained increase in attachment of properties linked with narcotics trafficking from 2023 to 2026, J&K Police has been ranked number three nationally during 2025 in this regard," he said.

He said 806 persons involved in the narcotics trade have been arrested in 724 NDPS cases registered across Jammu and Kashmir.

"Among the major arrests was that of Gulzar Ahmad alias Love Gujar, who was wanted in 28 cases and Aneet Singh alias Nagi, who was wanted in 17 cases in Jammu province," he said.

He said 97 properties worth ₹41.85 crore linked with narcotics trafficking have been identified and attached so far.

Sharing further details, DGP said 41 properties worth nearly ₹15 crore identified as proceeds of narcotics trade have also been demolished



Director General of J&K Police (DGP) Nalin Prabhat

after following due legal process. "Illicit poppy and cannabis cultivation spread over 117 kanals of land has been destroyed during the drive". He also said that there has also been focused inspection of pharmaceutical establishments. "At least 5,238 chemists and drug shops were checked while action was initiated against 151 erring establishments. 4,962 kilograms of narcotics and 6,493 units of psychotropic substances were disposed off during the campaign".

He said driving licences of 162 persons involved in narcotics cases were either cancelled or suspended, while registration certificates of 92 vehicles used in drug trafficking were also cancelled or suspended.

Besides, recommendations have been made for impounding 10 passports linked to narcotics-related activities, he added.

The DGP further said that 240 PIT-NDPS detentions were carried out in 2025, for which J&K Police ranked first in the country. "Specifically under the Nasha Mukht Abhiyan, there has been nearly a seven-fold increase in NDPS cases compared to last year," he said.

The DGP said police seized 667 kilograms of narcotics and over 90,000 units of psychotropic substances during the campaign.

PM leading country with firmness, skill through global conflict: Rajnath

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jodhpur

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Thursday said India has displayed remarkable political willpower amid the ongoing global economic and geopolitical challenges by signing trade deals with 38 countries. No force in the world could stop the country from becoming a global superpower by 2047, he claimed.

The minister was addressing a programme in Jodhpur after unveiling a statue of former vice president and former Rajasthan chief minister Bhairon Singh Shekhawat.

Praising Prime Minister Narendra Modi for steering the country through adverse international conditions, he said, "India's political willpower has been demonstrated recently in the matter of trade tariffs. The world is facing crises in West Asia, yet Prime Minister Modi is leading the country forward with firmness and skill in adverse international circumstances."

"I can say with confidence that no other country has achieved what India has. Despite global tensions, India has signed trade agreements with 38 countries. This has become a milestone in the history of trade," he added. Singh claimed that as a result of it, the US had to reduce tariffs. "When adverse situations arise, India emerges stronger. The entire world may be facing difficulties, but India will emerge even more refined from these circumstances," he said.

"By 2047, no power in the world will be able to stop India from becoming a global superpower," the defence minister claimed.

Referring to Modi's recent appeal for moderating fuel use and other specific expenditures, Singh said people were responding positively.

"The prime minister recently told people what they should do—avoid purchasing gold for a year, save fuel and reduce the use of vehicles. We have also done that and reduced our



Union Defence Minister Rajnath Singh and Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajanlal Sharma during a public meeting after unveiling a statue of Rajput ruler Rao Duda at Merta in Nagaur district, Rajasthan PTI

convoy strength by more than 50 per cent," he said. Recalling India's nuclear tests in Rajasthan, Singh said former prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee had shown courage despite international sanctions.

"Five nuclear tests were conducted on the soil of Rajasthan when Atal Bihari Vajpayee was the prime minister and Shekhawat was the chief minister. India emerged as a nuclear power despite global sanctions and challenges," he said. Praising

Shekhawat's contribution to the BJP and Indian politics, Singh said he played a key role in strengthening the party at the grassroots level.

"The greatest credit for taking the BJP to every household can be given to Bhairon Singh Shekhawat. He strengthened the party at the grassroots level, and his image rose above party politics," Singh said.

"He did politics not merely to form Governments, but to build society and the nation," he added. Singh said

India will ensure zero casualty during heat waves: Amit Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday said his ministry has prepared a plan to ensure that no lives are lost in the country during heat waves in the next few years, with the underlying principle of the Modi Government being "proactive" rather than "reactive" towards disasters.

The minister spoke after he presented the President's Colour to the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) at its 8th battalion campus here. The recognition, given in the form of a flag, is awarded to a military or police unit for rendering exceptional service.

The honour was bestowed upon the NDRF in its 20th year



Union Home Minister Amit Shah during President's Colour award ceremony of the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) at the 8th Battalion campus in Ghaziabad PTI

of establishment, after it was raised in 2006 as a federal contingency force to undertake relief and rescue operations during natural and artificial disasters.

The President's Colour is not just an "acknowledgement" for the service of the NDRF. Still, also of all the state disaster response forces, the state machinery down to the level of the panchayats, the NCC (National Cadet Corps), NSS (National Service Scheme), 'Apda Mitras' (civil defence volunteers), among others, Shah said.

The minister said the Modi Government aimed to ensure "zero casualty and minimum property damage" during tragedies and calamities, including cyclones, earthquakes and floods.

The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) is well prepared to combat the "serious challenge" of heat waves in the country, and we will be able to ensure "zero casualty" and no loss of lives over the next few years, Shah said. Every year, numerous people lose their lives in various states due to heat strokes and health conditions emerging due to heat waves.

Our approach and policy have been "proactive" against disasters rather than being just "reactive", he said.

"Under Prime Minister Modi's leadership, we are in a situation where we can move towards the aim of zero casualty," he said. The minister said that before the Modi Government took charge in 2014, the approach to disasters

was rehabilitation- and relief-oriented. "Earlier, the approach was that disasters struck, those who survived were rescued, relief was sent, and the job was done. Modi brought a different approach; he incorporated the concept of safety to ensure and minimise loss of life and property," he said.

We have successfully travelled the course from ensuring a minimum of casualties to zero casualties, Shah said.

Shah said India has made its name as an "undisputed global leader" in disaster management and being the "first responder" during calamities. He stressed that the role of NDRF will be "vital" as disaster incidents rise due to global warming and climate change.

AIADMK tussle: Rebel group wants Palaniswami to be disqualified as MLA; EPS says slander being spread against him

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

The rift in the AIADMK widened further on Thursday, with the faction opposed to party chief Edappadi K Palaniswami accusing him and his supporting MLAs of "defying" its "whip" regarding the floor test of the TVK Government, and sought their disqualification under the anti-defection law.

Hitting back at his rivals, Palaniswami, addressed as EPS, alleged the they were behind minister posts and were spreading slander against him.

"They have fallen for the lure of six minister posts and 10 board chiefs," he claimed in a statement here.

"It is very painful that those who have betrayed the party

are spreading slanderous propaganda about me", he claimed.

His rival faction, led by senior leaders and former ministers C Ve Shanmugam and SP Velumani, claimed they had the majority of the 47 MLAs the party has.

CVijaybaskar, appointed as the "whip" of the faction, told reporters that the legislature party is decided based on majority numbers and indicated that his faction enjoyed that.

His instruction to vote in favour of the C Joseph Vijayleed TVK Government during its confidence vote on Wednesday was duly communicated to all the AIADMK MLAs through Whatsapp and e-mail, he said.

"Of the 47 MLAs, 25 abided by the instruction. As many as



Edappadi K Palaniswami

22 party MLAs, including Edappadi Palaniswami, did not comply with the directives issued by me, who is the whip, and went contrary to that. So we have met the Assembly Speaker today and sought their (pro-Palaniswami MLAs) disqualification under the anti-defec-

tion law," he said.

"Majority of MLAs under S P Velumani followed the whip order. So only majority is valid," he said.

Velumani, citing precedents, said that when a split emerges in a party due to difference of opinion, no decisions can be taken; neither

can someone be appointed or removed from the party posts or the organisation.

"We are clear—(Palaniswami should) convene party General Council to discuss the reasons for the poll defeat. He is the general secretary," Velumani said.

Further, hitting out at the party chief, he said his actions pertaining to sacking functionaries from party posts and and making new appointments were "not valid." "Our intent is to strengthen the party. Bring back those who had gone, who had been sacked from party. Why did MGR start the party — to oppose DMK," he said.

Palaniswami's decisions regarding removing people from their party positions are

not valid and "they continue in their posts," he added. The AIADMK chief had removed from party posts, Shanmugam, Velumani and others in the wake of the rift and cross-voting in the TVK Government's confidence vote on Wednesday that ruling party won comfortably.

Meanwhile, Palaniswami met with senior leaders to discuss their next steps after growing differences within the party led to cross-voting. Later in the day, in a statement he hit out at his rival camp.

People of the state voted for the AIADMK to form Government, he claimed. But, a few party MLAs have voted in favour of the ruling Government's no confidence motion against the "official"

order of the whip. "This act is a great betrayal to the party", he said. Amid the simmering tensions in the AIADMK, the party headquarters, Puratchi Thalavar MGR Maaligai, came under a heavy police security cover, apparently in anticipation of trouble. Violence had broken out and the AIADMK headquarters was targeted and damaged during the heightened differences between Palaniswami and then party leader O Panneerselvam over a leadership struggle in 2022.

Speaking to the mediapersons, Shanmugam asserted that his supporting MLAs or senior leaders will not visit AIADMK headquarters unless his group gets justice. "In any situation, I will not come to the head office", he said, adding, "we will also ensure

that there will not be any clash between the two groups". Palaniswami also chaired a meeting with his supporting MLAs at his residence here to counter the rebel group. Large number of AIADMK cadres thronged Palaniswami's residence with bouquets to extend their support. Newly appointed office-bearers also called on him.

Meanwhile, Palaniswami's supporter and MLA Agri SS Krishnamurthy and legislator Thalavai N Sundaram met the assembly speaker JCD Prabhakar seeking action on their complaint seeking disqualification of the rebel MLAs since they did not vote against the Government in the floor test on Wednesday in lines with the party directive.

States Focus



2 HELD FOR OFFENSIVE VIDEO TARGETING CM SUVENDU

Two online content creators were arrested from Dinhat in West Bengal's Cooch Behar district for allegedly posting an offensive video targeting Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, a senior police officer said on Thursday. The duo was apprehended on Wednesday following complaints that the viral video "contained derogatory and offensive language against the CM", he said. The Dinhat police launched an investigation, leading to their arrest from Dinhat area, the officer said. Preliminary investigation suggests that the accused are active content creators on social media, and had posted the controversial video on their platform, he said. "Based on the complaints and initial verification, they were detained and subsequently arrested. Investigation is underway," the officer said. Meanwhile, the West Bengal Police in a statement said: "No individual is permitted to upload or circulate content that contains abusive language against any person or that may hurt religious or social sentiments. Strict legal action will be taken against those found violating these norms." (PTI)



KARNATAKA GOVERNOR CUTS CONVOY ON PM'S CALL

Karnataka Governor Thawarchand Gehlot on Thursday reduced the size of his official convoy to the minimum required strength following Prime Minister Narendra Modi's austerity call. In a post on social media, the Lok Bhavan said Gehlot had taken the step in response to the Prime Minister's appeal for fuel conservation and reduction in foreign exchange expenditure amid the West Asia crisis. "Hon'ble Governor of Karnataka Shri Thawarchand Gehlot has reduced his convoy to the minimum required strength, following Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi Ji's appeal," the post said. The move comes days after Modi, while addressing a rally organised by the BJP in Hyderabad, called for several measures aimed at conserving foreign exchange and reducing dependence on imports amid tensions in West Asia. (PTI)

Maharashtra bars foreign tours, bike rallies in austerity drive



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Maharashtra government has announced austerity measures, including the cancellation of foreign tours by officials and promoting public transport and electric vehicles, in response to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal amid the West Asia crisis. The state has directed the police not to grant permissions for bike rallies, vehicle processions or large motorcades.

In a circular issued on May 13, Chief Secretary Rajesh Kumar directed all departments, divisional commissioners, district collectors and municipal commissioners to implement the measures for reducing fuel consumption, conserving foreign exchange and cutting avoidable expenditure.

The circular said all approved foreign study and official tours of government officers should be cancelled, and no new overseas visits should be planned for the time being.

Fadnavis rides bike to house, defends PM's austerity call

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis on Thursday rode a motorcycle to the Vidhan Bhavan here and later defended the Centre's austerity measures, saying Prime Minister Narendra Modi has only "asked people to make small sacrifices".

He also criticised the Opposition for creating "unnecessary controversy" over the matter, adding that questioning the PM's foreign visits - aimed at strategic alliances and economic benefits - was "sheer foolishness". Fadnavis arrived at the Vidhan Bhavan in South



Mumbai on a motorbike from his residence 'Varsha', with BJP leader and minister Ashish Shelar accompanying him, to attend the swearing-in of new members of the legislative council.

The move comes as part of the measures after PM Modi's appeal to conserve

national cooperation, public awareness, knowledge-sharing, capacity building, and best conservation practices," he said.

In the future, the IBCA will prove to be a pivotal milestone in strengthening global capabilities and advancing Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision, he said.

"The most effective way to maintain coexistence with nature is to ensure the conservation and preservation of apex predators," Yadav said.

"We aim to establish a model of nature conservation where both ecology and economy can thrive in tandem. Today, the greatest threat posed by climate change globally is the disruption of our ecological balance with nature," he said.

Nature protects those who protect nature. To foster this coexistence with nature, PM Modi has introduced a major climate action initiative in the form of the IBCA. Over the



past decade, the PM has championed numerous climate action programmes on the global stage, he said.

Yadav said that Gujarat is already home to lions, leopards, and now, tigers have also made their presence felt.

Initiatives are also being taken for the conservation of critically-endangered Great Indian

conflict in West Asia, which has disrupted global energy supplies. India relies heavily on West Asia for crude oil and gas imports.

PM Modi has significantly reduced his convoy size, days after he appealed for cutting down fuel consumption and spending more wisely, prompting several BJP chief ministers and other leaders to adopt similar measures.

The prime minister's appeal is not about spending less but spending more wisely by reducing fuel consumption, avoidable dependence on imported goods and foreign-currency-intensive services, official sources said on Wednesday, stressing that the Modi government is not cutting capital expenditure, welfare spending or subsidies.

Goa CM halves convoy after PM's appeal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Panaji

Goa Chief Minister Pramod Sawant has halved his convoy, following Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal for cutting down fuel consumption and spending more wisely in view of the West Asia crisis, officials said on Thursday.

The CM's convoy, which earlier had six vehicles, has now been reduced to three, including the car in which he travels, an official from the Chief Minister's Office said.

"Following the austerity measures adopted by the PM, the chief minister has asked for the reduction of the vehicles (in his convoy)," the official added.



The move comes in response to PM Modi's appeal to conserve fuel and foreign exchange in view of the ongoing

ATS operation targets network of Shahzad Bhatti across Maharashtra

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Mumbai

In a major counter-terrorism and organised crime operation, the Maharashtra Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS) on Wednesday carried out coordinated raids at more than 40 locations across the State, targeting individuals suspected of being in contact with Pakistan-based gangster Shahzad Bhatti and his syndicate. At least 53 persons were being questioned as part of the probe, officials confirmed.

The Maharashtra raids come days after the Delhi Police Special Cell's high-impact "Gang Bust Operation 2.0", a 48-

hour pan-India drive across Delhi, Haryana, Punjab, Rajasthan, and Uttar Pradesh that led to the arrest of 482 alleged gangsters and associates. Crucially, nine operatives linked to the Shahzad Bhatti module were among those arrested. Interrogation of these operatives had revealed that Pakistan's ISI had allegedly planned coordinated attacks through the Bhatti network on a historic temple in Delhi, a popular dhaba on the Delhi-Sonapat highway and a military camp in Haryana.

The module was also tasked with random firing incidents targeting security personnel in the Delhi-NCR and northern

India, alongside arms trafficking. Earlier, in April 2026, Delhi Police arrested two fresh recruits, Rajveer (21) and Vivek Banjara (19) from Gwalior, Madhya Pradesh, with no prior criminal record, who were allegedly preparing attacks on a prominent hotel in the NCR on Bhatti's directions.

The raids by Maharashtra ATS teams, which began in the early hours on Wednesday, spanned key areas including Mumbai, Akola, Nanded, Pune, Mira Road (Thane district), Nallasopara (Palghar district), Nashik, Jalgaon, Nagpur, and several other districts. ATS teams acted on specific intelligence about suspicious activ-



ities, including alleged links via social media and encrypted communication platforms to Bhatti's network, which is accused of radicalising and recruiting Indian youth for anti-national activities, arms trafficking, and potential terror support.

West Bengal Govt makes Vande Mataram mandatory in schools

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The West Bengal Government has directed all State-run and aided schools to mandatorily include the singing of Vande Mataram during morning assemblies with immediate effect, according to an official communication issued by the School Education department.

The directive states that every student must participate in singing the national song at the start of the



school day. "From next Monday, Vande Mataram will be introduced as the prayer song in all schools across the State. I will go to Nabanna today and inform them," West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari told reporters at the Assembly.

Sikkim CM cuts motorcade by 50 per cent

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gangtok

Sikkim Chief Minister Prem Singh Tamang on Thursday announced cutting the number of vehicles in his motorcade by 50 per cent following Prime Minister Narendra Modi's call to curb the use of petrol and diesel.

In a social media post, he said the other austerity measures include withdrawal of pilot vehicles assigned to the Assembly speaker and deputy speaker, a 20 per cent cut in fuel consumption in vehicles allotted to ministers and MLAs, and pooled vehicle services in government departments.

"In compliance with the appeal made by Prime Minister Narendra Modi for



adopting austerity measures, and to demonstrate our commitment towards the national service and responsible governance, I have decided to reduce the number of vehicles in my official carcade by 50 per

cent. It will significantly contribute towards fuel conservation," Tamang said.

The chief minister also shared that he has urged all district collectors and superintendents of police not to undertake protocol duties

during his inter-district tours.

He said the decision on austerity measures was taken at an emergency meeting with Cabinet ministers, legislators, the chief secretary, the state police chief, heads of departments, district collectors, and superintendents of police on Thursday.

After detailed deliberations, several temporary measures have been adopted in the larger interest of fuel conservation, administrative efficiency, and national responsibility, the chief minister said. Among other measures, public servants have been urged to use public transportation and rely on virtual meetings and digital communication.

Telangana Governor urges CM to follow austerity call

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

Telangana Governor Shiv Pratap Shukla on Thursday announced reducing his convoy's vehicle count by half following Prime Minister Narendra Modi's austerity call. He said he would urge the Chief Minister to direct his cabinet colleagues and officials to ensure that the "PM's call is fully followed in the state". "It is his appeal to the CM," he said.

Shukla pointed out that PM Modi has led by example, by downsizing his own motorcade. He further said that he had already reduced the number of vehicles in his convoy after assuming office in Telangana. "Still, I have

decided that Lok Bhavan will cut its vehicle strength by 50 per cent," he told reporters.

The Governor appealed to all political leaders in the state to reduce the number of avoidable vehicles in their convoys. "My appeal to people of political parties is to reduce the avoidable vehicles under any circumstance. They should move before people do. Similar to what the Prime Minister, Union Home Minister and Defence Minister did," he said. These measures would send a message to raise people's awareness on the PM's austerity call and help in saving foreign exchange, he said.

Advocating for the adoption of EVs as an "eco-friend-



ly measure", he said he would discuss it with the Chief Minister.

On the promotion of EVs, the governor said the government is already working on it. Recalling a successful campaign against drug abuse during his tenure as Governor of Himachal Pradesh, Shukla said it reached most villages,

and Panchayats pledged to act against substance abuse.

He said he has appealed to the Chief Minister (A Revanth Reddy) to adopt similar measures and expressed satisfaction with the CM's assurance on his call.

Shukla further proposed that students, during admissions into colleges and universities, should be required to submit a declaration against substance abuse.

"This would send a big message to people through the students. The Prime Minister is conducting a 'Nasha Mukh Bharat Abhiyan' (campaign for drug free India). We should conduct a 'Nasha Mukh Telangana' (drug-free Telangana) campaign," he said.

West Bengal Governor urges citizens to save fuel, use public transport

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Governor RN Ravi on Thursday urged people of the state to join Prime Minister Narendra Modi in the collective endeavour to strengthen the country through "responsible choices" like conserving fuel, using public transport and moderating edible oil consumption.

Emphasising that the Centre is trying to shield people from the adverse impact of the conflict in West Asia, Modi had on May 10 called for judicious use of fuel, postponement of gold purchases and foreign travel,



among other measures, to strengthen the economy.

The Governor also appealed to institutions, industries and workplaces to "encourage virtual meetings and work-from-home practices" wherever feasible, contributing to national resource conservation. In a

statement released by the Lok Bhavan, Ravi said, "I urge the sisters and brothers of West Bengal to join Prime Minister Shri @Narendra Modi in this collective national endeavour to strengthen Bharat through responsible choices, active public participation and a spirit of self-reliance.

By conserving fuel, using public transport and carpooling, supporting 'Vocal for Local', promoting domestic tourism, using our resources responsibly, moderating edible oil consumption, reducing avoidable imports, making purchases such as gold judiciously, and encouraging natural farming,



Remote-controlled Govt: BJP slams Congress over Kerala CM pick

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Thursday took a dig at the Congress, saying that its decision to appoint VD Satheesan as the next Kerala chief minister exposes “infighting” within the party and shows that it would be a “remote-controlled Government”.

The BJP asserted that the chief ministerial pick was not the choice of Congress MLAs but of its ally, the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML), which is the second-largest constituent of the coalition United Democratic Front (UDF).

The Congress on Thursday named Satheesan as the next Kerala chief minister, ending days of suspense and speculation. The decision was announced at a press confer-

ence here by AICC Kerala in-charge Deepa Dasmunshi and the party’s central observers for the state, Ajay Maken and Mukul Wasnik.

The three main contenders for the post were Satheesan, KC Venugopal and Ramesh Chennithala.

In a social media post, BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla said the decision was imposed on the state unit by the Congress’s central leadership.

“It is clear that Kerala’s chief ministerial face was decided in New Delhi and not in Kerala. The announcement was made from the AICC headquarters in Delhi, which shows that this will be a remote-controlled ‘sarkar’ (Government),” he said.

The BJP leader also claimed that there was disagreement



within the Gandhi family over the leadership choice in Kerala.

He alleged that Satheesan was selected due to “pressure from Priyanka Gandhi” who

“did not want Rahul Gandhi’s candidate K C Venugopal at any cost”.

“Priyanka Vadra was dead against Rahul Gandhi’s pick, K C Venugopal. In fact, there



was a huge family fight over who would call the shots in Kerala,” he claimed.

Poonawalla also blamed internal differences and pressure from alliance partners

for the Congress’s delay in announcing the new Kerala chief minister.

“After 11 days, the Congress party from Delhi has finally announced the name of V D Satheesan ji as the next Kerala chief minister. This has been done under two pressures. The Jamaat and the IUML had read the riot act to Congress. So, this is the clear influence of the Muslim vote bank,” he alleged.

Drawing parallels with the Congress Government in Karnataka, the BJP spokesperson alleged that factional rivalry will continue to trouble the party in Kerala as well.

“It will be the same model as the Karnataka Congress sarkar. There it was DK Shivakumar versus Siddaramaiah. Here it will be Satheesan versus KC

Venugopal versus Chennithala versus Shashi Tharoor. There will be four to five claimants, who will constantly rock the boat,” he claimed.

He said similar internal conflicts had affected Congress Governments in states such as Himachal Pradesh, Punjab and Rajasthan.

“So, again, Kerala people will be bracing themselves for instability,” he said.

A decision on the next Kerala chief minister face had been pending since May 4 when the Congress-led UDF bagged 102 seats out of the 140, which was more than a two-thirds majority.

Asserting that decision-making in the Congress requires the approval of the IUML and allied religious groups, BJP national spokesperson Pradeep Bhandari said in a post, “It is

clearly evident that the new Congress chief ministerial pick from Kerala was not the choice of the Congress MLAs but of the IUML.”

Terming the Congress the “new Muslim League”, Bhandari said the Gandhi-Vadra family has once again shown that it listened to the dictates of the IUML.

“The remote control of the Congress and the Gandhi-Vadra family is with the IUML. The Congress today is nothing short of a modern-day Muslim League. The Congress is the Muslim League-Maoist Congress,” he alleged.

The Congress has 63 MLAs in the 140-member Kerala Assembly. Among its allies, IUML has 22 seats, Kerala Congress (KEC) has eight, and the Revolutionary Socialist Party has three MLAs.

FORDA writes to PM Modi, demands action in NEET-UG leak and CBT format

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Federation of Resident Doctors’ Association (FORDA) has written to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, demanding strict action against those involved in the alleged NEET-UG 2026 paper leak and seeking a shift to a computer-based format for the medical entrance test.

The NEET-UG examination was conducted on May 3, following which allegations of a paper leak surfaced, triggering investigations by Rajasthan Police’s Special Operations Group (SOG).

The National Testing Agency (NTA) on Tuesday cancelled the examination and said it would be re-conducted on dates to be announced separately.



In a statement, the NTA said the decision was taken with the approval of the Centre in the interest of maintaining transparency and preserving trust in the national examination system.

In a letter to the prime minister dated May 13, the FORDA described the alleged paper leak as a “moral and institutional catastrophe” that had impacted nearly 23 lakh medical aspirants and their families.

First made-in-India C-295 aircraft rolled out from Vadodara Tata-Airbus facility

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Vadodara

India has achieved a major milestone in its defence manufacturing journey as the first domestically produced C-295 military transport aircraft has been assembled at the Tata-Airbus facility in Vadodara, Gujarat.

The development marks the first time a private sector company in India has manufactured a complete military aircraft within the country.

The aircraft has been produced at the Tata-Airbus Final Assembly Line (FAL) located in Harni, Vadodara, established under a joint venture between Tata Advanced Systems Limited and Airbus. The plant was inaugurated on October 28,



2024, by Narendra Modi and Pedro Sánchez.

According to information related to the project, India has signed an agreement for 56 C-295 transport aircraft. Of these, 16 aircraft are being supplied directly from Spain in fly-away condition, while the remaining 40 are planned to be manufactured in India under the “Make in India” initiative at the

Vadodara facility.

The Harni-based plant has been developed as a comprehensive aerospace manufacturing centre, handling aircraft assembly, testing, maintenance, repair and overhaul (MRO) operations. Officials view the rollout of the first aircraft as a significant boost to India’s efforts toward self-reliance in defence production.

Pawan Khera appears before Assam Police for second day

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Congress leader Pawan Khera appeared before Crime Branch on Thursday for the second consecutive day in connection with the cases filed by Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma’s wife, Riniki Bhuyan Sharma. The cases were lodged after Khera alleged that Riniki possessed multiple passports and undisclosed properties abroad.

Police questioned Khera for over 10 hours on Wednesday. “They asked me questions, and I answered. That’s how it has been going. They have called me again on the 25th. I will come and fully cooperate, just as every responsible citizen should, said Khera to reporters after coming out around six pm.



Congress leader Pawan Khera appears before the Assam Crime Branch in connection with the defamation case filed by Riniki Bhuyan Sharma, wife of Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma in Guwahati on Thursday

PTI

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma had said on Wednesday that the law

will take its own course, but “we have already received in writing from the Union government that the documents Khera displayed were fake.” Police investigations, therefore, will not take long, and they will be able to submit the chargesheet within the stipulated time, the CM said.

Sarma’s wife had filed criminal complaints against Khera and others at the Guwahati Crime Branch Police Station under various provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). The charges against the Congress leader include making false statements in connection with an election, cheating, forgery, use of forged documents as genuine, intentional insult with intent to provoke breach of peace, and defamation.

Probe ordered after two Govt quarters allegedly disappear in Gujarat village

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Himmatnagar

A controversy has surfaced in Jadar village of Gujarat’s Sabarkantha district after two Government residential quarters reportedly vanished from their original location, prompting authorities to order an official inquiry into the matter.

The missing quarters, reportedly meant for an extension officer and a gram sevak, became the centre of public attention after a video related to the issue circulated widely on social media. The incident has triggered questions over the disappearance of the Government properties and possible irregularities linked to the case.

The matter pertains to Jadar village in Idar taluka, where residents claim that



the structures no longer exist at the site and the land has been left vacant. Following written representations regarding the issue, the Taluka Development Officer has directed a detailed investigation.

Officials have reportedly instructed that an inquiry report be submitted within seven days following communication from the Prant Officer. The investigation is expected to determine

how the quarters were removed and whether any rules or procedures were violated.

Amid growing public discussion, the Jadar Gram Panchayat has clarified that the quarters were not under the control of the panchayat and denied any involvement in demolishing the structures.

Local discussions suggest that the quarters may have been demolished using heavy machinery and that debris was later cleared from the site. However, authorities are yet to officially confirm these claims.

The Taluka Development Officer has ordered strict action against anyone found responsible for damage to Government property. Further legal steps are expected after the submission of the inquiry report.

WB Police raid TMC MLA Dilip Mondal’s homes over threat video

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Police on Thursday launched search operations at two houses of TMC MLA Dilip Mondal in West Bengal for making “provocative remarks and issuing threats” to BJP workers in a purported video, a senior officer said.

Personnel from the Diamond Harbour Police District, accompanied by central forces, reached the Bishnupur legislator’s residence at Pailan area in South 24 Parganas district in the morning, he said.

“Searches are being carried out as part of an ongoing investigation based on specific allegations mentioned in FIRs. All necessary steps are being taken in accordance with the law,” the police officer told PTI. In the now-viral videos,



Mondal is seen making threatening remarks against BJP workers during a public rally. PTI could not independently verify the authenticity of the videos.

Two FIRs have been registered against the Bishnupur MLA under non-bailable sections, the officer said.

Mondal was not present at his “sprawling” Pailan residence when the police team arrived, he said. He was, however, reportedly seen

in the locality earlier in the morning, the officer said.

“Two mobile phones belonging to the legislator were found at one of his two houses and are being examined as part of the investigation,” he said.

The search operation is still underway.

Mondal had won the Bishnupur assembly constituency, defeating BJP’s Abhijit Sardar by a margin of 36,925 votes.

Andhra moots no-vehicle day, WFH over West Asia impact

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

No vehicle day, online classes, downsizing convoys, reducing special flights and foreign tours, and deferring gold purchases are some of the measures recommended by the Andhra Pradesh cabinet on Thursday to ward off the economic headwinds emanating from the Gulf war.

Work from home, using public transport, virtual



meetings and monitoring fuel consumption were the other recommendations.

Addressing a press conference at the secretariat, Information & Public Relations (I&PR) Minister K Parthasarathy said Chief

Minister N Chandrababu Naidu gave a call to people to adopt “My Country, My Responsibility” philosophy for the benefit of the country during this critical time triggered by the US — Israel and Iran war.

“Keeping in mind the current geo-political circumstances...and particularly the pressure on our country’s energy needs, forex and the exports of farmers produce, every person with the philosophy of My Country, My

Responsibility should take some actions for the benefit of the country,” he said, detailing Naidu’s deliberations and guidelines in the cabinet.

The cabinet recommendation comes in the wake of Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s appeal to citizens to spend wisely, deferring gold purchases and foreign travel for some time and cutting down on the use of petrol-diesel to soften the pressure on the country’s forex reserves.

Opposition politicising NEET-UG row, leak accused would not be spared: NDA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

NDA leaders in Bihar on Thursday said opposition parties are politicising the cancellation of the NEET undergraduate examination and trying to “mislead” students. They said strict action would be taken against the accused involved in the NEET paper leak, and no one will be spared.

The NEET (UG) 2026 exam held on May 3 was cancelled on Tuesday amid allegations of paper leak, with the CBI registering an FIR after the Government asked it to carry out a comprehensive inquiry into the “irregularities”.

Talking to reporters here, JD (U) Bihar unit president Umesh Singh Kushwaha said, “The authorities concerned have already initiated action against those who indulged in the NEET-UG paper leak case. Strict action will be taken against the accused... no one will be spared. Opposition members are simply politicising the



matter and trying to mislead students.”

Kushwaha also praised the austerity measures recently announced by Prime Minister Narendra Modi to meet the challenge of disruptions to fuel and other supplies caused by the West Asia conflict.

“Following the PM’s recent appeal to embrace fuel conservation, state Governments, including Bihar, have started taking significant steps in that direction. The decision has been taken in the interest of the country,” he said.

Echoing a similar view, BJP national spokesperson, Guru Prakash Paswan, said, “Several state Governments took a broad set of measures as part of the austerity drive following the PM’s appeal.

India had superior situational awareness in Operation Sindoor: CDS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Indian armed forces had superior situational awareness and better battlefield transparency during Operation Sindoor, and “dominated the escalation matrix on all four days” of the conflict, Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) General Anil Chauhan said on Thursday.

His remarks, made during an interactive session at the “Kalam and Kavach” defence conclave at the Manekshaw Centre here,

came days after the country and the armed forces marked the first anniversary of the military action.

“We dominated the escalation matrix on all four days, because we had a superior situational awareness. We knew what we had hit, what was happening,” he said in response to a query during the event.

The CDS asserted that Indian forces had situational awareness not only on their own side but also across the border, and that “we were able to dominate



Chief of Defence Staff General Anil Chauhan speaks during the Kalam & Kavach 3.0 defence dialogue in New Delhi on Thursday

PTI

every ladder of escalation”. Asked how he foresaw future battlefields, given the evolving nature of warfare,

dominated by drones and advanced weapons, he warned against getting drawn into prolonged conflicts.

“We should not fall into this trap of long-duration warfare. There is an increased propensity among nations to use force now. But, after you use force to walk out of that... that is a major challenge,” the CDS said.

“Your objectives should be very clear, your politico-military objectives. Once you achieve them, there is no point lingering on. You should have a clearly earmarked exit strategy,” the CDS said.

Operation Sindoor was launched early on May 7 last year to avenge the deadly

Pahalgam terror attack, with Indian forces conducting precision strikes on multiple terror infrastructure in Pakistan and Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK).

Pakistan later also launched offensives against India, and all subsequent counter-offensives by India were also carried out under Operation Sindoor.

The military conflict between the two nuclear-armed neighbours, lasting nearly 88 hours, halted after they reached an understanding on the evening of May 10.



Editor's
TAKE

NEET paper leak: Playing with students' futures

The anger among Gen Z aspirants is not just about a leaked paper; it is about a betrayal by institutions that promised fairness, merit and equal opportunity

The country's Gen Z is outraged. The NEET paper leak has once again shocked the nation. This is not the first time that an examination promising admission to medical colleges has been compromised. A similar incident occurred in 2024, and now again in 2026, which speaks volumes about the audacity of those involved in the leak. The government took the right decision to scrap NEET UG 2026, but that does not redeem the situation, as it has erased the hard work of millions of students who sacrificed everything for this examination.

It is merely damage control for a situation that should never have arisen in the first place. NEET is an important examination that carries the hopes and aspirations of the middle class and also provides the nation with the qualified pool of doctors it urgently needs. Parents spend lakhs on coaching and even relocate to help their children prepare for the exam. When a leak destroys those hopes, lives are shattered, leaving families in uncertainty and despair. The emotional trauma is enormous, with students burdened by the prospect of preparing all over again and potentially losing an entire year. Witnessing the same scandal repeat itself has deepened frustration and cynicism. The larger question is unavoidable: why does this keep happening? India has witnessed paper leaks in recruitment tests, state board examinations, police recruitment exams and now repeatedly in national-level entrance examinations. The problem is systemic.

Examination mafias have evolved into organised criminal networks with political links, local protectors and insiders within institutions. Using sophisticated digital techniques, they earn crores of rupees. Yet investigations often end with the arrest of minor intermediaries while the masterminds remain untouched. This culture of impunity is even more worrying. While governments routinely promise "zero tolerance", public confidence is steadily declining because accountability is rarely fixed. Merely making arrests is no solution; the entire ecosystem enabling such leaks must be dismantled. That means identifying officials who failed in supervision, exposing coaching-centre nexuses, tracking money trails and ensuring swift convictions of the real culprits. Unless the kingpins are punished, paper leaks will continue to reappear in new forms.

The outrage among Gen Z is therefore understandable. Today's students are digitally connected, politically aware and far less willing to quietly accept institutional incompetence. Social media has amplified their anger because many believe the system is rigged against sincere candidates. India cannot aspire to become a 'Vishwa Guru' and a global knowledge powerhouse while its examination system repeatedly collapses.

Competitive examinations are meant to be the great equaliser in a deeply unequal society. When they lose credibility, social trust itself begins to erode. India urgently needs a complete overhaul of examination security – stronger digital safeguards, encrypted paper distribution, tighter monitoring and a phased transition towards secure computer-based testing. More importantly, the government must instil confidence among young people that it is committed to protecting their interests.

Regional titans fall as BJP rises

The 2026 Assembly elections have triggered one of the most dramatic political realignments in recent Indian history, toppling powerful regional leaders and reshaping the balance of power across the country



KALYANI SHANKAR

In the recently concluded 2026 Assembly elections, three prominent chief ministers faced unexpected defeats, a situation that many in the political arena recognise as a challenging part of the process. The chief ministers of West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, and Kerala lost their elections.

In the recent 2026 Assembly elections, three well-known chief ministers lost unexpectedly. This includes the chief ministers of West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, and Kerala. Winning and losing elections are common in politics. Still, recent results-like the defeats of Arvind Kejriwal and Uddhav Thackeray- highlight significant political shifts that impact regional and national power dynamics, helping readers understand the broader implications.

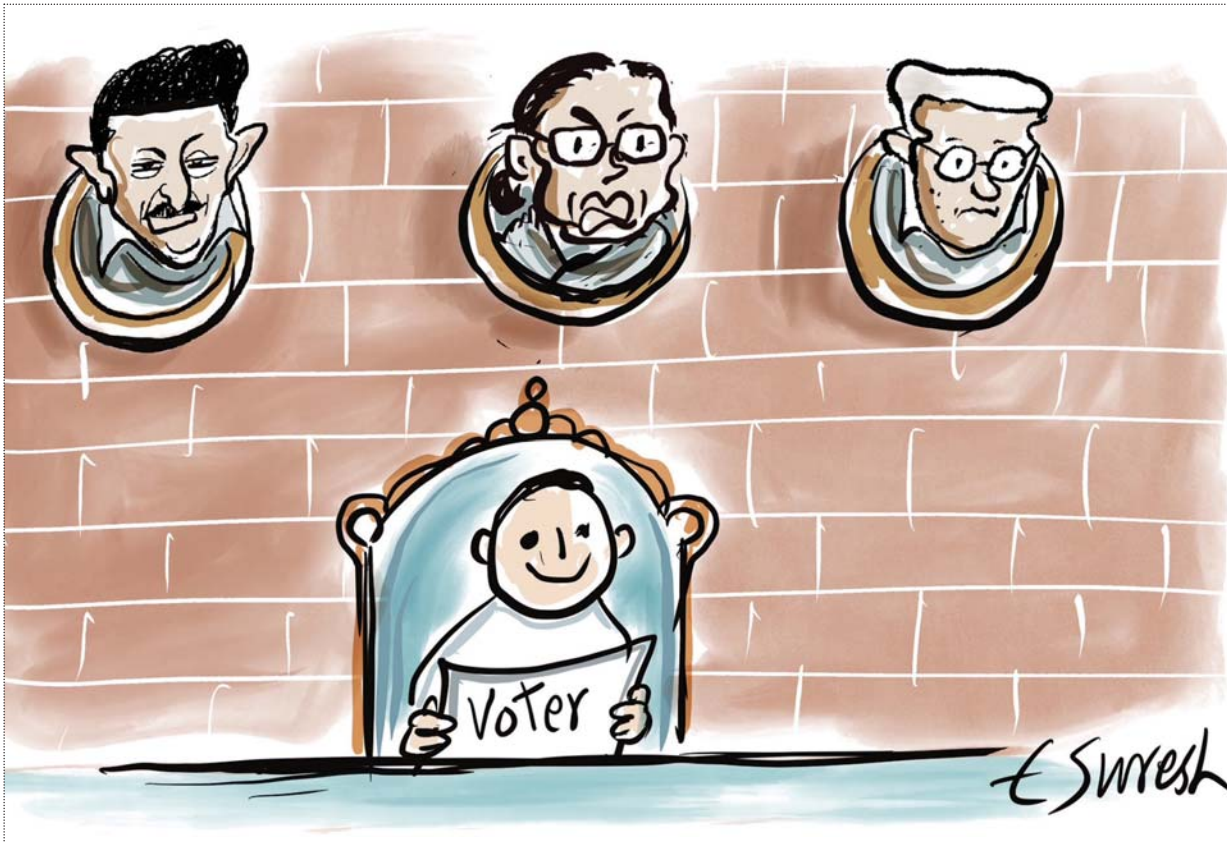
The BJP's victories in West Bengal and Assam mark a major expansion, signalling a growing central influence that challenges regional parties and reshapes the overall power balance in Indian politics, which is crucial for understanding current trends. Changes can be tough for regional parties, which play an important role in our democracy. Recognising their supporters' feelings fosters empathy and understanding during this transition.

The political situation in Tamil Nadu is getting more intense as parties work behind the scenes. The Tamil Valour Katchi (TVK) has won 108 seats but needs 118 to secure a majority. They have the support of Congress, CPI, CPI(M), and VCK, suggesting that Vijay should lead the government. However, the TVK still lacks enough seats to govern on its own. After four days of meeting the governor, Vijay was sworn in on Sunday. While some regional parties are declining, the rise of Vijay's TVK brings a new perspective to politics. Established parties like the DMK, TMC, and CPI(M) may face challenges ahead.

The Shiv Sena is struggling with internal divisions, and the Akali Dal is facing difficulties as well. Other parties, such as the NCP and JD(S), are losing influence, and the JD(U) seems to be in decline. Additionally, the BRS and BSP are facing their own challenges, which can be frustrating for their supporters.

Mamata Banerjee's loss to BJP's Suwendu Adhikari in the 2026 election marks a pivotal moment in West Bengal politics, ending her 2011 victory and raising questions about her political future and regional leadership dynamics, both of which are vital for understanding the current political landscape.

What comes next for Mamata Banerjee? She will likely continue her p 'stests and work hard to mobilise the TMC, remaining a vital part of the INDIA coalition. Still, many supporters and



THE BJP'S VICTORIES IN WEST BENGAL AND ASSAM MARK A MAJOR EXPANSION, SIGNALLING A GROWING CENTRAL INFLUENCE THAT CHALLENGES REGIONAL PARTIES AND RESHAPES THE OVERALL POWER BALANCE IN INDIAN POLITICS, WHICH IS CRUCIAL FOR UNDERSTANDING CURRENT TRENDS

The writer is a popular columnist

dailypioneer
 @kalyanishankar
 The Pioneer

analysts are concerned about her political future amid the BJP's growing influence in West Bengal, which could reshape regional leadership dynamics. There was a strong rumour that DMK and AIADMK would come together to form a government, as Vjay was struggling to get the majority.

On the same night, AIADMK General Secretary EV Palaniswamy, unaware of these developments, began discussions with Udhayanidhi. Political manoeuvring in Tamil Nadu began on May 4, after actor Vijay's party, TVK, won 108 seats, just 10 short of a majority. Reports revealed that AIADMK leaders S. P. Velumani and C. V. Shanmugam aimed to rally 33 of the party's 47 MLAs to align with TVK while circumventing the anti-defection law.

India's political landscape has undergone a significant change, as a communist party currently governs no state for the first time since 1977. Kerala's loss of Left control marks this shift, following a story where figures like Jyoti Basu nearly became prime minister. The Left's 34 years in power in West Bengal and its recent defeats in Tripura and Kerala highlight its decline, prompting reflections on its acts and on how the BJP.

Marking the first time since 1977 that the state is ruled by a communist government, following Kerala's shift from Left control. From Jyoti Basu's near-prime ministerial bid to the Left Front's historical influence and its presence in Bengal, the decline of this powerful ideological force prompts reflection

on its achievements, failures, and on how the BJP outmaKerala's it. The CPI(M) will need to regroup and energise to maintain relevance in the public sphere. The Congress party has not yet named its new chief minister, but many are watching K.C. Venugopal, a close aide to Rahul Gandhi, as a potential candidate.

Established parties like TMC, DMK, and the Left must introspect on their recent electoral failures. If they do not correct their mistakes, the BJP will solidify its position in Bengal, and both DMK and AIADMK may lose their voter base. The sooner they do this, the better for their parties.

Meanwhile, Vijay must focus on giving good administration.

Some states, such as Tamil Nadu, West Bengal, and Kerala, are undergoing significant change. The new chief ministers must lead effectively, inspiring confidence in

their ability to adapt and guide their states through transition. Vijay is relatively unknown in the political arena, and his greatest challenge will be managing the government. He faces the risk that his allies could blackmail him at any time. Additionally, he must fulfil his campaign promises.

In contrast, the BJP is in a stronger position, having won West Bengal and retained control of Assam.

On the whole, the opposition has to sit down and chalk out a future. In contrast, the BJP is in a stronger position, having won West Bengal and retained control of Assam.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

Madan Lall Manchanda: A bridge between cultures and eras

MADHU BHATT TAILANG

2ND OPINION

The world of literature remembers Madan Lall Manchanda not merely as a writer, but as a rare visionary who used his pen to weave a tapestry of communal harmony. On the occasion of his 102nd birth anniversary on May 15, we celebrate a life dedicated to the 'Ganga-Jamuni Tehzeeb' – the syncretic culture of India – nurtured through nine decades of profound experience. His scholarship was unique in its ability to transcend linguistic barriers; through prestigious dailies like *The Pioneer*, *The Hindustan Times* and *The Hindu*, he introduced the nuances of Urdu literature to a global English-speaking audience. From the mystical contributions of Amir Khusro to the intricate layers of Mirza Ghalib's poetry, his essays served as a vital link between traditional heritage and modern sensibilities.

His seminal work, *Glimpses of Modern Urdu Literature*, remains a definitive resource offering an analytical history of Urdu drama and the evolution of the Ghazal, reflecting his belief that languages are never walls of separation but bridges of connection.

Manchanda's creative prowess reached its zenith in *Reality Delights*, a collection of stories exploring the extraordinary hidden within the mundane. He famously noted that truth is often more wonderful than fiction, a philosophy that so deeply impressed the former President of India, APJ Abdul Kalam, that he agreed to release the book only after a meticulous reading. Captivated by the depth of the prose, Dr Kalam's query to the author – "How do you manage to write so beautifully?" – remains a tribute of the highest order. This sensitivity is equally evident in stories like *A Conscience Keeper*, which captures the loneliness of the elderly, and *Caste Crossed*, which confronts social prejudices. Whether emphasising the purity of faith over ritual or

documenting his vast experiences in *Precious Memories*, his writing remained a mirror to the human soul.

In his later essays, such as *Saving the Mahatma* and *Need for Communal Harmony*, Manchanda underlined the timeless relevance of Gandhian values and the innate humanity that transcends religious boundaries. His global concerns were equally sharp; in *Spectre of*

Nuclear Holocaust, he echoed the warnings of poets like Sahir Ludhianvi against the perils of war. Even after crossing the age of ninety, and having been honoured with the Delhi Urdu Academy Award in 2010, he continued to offer a positive vision for a changing world. In an era

often marked by polarisation, Madan Lall Manchanda's legacy stands as a lighthouse, ensuring that the fragrance of literature, love and shared humanity continues to inspire future generations.

The writer is a Professor

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Manipur demands immediate peace

The continuing violence in Manipur reflects the failure of both the state and Union governments to effectively exercise their constitutional responsibilities in restoring peace and order. A day after three church leaders were shot dead in Kangpokpi district, another civilian was killed in Noney district in what appeared to be a retaliatory attack. These repeated incidents highlight a serious collapse of governance and law enforcement in the state. Three persons belonging to one community were killed on Wednesday morning, while a civilian from another community was killed later in the evening, reportedly in retaliation. The Union government appears to be a mute spectator despite the ongoing bloodshed. How long will the Centre remain silent while innocent lives continue to be lost?

Manipur remains trapped in violence, with even the Supreme Court observing a collapse of law and order. Restoring peace is the government's responsibility. The ethnic conflict between the Meitei and Kuki communities, which erupted in May 2023, has already claimed at least 260 lives and displaced thousands. Both the state and Union governments must act decisively to restore normalcy and rebuild trust among communities.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Criminalisation in politics

The latest report released by the Association for Democratic Reforms on newly elected MLAs facing criminal charges has once again highlighted the alarming extent of criminalisation in politics. The findings raise serious concerns about governance, accountability and the credibility of democratic institutions.

According to the report, the ruling TVK leads the list, with 41 MLAs facing criminal cases, including 19 with serious charges. The DMK follows with 37 legislators facing cases, 14 of them serious, while the AIADMK has 33 MLAs with criminal charges, including 14 grave cases. The fact that all major political parties figure prominently in the report shows that criminalisation has become a widespread political problem rather than an isolated issue.

When lawmakers themselves face serious allegations, public confidence in democracy weakens. Citizens expect elected representatives to uphold the law, not stand accused of violating it.

Political parties must stop fielding tainted candidates merely because of their influence or financial strength. Electoral reforms, speedy trials and greater public awareness are urgently needed to restore faith in politics and democratic governance.

AP THIRUVADI | CHENNAI

Balancing economy and citizens

Apropos the news report, 'Govt raises import duty on gold to conserve forex' (May 14), India's decision to sharply raise customs duty on gold and silver reflects the seriousness of the economic challenges arising from the prolonged West Asia conflict. The increase in the prices of petrol, diesel and domestic LPG cylinders now appears to be the next step in the government's list of measures. With oil prices and import bills rising sharply, conserving foreign exchange has become essential. In this context, the government's decision appears justified. However, such measures will inevitably burden ordinary citizens, especially middle-class families and small jewellers. In India, gold is not merely a luxury commodity; it is also closely linked to savings, weddings and tradition. A steep rise in import duties may also encourage smuggling and illegal trade, against which policymakers must remain vigilant.

The government must ensure that such austerity measures remain balanced and temporary. Simultaneously, efforts to reduce dependence on imported oil through renewable energy, ethanol blending and public transport reforms should be intensified. Citizens too must cooperate responsibly during this period of global uncertainty.

SANJAY CHOPRA | MOHALI

PIC TALK



Couples during a mass marriage ceremony organised under the 'Kanya Vivah Sahayata Yojana', in Kanpur.

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



www.dailypioneer.com

facebook.com/dailypioneer @TheDailyPioneer
 instagram.com/dailypioneer linkedin.com/in/ThePioneer

NEET EXAMINATION LEAK EXPOSES DEEP FLAWS IN SYSTEM

The recent developments in the NEET paper leak investigation, in which the CBI reportedly traced the "guess paper" operation to Kerala and arrested five accused persons, have once again exposed serious weaknesses in the country's examination system. NEET is among India's most important entrance examinations, and any compromise in its fairness severely affects the confidence of lakhs of students aspiring for a medical career.

The repeated occurrence of such scandals highlights deep flaws that can no longer be ignored. Students spend years preparing with dedication, discipline and honesty, hoping to secure admission purely on merit. When paper leaks and organised malpractice influence examinations, deserving candidates feel betrayed and

demoralised. The fear that unfair means may overpower genuine hard work is damaging not only for students but also for society's faith in educational institutions.

While the CBI's action is a welcome step, arrests alone cannot provide a permanent solution. Authorities must uncover the entire network involved and identify the loopholes that enabled confidential material to be leaked. Stronger cybersecurity systems, encrypted paper distribution, stricter monitoring and swift punishment for offenders are urgently required.

A fair and transparent examination system is essential for preserving trust in India's education structure. Protecting the future of honest students must remain a national priority.

RUKMA SHARMA | JALANDHAR

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Environmental and economic damages due to Iran war

The US-Israel-Iran conflict has evolved into a major geopolitical and economic crisis, disrupting global energy supplies, raising fears of nuclear escalation and causing severe environmental damage. The closure of the Strait of Hormuz and rising oil prices may also significantly impact economies such as India



B K SINGH

Trump claimed to have obliterated all Iranian nuclear facilities in Operation Midnight Hammer, using US B-2 bombers and Israeli missiles during the 12-day war in June 2025. Yet, his forces, along with the Israelis, launched Operation Epic Fury on 28 February 2026, bombarding Iranian nuclear enrichment sites, missile manufacturing facilities, hundreds of naval ships and IRGC installations. Trump again claimed to have destroyed Iranian naval and air power, as well as missile launchers, during the 39-day-long war and unilaterally declared a ceasefire. Since then, negotiations between the US and Iran have made no headway. Trump has been demanding that Iran surrender 450 kg of enriched uranium and suspend programmes aimed at developing nuclear weapons. The Strait of Hormuz, which remained open for international trade until 28 February, has now been closed by Iran to exercise leverage in negotiations. Trump also ordered a naval blockade in the Gulf of Oman to prevent cargo ships from transiting to and from Iranian ports in the Persian Gulf, with a view to embargoing oil movement and blocking revenue that funds the war. This has not proved effective, as Chinese ships have defied the blockade. The Iranian regime is fighting for survival and does not wish to surrender its only leverage - the closure of Hormuz.

The bombardment of Iranian energy infrastructure, oil refineries, oil stocks and ships transporting oil in Iran, Kuwait, Bahrain, Saudi Arabia, Israel and the UAE has caused environmental damage at both regional and global levels. The black rain that followed in Tehran during the recent conflict contains atmospheric pollutants. The environment is choked with pollutants released from the burning of heavy fuel — a low-quality by-product of oil refining — including methylene chloride, benzene and acetone. Benzene, notably, is known to cause cancer. Missiles and drones generate chemically laden debris, which falls on agricultural land surrounding military and oil infrastructure sites. Combined with fires on the ground, these chemicals remain in the soil and considerably reduce agricultural productivity. Around 5,000 MT of explosives are believed to have been dumped in the region, polluting air, water and soil. The environmental impact of the war has far-reaching consequences, affecting human health, livelihoods and even contributing to catastrophes caused by rising seas.

During the 39 days, Iran struck all 13 US bases in GCC countries, as well as Israeli defence and civilian infrastructure, oil refineries and residential areas near Dimona, close to the nuclear research centre. Dimona is believed to produce plutonium for Israel's undeclared nuclear weapons programme. It hosts the IRR-2 heavy water reactor, which operates outside IAEA safeguards. The Strait of Hormuz, through which 20 million barrels of oil and gas per day once flowed for global consumption, has been choked by the Iranian IRGC, and now only a trickle passes through, triggering one of the biggest global energy crises.

Theodore Postol, a professor of nuclear physics at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology and a former Pentagon adviser, stated before Western media — based on engineering data and battlefield evidence — that Iran already possesses the material needed to move quickly towards developing a bomb. Iran's stockpile of 450 kg of 60 per cent enriched uranium hexafluoride could potentially produce 11 atomic bombs. Prof. Postol further added that experience suggests Iran would not make the first use of a nuclear bomb. However, if the US or Israel were to use nuclear weapons against Iran, a response would be inevitable. From its existing stockpile of 60 per cent enriched uranium hexafluoride, Iran has the capability to further enrich it to 90 per cent within less than two weeks.



AMITABH RANJAN

outsiders. However, 'Bharat' is a timeless name through which this civilization has addressed itself for ages. In a completely decolonized civilisation, Bharat deserves unequivocal primacy over India.

The mighty river Sindhu and the Vedic culture are like conjoined twins, so much so that even the Rig Veda refers to Sapta-Sindhu, the land of seven rivers spread across the north-western subcontinent. In Vedic hymns, Sindhu is synonymous with both the Indus and its wider cultural landscape.

With the eastward expansion of the Achaemenid Persians, Sindhu became Hinduś, depicting the lower Indus basin as an extension of their empire. The Greeks pronounced it Indos and its inhabitants as Indoi — the people of the Indus. Eventually, Indos evolved into 'India' in English, while Hindustan came to be used in medieval times.

In other words, 'India' is an exonym - a word born in Persian and Greek geographies looking eastward towards a frontier river, rather than a

Trump claimed to have obliterated all Iranian nuclear facilities in Operation Midnight Hammer, using US B-2 bombers and Israeli missiles during the 12-day war in June 2025. Yet, his forces, along with the Israelis, launched Operation Epic Fury on 28 February 2026, bombarding Iranian nuclear enrichment sites, missile manufacturing facilities, hundreds of naval ships and IRGC installations. Trump again claimed to have destroyed Iranian naval and air power, as well as missile launchers, during the 39-day-long war and unilaterally declared a ceasefire. Since then, negotiations between the US and Iran have made no headway. Trump has been demanding that Iran surrender 450 kg of enriched uranium and suspend programmes aimed at developing nuclear weapons. The Strait of Hormuz, which remained open for international trade until 28 February, has now been closed by Iran to exercise leverage in negotiations. Trump also ordered a naval blockade in the Gulf of Oman to prevent cargo ships from transiting to and from Iranian ports in the Persian Gulf, with a view to embargoing oil movement and blocking revenue that funds the war. This has not proved effective, as Chinese ships have defied the blockade. The Iranian regime is fighting for survival and does not wish to surrender its only leverage - the closure of Hormuz.



Despite continuous bombardment of its nuclear sites at Isfahan and Natanz, Iran's capability has not been completely obliterated. Nearly 100 centrifuges required for further enrichment to weapons-grade material could reportedly be brought into operation quickly, enabling the preparation of 11 atomic bombs. These centrifuges can be installed inside tunnels and concealed locations. Three atomic bombs could destroy an area of 25 square kilometres, such as Tel Aviv, while 11 would theoretically be sufficient to eradicate Israel entirely.

Even if Iran has not assembled a complete nuclear bomb, a delay of two weeks in response would make little difference in strategic terms. Even lower-grade nuclear weapons could unleash urban firestorms, radiation exposure and radioactive rainfall, leading to massive casualties in cities such as Tel Aviv.

Iran's technological base has not been undermined despite decades of sanctions and international isolation. Iran's targeting of Israel and American bases with ballistic missiles is considered a game changer. Prof. Postol says ballistic missiles travel at hypersonic speeds of up to Mach 5 or more, leaving detection systems with only seconds to react. Israeli claims that they intercept 90 per cent of missiles and drones are also disputed.

This asymmetric warfare has created economic cost imbalances between Iran and the far more powerful US. Iranian drones costing ten to twenty thousand dollars are intercepted using missile defence systems operated by the US and Israel, with each interceptor missile costing several million dollars. Attacks on US allies in GCC countries, disrupting supply chains and energy infrastructure, amount to attacks on the economic lifelines of adversaries. Iran does not seek to overpower the US and Israel militarily, but rather to demoralise them psychologically and inflict damage on their military and economy. Democracies such as the US and Israel often struggle to sustain prolonged wars, as approval ratings for leaders in such countries can decline sharply. Six months from now, Trump's Republican Party faces the US midterm congressional elections, and he is keen to exit the war early. As the stronger side, failure to secure a decisive victory would place the US at a disadvantage. The side that endures longer gains the advantage. Henry Kissinger once observed, "The guerrilla wins if he does not lose. The conventional army loses if it does not win."

It is high time that Trump distances himself from

Netanyahu and halts the supply of weapons and air defence systems. Annual inflation in the US has sharply increased from 2.4 per cent in February to 3.3 per cent in early May. Global oil production has declined by 10 per cent, while petrochemical production has fallen by 7 per cent. Helium and fertiliser production have also suffered setbacks. Unless normalcy is restored, prices will remain elevated, and the midterm elections could prove disastrous for Trump.

The shockwaves will also be felt in the Indian economy. Despite strong growth in automobiles, cement, credit and consumer demand during March, April and May, real growth is projected to decline by 1.2 per cent. If the average oil price for the year remains around \$85 per barrel, compared with last year's average of \$70 per barrel, India will have to pay an additional \$40 billion for energy imports - roughly 1 per cent of GDP. If prices average around \$100 per barrel, the economic headwinds could amount to 2 per cent of GDP. Hopefully, such a situation does not arise. Cuts in excise duty on petrol and diesel, continuing losses at oil marketing companies, and subsidies on LPG and fertilisers may further impact GDP by 1.2 per cent. If oil prices remain elevated, fuel and LPG prices may have to increase. A rise of Rs 10 per litre could reduce GDP growth by 0.4 per cent annually.

We must therefore respond to the Prime Minister's appeal, in which he urged citizens to reduce gold purchases for the next year. In a follow-up measure, the Central Government increased duty on gold and silver from 6 per cent to 15 per cent to suppress demand. This would help reduce dollar outflow and stabilise the weakening rupee. The use of public transport and working from home were followed diligently during COVID; these habits should again be encouraged to address the current situation. Such measures also reduce the carbon footprint amid worsening environmental degradation. The Prime Minister has also advised reducing foreign travel, which could provide a boost to the domestic tourism sector. His appeal to reduce dependency on foreign goods and move towards swadeshi products should be followed. Finally, reducing the use of chemical fertilisers could make Indian agriculture more resilient.

The writer is former Head of Forest Force, Karnataka, and teaches Economics at the Karnataka Forest Academy.

 dailypioneer
 @TheDailyPioneer
 The Pioneer

Fuel conservation must begin with the Government



SUBHASH CHANDRA AGRAWAL

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal to citizens to save fuel in the national interest is both timely and necessary. At a time when rising global crude prices, environmental degradation and growing urban congestion are placing enormous pressure on India's economy, energy conservation cannot remain merely a matter of public responsibility. The government itself must lead by example through serious structural reforms and policy changes that reduce unnecessary fuel consumption and discourage the culture of excessive automobile dependence.

One of the first steps should be a complete ban on extravagant political roadshows and large election rallies that involve thousands of vehicles, helicopters, diesel generators and massive logistical arrangements. Political parties often preach austerity to citizens while practising excess themselves. Such events not only consume enormous quantities of fuel but also create traffic chaos and environmental pollution. Public messaging on fuel conservation will carry credibility only when political leadership demonstrates restraint.

Similarly, the government should review the size of official convoys accompanying ministers and senior bureaucrats. Security considerations are important, but there is ample scope to reduce unnecessary layers of vehicles without compromising safety. Long convoys of SUVs and luxury cars moving through crowded cities send the wrong message in a country where ordinary citizens are repeatedly urged to conserve fuel and reduce consumption.

Government expenditure on luxury vehicles must also be curtailed. All central and state government departments, along with public sector undertakings, should be required to purchase only economy-range vehicles, except for constitutional authorities such as the President, Vice-President, Prime Minister and visiting foreign dignitaries. Over the years, several state governments have faced criticism for purchasing expensive luxury cars even during periods of economic distress. Such decisions create public anger because they reflect misplaced priorities. Public money should be directed towards healthcare, education, public transport and infrastructure rather than official extravagance.

India must also rethink its broader transport culture. The obsession with private cars has reached unsustainable levels in major cities. Roads are congested, parking space is shrinking and pollution levels continue to rise. Instead of encouraging ever-growing car ownership, policy should focus on efficient, affordable and eco-friendly public and shared transport systems. One practical solution could be the promotion of modern, air-conditioned auto-rickshaws powered by electricity or CNG. Such vehicles occupy less road space, require less parking, consume less energy and are more environmentally sustainable. If designed properly with safety and comfort in mind, they could become a preferred mode of transport even for sections of the middle class.

Government departments should adopt public and shared transport alternatives instead of maintaining large fleets of cars. India must expand metro rail networks, electric buses and integrated urban transport systems rather than encouraging private automobile growth. At the same time, luxury vehicles should attract higher taxes and stricter loan norms, as such consumption often reflects status rather than necessity.

The government should further reconsider policies that indirectly encourage the expansion of large private vehicles. Former Union Environment Minister Jairam Ramesh once accurately described SUVs as "Socially Useless Vehicles" because they consume excessive fuel and occupy disproportionate road space. Large cars worsen congestion while offering little public benefit. India requires a fresh automobile policy that prioritises compact, energy-efficient and environmentally responsible vehicles over oversized luxury models.

Another critical issue is diesel usage in private cars. Diesel has historically been subsidised because it powers public transport, goods carriers and essential logistics. Allowing luxury private vehicles to benefit from lower-priced diesel distorts the purpose of the subsidy. Diesel engines in private cars should therefore be gradually phased out while investments are directed towards electric mobility, CNG infrastructure and cleaner technologies. At the same time, environmental regulation should become more practical and scientific. Blanket scrapping policies that force owners to abandon diesel cars after ten years and petrol cars after fifteen years often unfairly burden middle-class families and senior citizens who use their vehicles sparingly. Vehicle fitness should instead be determined through rigorous pollution and safety testing rather than arbitrary age limits. Authorised workshops should conduct computerised fitness checks after a fixed number of years, and only vehicles failing those tests should be scrapped.

Pollution-control systems also need major reform. Automobile workshops should be mandated to install pollution-testing facilities so that every vehicle leaving a service centre is certified for emissions compliance. Presently, vehicle owners are forced to repeatedly visit separate pollution-testing centres, causing inconvenience and unnecessary fuel consumption. A more integrated system would improve efficiency and compliance.

The automobile industry itself requires greater regulation in the interest of consumers. Excessive variants of the same car model confuse buyers and artificially inflate prices. Standardisation of components such as tyres, batteries and spare parts across manufacturers could significantly reduce costs through economies of scale. Car manufacturers currently enjoy enormous profit margins on spare parts because of limited competition and lack of standardisation. The government's anti-profiteering mechanisms should ensure that consumers are not exploited through unreasonable pricing.

India must ultimately redefine what progress means in the transport sector. Development cannot simply be measured by rising sales of expensive cars or expanding highways crowded with private vehicles. A truly modern transport vision is one that prioritises efficiency, sustainability, affordability and public welfare. Fuel conservation is not merely about reducing imports or saving money; it is also about environmental responsibility, urban livability and economic discipline. Citizens certainly have a role to play, but meaningful change will come only when governments, policymakers and industries demonstrate the same commitment they expect from the public.

The writer is a Delhi-based RTI consultant

 dailypioneer
 @TheDailyPioneer
 The Pioneer

Bharat, that is India: Reclaiming a civilisational identity

Since time immemorial, civilisations have invariably been perceived through the names associated with them. The nomenclature 'India' is a term shaped by geography rather than culture, given by outsiders. However, 'Bharat' is a timeless name through which this civilization has addressed itself for ages. In a completely decolonized civilisation, Bharat deserves unequivocal primacy over India.

The mighty river Sindhu and the Vedic culture are like conjoined twins, so much so that even the Rig Veda refers to Sapta-Sindhu, the land of seven rivers spread across the north-western subcontinent. In Vedic hymns, Sindhu is synonymous with both the Indus and its wider cultural landscape.

With the eastward expansion of the Achaemenid Persians, Sindhu became Hinduś, depicting the lower Indus basin as an extension of their empire. The Greeks pronounced it Indos and its inhabitants as Indoi — the people of the Indus. Eventually, Indos evolved into 'India' in English, while Hindustan came to be used in medieval times.

In other words, 'India' is an exonym - a word born in Persian and Greek geographies looking eastward towards a frontier river, rather than a



name emerging from the soul of the civilization itself. Over time, colonial cartography stretched this frontier term to cover the entire subcontinent, and post-colonial diplomacy understandably retained it for continuity in treaties, maps and global recognition. However, the etymology is unambiguous — 'India' is what others called the land of Sindhu, not what its inhabitants called themselves.

Bharat, however, is not rooted in a foreign ecosystem but in our own polity, history and geography. The Vishnu Purana describes this land, 'lying to the north of the ocean and to the south of the snowy mountains', as Bharat, where dwell the descendants of King Bharat. This Bharatvarsha is perceived as a living entity within Jambudvipa and not a colonial landscape depicted on a map by Mercator. Ancient texts remember Bharat as a dutiful and righteous king whose name became synonymous with the land — Bharatavarsha — its inhabitants, Bharatiyas, and the Mahabharata, the tale of Bharat's descendants.

The framers of our Constitution were aware of this duality, as Article 1 opens with the carefully chiselled phrase, "India, that is Bharat, shall be a Union of States." Our Constituent Assembly explicitly chose to retain both names — one carrying international familiarity, the other civilisational continuity — as two faces of the same coin. The question now is not whether to delete 'India', but whether and how to accord rightful recognition to 'Bharat'.

This relates to the larger question of decolo-

esteem. This is evident even in the comparisons we commonly make. Kalidasa, widely regarded as the greatest poet of ancient India, flourished sometime during the 4th-5th century CE, whereas Shakespeare lived in 16th-17th century England. Yet we still refer to Kalidasa as 'the Shakespeare of India'. This remains a stark example of the mental and cultural colonialism with which we continue to live.

Following the English system of vowels, we insert 'a' into our original words such as 'Kalidasa', 'Bharata' and 'Kerala' (fortunately now often rendered as Keralam), and pronounce them accordingly, distorting Sanskrit and Hindi pronunciations. So much so that we write 'Yog' as 'Yoga' and pronounce it in the same fashion. The greatest irony is that I am writing this piece in English only to make it more noticeable.

If we take the Prime Minister's 2035 horizon for eradicating colonial mentality seriously, then nomenclature is not a peripheral issue but part of the mindset that must be revisited. Article 1 already acknowledges both names. However, a logical next step may be to amend the Constitution to place Bharat first, making it "Bharat, that is India, shall be a Union of States", and to echo this primacy wherever citizens identify themselves.

Such an amendment would allow the Preamble to begin with "We, the people of Bharat...", aligning our supreme law with a civilisational reality that predates colonial modernity by millennia. Globally, the state may continue to use 'India' where necessary for reasons of familiarity and

continuity, just as many nations function with multiple official names without legal complexities. However, domestically and constitutionally, the fulcrum would decisively shift from the foreign exonym to our own original endonym. Critics may argue that this is mere symbolism. Yet symbols are what nations are built upon — emblems, flags, songs, anthems and names crystallize the stories we tell about ourselves.

The journey from Sapta-Sindhu to 'India' reflects how others mapped us. The journey of Bharat — from the Puranas to the epics, from inscriptions to the Constitution — reflects how we shaped ourselves. As we approach 2035, two hundred years after Macaulay's project of a decisive mental shift, it is perhaps time to decide which of these paths will anchor the next century of our republic.

Granting unequivocal primacy to Bharat is not about denying history, diversity or global engagement. It is about affirming that this Union of States is fundamentally a civilisational community with its own lineage of thought, its own categories of dignity and, above all, its own ancient name. Perhaps the time has come for both a constitutional and cultural shift to cast off a borrowed identity so that we may proudly live as "We, the people of Bharat" — Bharat, that is India.

The writer is an alumnus of NES, Washington DC, and IIT (ISM) Dhanbad, and is associated with the Indian Institute of Public Administration (IIPA), New Delhi, as Registrar

 dailypioneer
 @TheDailyPioneer
 dr-amitabh-ranjan-3601a210



**TRANSGLOBE
ADVISORS**

**Your Trusted
Management
Advisory**

www.transglobeadvisors.in

Order Order

**Ex-minister Alamgir Alam
walks out of jail on bail**

Former Jharkhand minister Alamgir Alam walked out of Birs Munda Central Jail here on Thursday after the Supreme Court granted him bail in a money laundering case linked to an alleged tender scam being investigated by the ED. The federal probe agency had arrested the Congress leader on May 15, 2024, days after around Rs 32 crore in cash was seized from premises linked to his aide. Alam had earlier moved the Jharkhand High Court seeking bail, but the court had rejected his plea, citing the seriousness of the allegations and the ongoing investigation. Challenging it, he moved the Supreme Court, which, after hearing arguments from both sides, granted him bail. "I am out of jail on bail after two years. I am happy that people in my area remembered the work I have done for them. Many of them met me in jail. During this time, I also figured out who truly stands by me," Alam told reporters at his residence after his release. Alam said he had always been a law-abiding citizen and had appeared before the ED after receiving notice. (PTI)

**ED OPPOSES
VADRA PLEA IN
DELHI HC**



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Enforcement Directorate on Thursday opposed a petition filed by businessman Robert Vadra in the Delhi High Court challenging a trial court order that summoned him in a money laundering case linked to a land deal in Haryana's Shikohpur. The counsel for the investigating agency argued before Justice Manoj Jain that Vadra's petition was based on a false legal submission and should therefore be dismissed with costs. The agency countered the submission by Vadra's lawyer, Senior Advocate Abhishek Singhvi, who argued that the Enforcement Directorate (ED) has no jurisdiction to probe the case as the offences filed against the petitioner under the Indian Penal Code and the Prevention of Corruption Act were not "scheduled offences" under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act at the relevant time. Singhvi said the land deal admittedly happened between 2008 and 2012, and the offences forming the basis of the ED case were only included in the schedule in 2013 and 2018.

SC bench reserves order on religious discrimination against women

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

A nine-judge Supreme Court bench on Thursday reserved its order on petitions related to discrimination against women at religious places, including Sabarimala temple of Kerala, and on the ambit and scope of religious freedom practised by multiple faiths. A constitution bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant heard the matter for 16 days and took note of arguments made by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, senior advocates C S Vaidyanathan, Abhishek Singhvi, Mukul Rohatgi, Indira Jaising, Neeraj Kishan Kaul and Gopal Sankaranarayanan among others. The bench also comprised justices BV Nagarathna, MM Sundresh, Ahsanuddin Amanullah,



Aravind Kumar, Augustine George Masih, Prasanna B Varale, R Mahadevan and Joymalya Bagchi. Ahead of the hearing, the Centre had filed written submissions and requested the top court to uphold restriction on the entry of women of menstruating age into the Sabarimala temple. The Union of India said the issue



Mamata alleges police inaction on post-poll attacks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kolkata

Trinamool Congress supremo Mamata Banerjee on Thursday told the Calcutta High Court that police remained passive during post-poll violence in West Bengal, while asserting that it is not a "bulldozer state", amid ongoing demolition drives against illegal structures. The former chief minister, who appeared for the first time before the high court to argue a case in connection with alleged violence against workers and attacks on TMC party offices following the announcement of the 2026 assembly poll results, sought urgent judicial intervention to protect the people of the state from the attackers. This was Banerjee's second appearance as lawyer before a court of law in recent times and the first



Ex-CM Mamata Banerjee appeared before the Calcutta High Court to argue a case in connection with alleged post-poll violence on party offices, in Kolkata (PTI)

since her party's electoral debacle in Bengal in the hands of the BJP, the previous one being in February this year, when she had personally appeared before the Supreme Court

and made submissions in the petition filed by her challenging the West Bengal SIR process. An LLB degree holder, Banerjee, accompanied by senior Trinamool

HC recalls order in *The Wire* founder status case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Thursday recalled its order setting aside the Centre's decision to reject *The Wire* founding editor Siddharth Varadarajan's plea seeking conversion of his Person of Indian Origin status to Overseas Citizen of India, saying he is prima facie guilty of suppressing facts. Justice Purushendra Kumar Kaurav also recalled its May 13 order asking the authorities to consider an application by the US citizen for a "return visa" and allowing him to travel to Estonia



Siddharth Varadarajan

between May 14 and 19. The judge said the journalist failed to disclose the existence of a 2020 Allahabad High Court order that granted him anticipatory bail in a criminal case and imposed conditions, such as surren-

dering his passport and restricting travel abroad without permission from the trial court concerned. Stating that it is always believed that a petitioner approaches the court with "full disclosure," Justice Kaurav issued notice to Varadarajan and asked him to file an affidavit in seven working days to explain his conduct. "A perusal of the entire pleadings and the submissions till now by the petitioner, nowhere discloses the binding directions of the Allahabad High Court to the petitioner. In all fairness, the petitioner should have truthfully disclosed the said aspect.

The Federation of All India Medical Association (FAIMA), through lawyer Tanvi Dubey, has also sought a direction to appoint a high-powered monitoring committee until a fresh body is formally constituted to oversee the re-examination. It further said the committee should comprise a retired Supreme Court judge as the chair, along with a cybersecurity expert and a forensic scientist, to ensure that no further leaks occur.

FAIMA urges SC to replace NTA with autonomous body for NEET-UG conduct

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

A medical body has urged the Supreme Court to direct restructuring or replacement of NTA with a robust and autonomous system to conduct NEET-UG, citing a "direct assault" on the fundamental rights of over 22.7 lakh students through recurring paper leaks.

The Federation of All India Medical Association (FAIMA), through lawyer Tanvi Dubey, has also sought a direction to appoint a high-powered monitoring committee until a fresh body is formally constituted to oversee the re-examination. It further said the committee should comprise a retired Supreme Court judge as the chair, along with a cybersecurity expert and a forensic scientist, to ensure that no further leaks occur.

The undergraduate-level National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET) held on May 3 by the National Testing Agency (NTA) for admissions to medical education programmes was cancelled on May 12 amid allegations of paper leak, which are now being probed by the CBI.

The NTA, Union Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, and the CBI have been made parties in the plea by FAIMA. "The present writ petition seeks the urgent intervention of this Hon'ble Court against the recurring, systemic and catastrophic failure of the NTA in conducting the NEET-UG," it said. According to the petition, the Rajasthan Police



Special Operations Group (SOG) uncovered that "guess papers" circulated on WhatsApp and Telegram contained 120 questions identical to those in the actual Biology and Chemistry sections of the NEET-UG 2026 paper.

Despite the NTA's claims of using high-tech security including 5G jammers, GPS tracking and AI-monitored cameras, the plea alleged that these measures existed "only on paper".

"Direct mandating the 'digital locking' of question papers and a transition to a 'computer based test' (CBT) model, as suggested in the aftermath of previous leaks, to eliminate the physical chain-of-custody risks," the plea said. It further sought a direction to the CBI to file a status report before the apex court within four weeks regarding the investigation into the paper leak, including the network identified, arrests made, persons charged and progress of prosecution. For "transparent detection of anomalies", the

NTA be asked to "forthwith publish centre-wise results (as and when available) of NEET-UG 2026", the plea said.

"NEET-UG is a national level examination for undergraduate medical admissions in India, directly affecting the academic and professional futures of over 22.7 lakh students. The recurring instance of systemic failure is a direct assault on the fundamental guarantees of equality and right to life/livelihood under Articles 14 and 21," it said.

The current system used by the NTA to conduct exams is without proper safeguards, it contested, adding that despite repeated paper leaks over the years, the authorities have "failed to implement requisite changes" to protect the exam's integrity.

"They continue to rely on risky, old-fashioned methods like physically printing question papers and using private couriers for transport, making them prone to leaks," it said. The petitioner highlighted that this is not an isolated incident.

**Congress moves
HC seeking
execution of sale
deed for its
former HQ**



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Thursday sought the stand of the Centre and Delhi government on a petition by the Indian National Congress seeking the execution of a sale deed in the party's favour for its former headquarters at 7, Jantar Mantar Road here. Justice Purushendra Kumar Kaurav issued notice to the governments on the petition as well as an application for interim relief, seeking their reply on both aspects. Even as senior advocate Abhishek Singhvi, appearing for All India Congress Committee, urged the court to pass an interim order to ensure that the premises is not allotted to someone else in the meantime, Justice Kaurav questioned the maintainability of the writ petition. "I have a doubt about the maintainability. Therefore, if you have to press for interim relief, you have to satisfy that the petition is maintainable. See what the response of the government is. You perhaps have to file a civil suit. This seems to be to wriggle out of limitation," the judge orally said.

iexceed

Appzillon™

AI Powered Digital Banking Solutions

WWW.i-exceed.com

IDFC launches business multiplier credit card

IDFC FIRST Bank launches Business Multiplier credit card for Founders & Entrepreneurs First-of-its-kind Metal Business Card backed by Fixed Deposit Mumbai, May 14th, 2026: IDFC FIRST Bank unveiled the FD-backed Business Multiplier Metal Credit Card for founders, entrepreneurs and business owners. Designed to support everyday operational needs, the premium metal card displays both the business name and the cardholder's name, reinforcing its business use. With a dedicated credit limit for business expenses, the Business Multiplier Credit Card can help keep business and personal spend separate. It can be used across a wide range of expenses including office supplies, digital marketing spends, SaaS subscriptions, business travel, equipment purchases, inventory procurement, international vendor payments, and employee reimbursements. Backed by assured credit limits linked to Fixed Deposits, along with rewards on key business categories, real-time visibility into spending, and zero forex markup on international transactions.

Kapil Dhiman conferred the Rashtra seva award

Kapil Dhiman, Co-Founder and Chief Executive Officer of Quranium, has been conferred the BFSI-FinTech Rashtra Seva Award 2026 in the category of India's Best BFSI-FinTech Companies & Thought Leadership for his work at Quranium, the quantum-secure Layer-1 blockchain. The award was presented at the Maha World Expo & Summit held at Nesco, Mumbai, from 7-9 May 2026 - a flagship industry convening organised under the BFSI Bharat + FinTech World Expo, Summit & Awards platform, themed around the Viksit Bharat Abhiyan (1947-2047) vision and India's Aatma Nirbhar Bharat mission. The recognition was conferred by Dr. Joseph Dias, Chairman & Managing Director of Trinity, and Ex-Special Executive Magistrate, Government of Maharashtra. The citation recognises Dhiman's "valuable contributions towards making India a global BFSI-FinTech superpower" and the thought leadership demonstrated by Quranium in advancing next-generation, quantum-secure financial infrastructure for the country.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | MAY 15, 2026

BUSINESS

11

WPI inflation spikes to 42-month high of 8.3%

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Wholesale price inflation shot up to a 42-month high of 8.3 per cent on the back of a spike in energy prices that followed the disruptions caused by the West Asia conflict. Wholesale price index (WPI) inflation was 3.88 per cent in March, while it was 0.85 per cent in April last year. According to global brokerage Barclays, the sequential increase in WPI inflation was the highest on record in the series. A sharp increase in global oil prices drove the surge in the headline rate. Core WPI inflation rose to 5 per cent year-on-year, led by higher manufactured prices of metals, chemicals and textiles. WPI inflation in fuel and power jumped to a 42-month high of 24.71 per cent in April, from 1.05 per cent in March. In crude petroleum, inflation was 88.06 per cent in April, the highest since October 2021.

Wholesale price inflation rises to 8.3% in April on sharp spike in fuel, power, crude

Monthly WPI-Based Inflation Trend (Apr 2025-Apr 2026)

Month	WPI Inflation (in %)
Apr 2025	0.85
May 2025	0.13
Jun 2025	-0.19
Jul 2025	-0.58
Aug 2025	0.52
Sep 2025	0.19
Oct 2025	-1.02
Nov 2025	0.96
Dec 2025	-0.13
Jan 2026	1.68
Feb 2026	2.26
Mar 2026	3.88*
Apr 2026	8.30*

Source: Ministry of Commerce and Industry

*Provisional

The West Asia war and the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz has disrupted crude petroleum imports into India. Also, the sharp rise in crude prices globally has made fuel

and non-food articles, etc," the ministry said in a statement. Inflation in food articles was 1.98 per cent in April, compared to 1.90 per cent in March. In non-food articles, inflation rose to 12.18 per cent during April, 11.5 per cent in the previous month, data released by the commerce and industry ministry showed. In manufactured products, inflation was 4.62 per cent in April, as against 3.39 per cent in the previous month. In the fuel and power basket, inflation in LPG was 10.92 per cent in April, as against (-) 1.54 per cent in March, while in petrol it was 32.40 per cent, as against 2.50 per cent in the previous month. In high-speed diesel, inflation was 25.19 per cent in April as against 3.26 per cent in March. Despite a 50 per cent spike in global crude oil prices, the government has so far held fuel pump and household LPG rates stable to

shield households from the impact of the retail price rise of petrol, diesel and LPG. However, prices of commercial LPG cylinders have been raised. This was evident from the April retail inflation data, which came in at 3.48 per cent. India Ratings & Research Director Megha Arora said the headline inflation is likely to further rise to 9 per cent in May 2026, due to transmission of high energy prices and via its users. the manufacturing sector. "WPI is expected to be higher than the CPI on account of higher weight of fuels in the index, as well as delayed transmission of high crude price to consumers, as the government and the oil marketing companies absorbed most of it until now," Arora said. The West Asia conflict leading to higher price of crude and its derivatives, as well as the potential El Nino effect continues to pose the upside risk to inflation, Arora added.

India's EV battery demand to grow 10 times to 200 GWh by 2032: IESA

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's electric vehicle (EV) battery demand is projected to grow 10 times from 20 GWh in 2025 to 200 GWh by 2032, industry body Indian Energy Alliance (IESA) said on Thursday. Citing a study, IESA said the EV opportunity in India is no longer limited to vehicle manufacturing; the largest strategic gains may lie in component localisation and supply chain development as India positions itself as a global manufacturing hub. The IESA, in association with Customized Energy Solutions (CES), is set to release the study report titled

'India EV & EV Component Market Outlook 2025-2034' at the 12th India Energy Storage Week (IESW), to be held from July 8-10 in the national capital. The study has found that India's EV battery demand is projected to rise sharply from 20 GWh in 2025 to 200 GWh by 2032, a tenfold increase, the industry body said. The EV industry in the country is on the cusp of a significant transformation. What began as a policy-driven transition is now maturing into a sprawling industrial ecosystem encompassing batteries, motors, power electronics, advanced chemistries, localised manufacturing, and robust supply chain investments, IESA said in a statement. "With India's EV market entering an era of unprecedented growth and battery demand projected to rise tenfold by 2032, the industry's next leap will be driven by localisation, advanced chemistry, and resilient supply chains," said Debmalya Sen, President of IESA. The report noted that India's EV sales crossed 2.5 million units in 2025, including

1.5 million two-wheelers and 0.7 million three-wheelers, reflecting the rapidly evolving adoption and manufacturing ecosystem. The report covers a wide spectrum, including the EV market outlook, battery demand forecasts, battery chemistry evolution, component manufacturing trends, supply chain developments, and strategic outlook for the industry through 2034. Vinayak Walimbe, Managing Director of Customized Energy Solutions, stated, "This report aims to give all stakeholders, from OEMs to investors, the strategic direction required to capitalise on these emerging opportunities."

Sensex jumps nearly 790 pts on buying in telecom, banking shares

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Stock markets rose for the second consecutive day on Thursday with the benchmark Sensex jumping by nearly 790 points in a volatile session, driven by value buying in telecom, pharma and private banking shares. The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 789.74 points, or 1.06 per cent, to close at 75,398.72. The index opened higher but slipped into negative territory in late morning deals.

BSE SENSEX

75,398.72 ▲789.74

73,134.32

April 2026

However, value buying in telecom and banking shares helped the barometer pare losses and later jump more than 1,000 points to a high of 75,681.88. Extending gains to the second day, the 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 277 points, or 1.18 per cent, to finish at 23,689.60. Among Sensex firms, Bharti Airtel emerged as the biggest gainer, rallying over 5 per cent after the telecom carrier's annual revenue crossed the ₹2 lakh crore mark for the first time. Eternal rose by 3.32 per cent while HDFC Bank advanced 2.67 per cent, emerging as the major contributor to the Sensex gains. Adani Ports, UltraTech Cement, ITC and State Bank of India were among the other gainers. On the other hand, Infosys, Tech Mahindra, HCL Technologies, Tata Consultancy Services, Hindustan Unilever, Axis Bank and Maruti Suzuki India ended lower. "Indian equities staged a counterintuitive

recovery from intraday lows and ended higher despite the rupee hitting a record low and crude remaining elevated," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Ltd, said. Investor confidence was bolstered in anticipation of potential government measures to mitigate INR weakness, including consideration of bond tax relief for foreign investors and potential tightening of the Liberalized Remittance Scheme to stem capital outflows, he added.

recovery from intraday lows and ended higher despite the rupee hitting a record low and crude remaining elevated," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Ltd, said. Investor confidence was bolstered in anticipation of potential government measures to mitigate INR weakness, including consideration of bond tax relief for foreign investors and potential tightening of the Liberalized Remittance Scheme to stem capital outflows, he added.

Rupee settles at record low of 95.73 against US dollar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The rupee weakened further and fell to a record low of 95.73 (provisional) against the US dollar on Thursday, amid a strong dollar and worries over inflation amid elevated energy prices. Forex traders said the rupee is expected to trade with a negative bias amid inflation concerns and the strength of the US dollar in the overseas market. The West Asia crisis and the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz have disrupted crude petroleum imports into India. Also, the sharp rise in crude prices has made fuel imports costlier. The rupee has become the worst-performing currency in Asia for the year, registering a loss of over 6 per cent so far this year, as elevated crude oil prices, a strong dollar and concerns over the West Asia crisis weighed on investor sentiments, traders said. At the inter-

RUPEE ₹ VS DOLLAR \$

1 USD = 95.73 INR*

94.22 (+27p)

94.49 (-27p)

95.28 (-79p)

95.68 (-40p)

95.66 (+2p)

95.73* (-7p)

May 7

May 8

May 11

May 12

May 13

May 14

*Provisional

(Inverted Scale)

bank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened lower at 95.74 against the American currency. In a volatile trade, the USD/INR pair witnessed an intra-day high of 95.61 and an all-time intraday low of 95.96 against the greenback before settling at 95.73 (provisional), down 7 paise from its previous close. The rupee on Wednesday slipped to an all-time low of 95.80 against the US dollar, and settled at 95.66 against the greenback. "We expect the rupee to trade with a negative bias amid inflation concerns and a strong dollar. Rising inflation in the US dimmed expectations of a rate cut by the Fed," said Anuj Choudhary, Research analyst at Mirae Asset ShareKhan. Choudhary said geopolitical tensions between the US and Iran and foreign fund outflows may also pressurise the rupee. However, any intervention by the RBI and import duty hike on gold and silver may support the rupee at lower levels. \$/INR spot price is expected to trade in a range of 95.50 to 96.10, Choudhary added. Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 98.51, down 0.01 per cent.

ECB filings halve in March: RBI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Foreign borrowing filings by companies and lenders halved to \$5.43 billion in March amid financial market volatilities following the West Asia conflict, the RBI said on Thursday. The proposals filed by Indian companies, including non-banking financial companies (NBFCs), were lower than the USD 11.04 billion they had filed in March 2025, but higher than preceding February's \$4.59 billion, the RBI said. Of the total, intent from general permission stood at \$5.22 billion in March 2026, and special permission was \$212 million, according to data. Amid concerns over sluggish capital expenditure growth, data suggested that there were 19 filings for new projects totalling a borrowing of \$1.14 billion, the central bank said, adding that USD 1.22 billion were intended to refinance either existing ECB or rupee loans. Among the

prominent firms that filed an intent in March 2026 with the RBI is Rajasthan Part I Transmission for \$750 million for a new project. The funding from a financial institution in an international financial services centre has a maturity of 4 years and 11 months, the RBI said. Adani Transmission Step-One filed to raise \$500 million to refinance existing ECB, it added. Among finance companies, IIFL Finance filed for raising \$500 million from the international capital market, while Indian Railway Finance Corporation and Bajaj Finance filed intentions for raising \$391.6 million and \$300 million, respectively.

World shares mostly gain as investors watch Trump-Xi summit

CHAN HO-HIMAP ■ Hong Kong

World shares were mostly higher on Thursday after Wall Street set more records, as investors closely monitored takeaways from US President Donald Trump's summit with Chinese leader Xi Jinping in Beijing. Trump met with Xi at the Great Hall of the People and they talked about US-China relations and Taiwan, but analysts did not expect major breakthroughs. US futures edged higher. In early European trading, Britain's FTSE 100 was up 0.3 per cent to 10,351.36, after the UK reported its economy expanded at a faster-than-expected pace at 0.3 per cent for March despite impacts from the war in Iran. France's CAC 40 rose 0.6 per cent to 8,057.64, and Germany's DAX gained 1.4 per cent to 24,462.22. In Asia, Tokyo's Nikkei 225 index

was down 1 per cent to 62,654.05, after briefly reaching another all-time intraday record at above 63,700, partly supported by robust corporate results.

South Korea's Kospi closed 1.8 per cent higher at 7,981.41 at a fresh record helped by technology-related stocks on the artificial intelligence boom. The Shanghai

Composite index lost 1.5 per cent to 4,177.92. Hong Kong's Hang Seng flatlined at 26,389.04. Australia's S&P/ASX 200 edged up 0.1 per cent to 8,640.70. Taiwan's Taiex was up 0.9 per cent, and India's Sensex climbed 1.1 per cent. Oil prices were mixed, with no clear ending to the Iran war after more than two months. Some were hoping the Trump-Xi meeting could bring results, after US officials said Beijing could use its close economic ties with Tehran to press Iran to reopen the Strait or Hormuz. On Thursday, the White House said Trump and Xi discussed enhancing US-China economic cooperation. Both sides also agreed that the Strait of Hormuz must remain open. Brent crude, the international standard, was up 0.2 per cent at \$105.87 per barrel. It was around \$70 a barrel before the war

in Iran started late February. That also came after the International Energy Agency said Wednesday that supply losses from the strait were "depleting global oil inventories at a record pace". Benchmark US crude was down 0.2 per cent to \$100.86 per barrel. Investors are also watching for updates on China's imports of Nvidia's advanced H200 chips, after Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang was confirmed to be a part of Trump's China trip alongside other top executives including Tesla's Elon Musk and Apple's Tim Cook. The US business leaders met with Chinese Premier Li Qiang Thursday afternoon. On Wednesday, technology stocks led Wall Street gains. The benchmark S&P 500 climbed 0.6 per cent to 7,444.25 and reached another all-time high. The Dow Jones Industrial Average edged down 0.1 per cent to 49,693.20,

while the technology-heavy Nasdaq composite rose 1.2 per cent to 26,402.34 and set its own record. In other dealings, the yield on the US 10-year Treasury edged down to 4.46 per cent from 4.47 per cent though still significantly above around 3.97 per cent from before the Iran war began. A report Wednesday showed that US wholesale prices surged in April, fuelled by impacts from the Iran war-caused energy shock. On Wednesday, the US Senate also confirmed Kevin Warsh, Trump's nominee, to lead the Federal Reserve. He would be take over from Jerome Powell, who had been criticised by Trump repeatedly for not cutting rates faster or deeper. The US dollar rose to 157.91 Japanese yen from 157.86 yen. The euro was trading at \$1.1709, down from \$1.1711. (AP)

FROM THE WORLD

ISRAEL

Minister criticises Spanish teen

Israel's defence minister has criticised Barcelona's teenage star Lamine Yamal for his waving of a Palestinian flag during celebrations of the Spanish league title win, saying the act "incites hate." "Lamine Yamal chose to incite hate against Israel while our soldiers combat the terrorist organisation Hamas, an organisation that massacred, raped and burned Jewish children, women and the elderly on October 7, (2023)" minister Israel Katz wrote on X on Thursday. The 18-year-old Yamal waved a large Palestinian flag from an open-top bus during a victory parade by Barcelona's team through the city on Monday. The parade drew some 7,50,000 people to celebrate the league title clinched the previous day, local authorities said. Yamal, who is Muslim, posted pictures of him holding the flag on his Instagram account. Spain's government and a large part of its population have been highly critical of Israel's military operations that killed tens of thousands of Palestinians in Gaza in response to the 2023 Hamas surprise attack. There has been a global backlash against Israel over the humanitarian toll of the war in Gaza, which has spread to sport and culture.

SAMYA KULLAB/
VASILISA STEPANENKO
■ Kyiv

Russia on Thursday unleashed a third straight day of massive drone and missile attacks on Ukraine, demolishing an apartment building in Kyiv where seven people were killed and dozens injured, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said. More strikes elsewhere in the country wounded more than two dozen civilians. As dawn broke on a clear day in Kyiv, a scene of devastation came into focus in the capital's leafy Darnytsia neighbourhood, located between a suburban forest and the Dnieper River. Wisps of smoke rose from the collapsed nine-storey apartment block, where emergency workers dug under concrete slabs and took people away on stretchers. The building's entrance was smashed in

the strike, preventing residents from escaping. All 18 apartments in the building were destroyed, officials said. Among the dead was a 12-year-old girl, Mayor Vitali Klitschko said. Zelenskyy said seven people were killed, with at least 20 people believed to be missing. Klitschko declared Friday to be a day of mourning for the victims. Ukrainian officials noted that the attack coincided with US President Donald Trump's trip to China. Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha said Trump and Chinese leader Xi Jinping have sufficient leverage to compel Russian President Vladimir Putin to end his 4-year-old invasion of Ukraine. "At the very time when leaders of the most powerful countries are meeting in Beijing and the world hopes for peace, predictability and cooperation, Putin launched



Rescuers clear the rubble after a Russian missile hit an apartment building during massive air attack in Kyiv AP

hundreds of drones, ballistic and cruise missiles at the capital of Ukraine," Sybiha

wrote on X. "Only pressure on Moscow can make him stop," Sybiha said of Putin.

Russia fired ballistic and cruise missiles in the attack, Zelenskyy said, adding that

Israeli drone strikes on vehicles in Lebanon kill 12

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Beirut

Israeli airstrikes on Wednesday struck seven vehicles in Lebanon — three of them on the main highway just south of Beirut—killing 12 people including a woman and her two children, the Lebanese Health Ministry said. The Israeli military said it struck Hezbollah infrastructure in several areas in southern Lebanon, hours after telling residents of six southern villages to evacuate. Lebanon and Israel are scheduled to hold another round of direct talks in Washington on Thursday as the Trump administration



pushes for a breakthrough between the two neighbours that have been in a state of war since Israel was created

in 1948. The United Nations has also accused Hezbollah of drone strikes near its peace-keeping forces in southern

Lebanon, and Secretary-General Antonio Guterres' message to both sides is that they must observe the ceasefire and stop all attacks, UN deputy spokesperson Farhan Haq said. The Health Ministry confirmed the seven airstrikes on vehicles, but didn't provide full details of the number of people in each vehicle. Two of Wednesday's drone attacks hit a highway linking Beirut with the southern port city of Sidon, while a third struck the town of Saadiyat near the busy freeway, the state-run National news agency said. The Health Ministry said those strikes killed eight people in total, including the mother and children. A fourth strike took place in the early afternoon near the northern entrance of Sidon, leaving one person dead and another wounded, the ministry said. It added that three other drone strikes on cars deeper in southern Lebanon killed three people. An Associated Press photographer saw the bodies of three people killed in two of the strikes near the coastal towns of Barja and Jijeh. In southern Lebanon, Israeli airstrikes were

reported in various towns and villages while Hezbollah claimed that it launched additional attacks on Israel as both sides keep exchanging fire despite a US-brokered ceasefire on April 17. Hezbollah also has been using drones in its attacks on Israeli forces. The UN peacekeeping force deployed in southern Lebanon known as UNIFIL said Wednesday it is increasingly concerned about fighting between Hezbollah and Israeli soldiers near its positions, putting peacekeepers at risk, including with explosions of drones in and around UN bases. UNIFIL said that a presumed Hezbollah drone detonated inside its headquarters in the coastal town of Naqoura on Tuesday, following earlier presumed Hezbollah drone detonations on Monday and Tuesday. No one was injured, but some buildings were damaged. The latest Israel-Hezbollah war started on March 2, when the Lebanese militant group fired rockets into northern Israel two days after the United States and Israel attacked Iran. The Health Ministry said Wednesday that since the war began, 2,896 have been killed and 8,824 wounded.

Dominican Opposition criticises deal with US to take third-country deportees



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Santo Domingo

Opposition figures in the Dominican Republic on Wednesday criticised an agreement signed with the United States to have the Caribbean nation receive third-country deportees, saying it lacks transparency and violates national sovereignty. The non-binding memorandum of understanding, which was announced on Tuesday by the Dominican Foreign Ministry, said the country will accept the temporary entry of a limited number of third-country nationals without criminal records before they return to their home countries.

The deal is the latest such agreement between the Trump administration and some countries in Latin America and Africa that has come under fire. The third-country deportations, costing millions of dollars, are part of US President Donald Trump's immigration crackdown that includes deporting migrants to countries other than their own. "This agreement represents a surrender of our national sovereignty," Manolo Pichardo, from the opposition Fuerza del Pueblo party, told The Associated Press. "It subordinates Dominican interests to the geopolitical priorities of major Western powers and their strategic allies," Pichardo added.

NORTHERN RAILWAY

OPEN TENDER NOTICE

The Director/Admin, Northern Railway Central Hospital, New Delhi-110055, for and on behalf of the President of India invites sealed open electronic-tenders for under noted work :-

S. No.	Name of work	Approximate cost of work	Earnest money to be deposited	Completion period	Date of opening
1	Supply of portable water through tankers at NRCH for one year in the section of SSE/W/ NRCH under ADEN/NRCH.	Rs. 1699907.88	Rs. 34000/-	12 Months	09.06.2026

The e-tender is to be submitted through railway website www.ireps.gov.in. The tenders can be submitted on website up to 15:00 hrs. on 09.06.2026 and shall be opened there after. NO: 128-W-269-O.E.T.-03-26-27-NRCH Date:-14.05.2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

1619/2026

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Venus W/o Pradeep Chandel R/o Flat No. 505, Raisan Armor Homes, Indirapuram, Ghaziabad have changed my name to Venus Chandel for all future purposes.

I, Shakunthalamma, Mother of No. 2620718P Nk Chinnaraju K, R/o- 145, Muthanuru PO- Gullahalli, Dist- Kolar, Karnataka- 563129, have changed my name from Shakunthalamma to Sukunthala, vide affidavit dated 14/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1106)C I, ZAKIR HUSSAIN S/o. Sher Mohammad, R/o.1065, Ward No. 7, Mehrauli, New Delhi-110030, have declared that my name was mentioned in my documents as ZAKIR HUSSAN instead of my actual name, ZAKIR HUSSAIN.

PD(1107)C I, No.16016837M Hav Chandrabhan Sirsat, R/o- Pant Nagar, Malkapur, Buldhana, Maharashtra- 443101, have changed my daughter's name from Krutika to Krutika Chandrabhan Sirsat, vide affidavit dated 14/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1108)C I, Bhateri Devi, Mother of No.16022631L Hav Vikram R/o- H.No. 269, Makho Soran Sirsa, Haryana- 125110, have changed my name from Bhateri Devi to Bhateri, vide affidavit dated 14/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1109)C I, Jhamu Devi, Mother of No.16026350M Nk Hukma Ram R/o- Karwasra Ki Dhani Bhainsar Chawandiyali, PO- Bhainsar Chawandiyali, RS- Mathaniya, Dist- Jodhpur, Rajasthan- 342305, have changed my name from Jhamu Devi to Jamu Devi, vide affidavit dated 14/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1110)C I, Suraj Bhan, Father of No. 14449918N BHM Dharmender, R/o- Vill/PO- Jhoju Kalan, Teh/Dist- Charkhi Dadri, Haryana- 127310, have changed my name from Suraj Bhan to Surajbhan, vide affidavit dated 14/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1111)C

PUBLIC NOTICE
We Mr. Dinesh Malhotra S/O late Laxmi Narayan Malhotra, and Mrs. Sunita Malhotra W/O Dinesh Malhotra R/O 192/1, East Model Town, Sulaxmi Niwas, District Ghaziabad hereby disown and evict our son Karan Malhotra, daughter-in-law Geetika Malhotra and their children from all our movable and immovable properties due to their bad conduct, and severe all relations and dissociate myself from them. In future they will have no right and relation with us or our assets. Henceforth, they will be solely responsible for their own actions. Neither us nor our family shall bear any responsibility for them and their transactions or behaviour in the future.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mrs. Poonam to inform the public at large that Smt. Poonam is purchasing the Ground Floor (without roof rights), built-up Property Bearing No. WZ-130, B, area measuring 42 sq. yards, out of Kharsa No. 31/8, situated in the revenue estate of Village Khyalla, colony known as Vishnu Garden, Delhi - 110018, from Smt. Nirmal Kaur, who became the owner through Relinquishment Deed dated 25.01.2024 (Document No. 2024/22/11008). The said property will be financed and mortgaged by Aditya Birla Housing Finance Ltd. It is stated that SMC issued by concerned authority reflecting the names of Shri Sewa Singh, Shri Gurcharan Singh (sons), Smt. Nirmal Kaur (wife) and Smt. Harpreet Kaur (daughter) as legal heirs of Late Gurmaj Singh is lost and FIR for the same Lodged vide FIR dated 23-04-2026. Therefore to comply with the requirements of the BANK/NBFC, this public notice is issued. If any person has any type of claim, right, interest or has created any mortgage over the said property, they are requested to inform in writing along with their objections, at the address mentioned below within 10 days from today. Failing which, it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all types of encumbrances. Lucem Legal LLP B-93B, Second Floor, Opp. SBI Bank Sector 2, Noida, UP-201301 Contact No. 120-2693737

NORTHERN RAILWAY

OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE

Invitation of tender through E-Tendering (E-Prorurement Systems) The Divisional Engineer-IV, Northern Railway, Delhi Division for and on behalf of President of India invites E-Tender on prescribed form for the following work:-

Name of work with its location	Setting up of Bio toilet testing lab at Jind Coaching Depot, (NIT 10-2026-27-W-IV)
Approx. Cost of work	₹20,95,944.06
Earnest Money	₹41,900/-

Date and Time of submission of tender and opening of tender

Bidding Start date for work No. Up to 15:00 hrs. on 22.05.2026 opening of e-Tender at 15:00 hrs. on 05.06.2026.

Website particulars, published e-tender, notice location etc. complete details of tender can be seen and website where the tender form can be downloaded

Above tender available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in

No.: 128-W/260/Tendering/NIT10/2026-27-W-IV Dated: 14.05.2026 1623/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

CUBICAL FINANCIAL SERVICES LIMITED

Regd. Office-456, Aggarwal Metro Height, Netaji Subhash Singh, Pitam

website : www.cubical90.com

CIN-L65993DL1990PLC040101

E-mail : cubfinser@yahoo.com (Rs. In Lacs)

Extract of the statement of Audited Financial Results for the Quarter/year ended March 31, 2026

Sl. No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended 31-03-2026 (Audited)	Quarter Ended 31-03-2025 (Audited)	Year Ended 31-03-2026 (Audited)	Year Ended 31-03-2025 (Audited)
1	Total Income from operations	27.2	33.76	130.59	241.99
2	Profit/(Loss) for the period before tax	13.8	12.94	32.15	67.82
3	Net Profit / Loss for the period after tax	6.91	-5.78	17.43	37.54
4	Equity Share Capital	1303.4	1303.4	1303.4	1303.4
5	Reserves excluding Revaluation Reserve			224.08	206.44
6	Earnings Per Share (EPS) (Of Rs. 2/- each)				
	Basic Diluted		0.03 0.03	0.06 0.06	

Note:- The above is an Extract of the Detailed Format of Quarterly Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The Full Format of the Quarterly Financial Results is available on the Website of Bombay Stock Exchange at www.bseindia.com & on Company website at www.cubicalcreators.com.

By Order of the Board of Directors for CUBICAL FINANCIAL SERVICES LIMITED

Sd/-
ASHWANI KUMAR GUPTA
MANAGING DIRECTOR
DIN-00348616

DATED : 14TH May, 2026
PLACE : DELHI.

CCCL

Central Coalfields Limited

"A Miniratna Company"
(A Subsidiary of Coal India Limited)

NOTICE

"All the tenders issued by CIL and its Subsidiaries for procurement of Goods, Works and Services are available on website of Coal India Ltd. www.coalindia.in/ respective Subsidiary Company (CCL, www.centralcoalfields.in), CIL e-procurement portal <https://coalindiatenders.nic.in> and Central Public Procurement Portal <https://eprocure.gov.in> in addition, procurement is also done through GeM portal <https://gem.gov.in>".

सेंट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया

Central Bank of India

1911 से आपके लिए "केन्द्रित" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911

BRANCH OFFICE: DELHI CANTONMENT, NEW DELHI

POSSESSION NOTICE (For Immovable Property)
[Under Rule 8(1) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002]

Whereas, the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of the Central Bank of India, Delhi Cantonment Branch, New Delhi under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued a Demand Notice dated 29.02.2020, Calling upon the Borrowers: MR. SURESH KUMAR S/O SHRI DHIV DAYAL, MRS. RAJBALA W/O MR. SURESH KUMAR, to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being Rs.10,97,296.08 (Rupees Ten Lakh Ninety Seven Thousand Two Hundred Ninety Six and Eight Paise Only) (which represents the principal plus interest due as on the 29.02.2020), plus interest and other charges from 01.03.2020 to till date within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The Borrower having failed to repay the amount, Notice is hereby given to the borrower, the Guarantor and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rule 2002 on this 13th Day of May 2026.

The borrower and the Guarantor in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealing with the property will be subject to the charge of the Central Bank of India, Delhi Cantonment Branch, New Delhi for Rs.10,97,296.08 (Rupees Ten Lakh Ninety Seven Thousand Two Hundred Ninety Six and Eight Paise Only) (which represents the principal plus interest due as on the 29.02.2020), plus interest and other charges from 01.03.2020.

The Borrower's attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section (13) of the Act, in respect of the time available, to redeem the secured assets.

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

All the parts and parcel of property consisting of Flat on Third Floor (without Roof Right) area measuring 61 yards, built on Property Bearing House No.H-2/162 C (Out of Kharsa No.79/12), main 33 Futa Road, Mahavir Enclave, Palam New Delhi within the registration Sub-District New Delhi and District New Delhi Bounded By:

North: Other's Property South: Road
East: Road West: Other's Property

PLACE: NEW DELHI (Authorised Officer),
DATE: 13/05/2026 Central Bank of India

DEREK GATOPOULOS/
COSTAS KANTOURIS
■ Athens

Greece says a new biometric screening system at airports for non-European Union citizens is fully operational, rejecting reports of a formal summer exemption for British travellers. But busy airports will be allowed to shut off scanners when needed this summer, officials say.

"We have not received any further update or clarification as to whether, for example, specific nationalities are temporarily exempt from the relevant procedure," the Foreign Ministry said Thursday in response to a question from The Associated Press.

The EU Entry-Exit System or EES began operating at Greek airports and other entry points on April 10 as part of a Europe-wide rollout, replacing passport stamps with biometric data collected through photographs and digital fingerprints. Greek officials visiting the UK had earlier suggested the requirement would be waived this summer for trav-

ellers from Britain, an important market for Greece's tourism industry.

Current travel guidance from the UK Foreign Office states: "Greek authorities have indicated that they will not collect biometric data (fingerprints and photos) for UK travellers as part of EES. Follow the advice of authorities on the ground."

But European and Greek authorities later clarified that suspension of the system is permitted only during periods of high passenger traffic at specific entry points and does not apply to any country or nationality. In practice, however, many travellers are still likely to pass through airports without the new biometric checks, as EU rules allow temporary suspensions during the early stages of implementation. Last week, Greek police described the digital entry system as being in "full operation," but said they would take "all necessary measures to ensure the smooth flow of visitors... making full use of provisions in (European) Union legislation". (AP)

UK health secretary's resignation piles pressure on PM Starmer

ADITI KHANNA
■ London

UK Health Secretary Wes Streeting resigned from the Cabinet on Thursday, declaring that he had lost confidence in the leadership of Prime Minister Keir Starmer.

As a frontrunner to replace Starmer at 10 Downing Street, Streeting is expected to launch his bid to be elected Labour leader if he can secure the backing of the party's requisite 81 members of Parliament.

It piles further pressure on Starmer, who has been attempting to quell an internal rebellion over the devastating results for the governing party in last week's local elections.

"It is now clear that you will not lead the Labour Party into the next general election and that Labour MPs and Labour unions want the debate about what comes next to be a battle of ideas, not of personalities or petty factionalism," Streeting said in his resignation letter



Keir Starmer

addressed to Starmer.

"It needs to be broad, and it needs to be the best possible field of candidates. I support that approach, and I hope you will facilitate it," he said. The former minister accused his boss of lacking any vision and overseeing a power "vacuum" and also went on to highlight his own record of leading the Department for Health and Social Care and the state-funded National Health Service (NHS).

Streeting added: "The National Health Service is the

embodiment of all that is best about Britain and our values. Thanks to our Labour government, it is on the road to recovery: lots done, but so much more to do.

"These are all good reasons for me to remain in post, but as you know from our conversation earlier this week, having lost confidence in your leadership, I have concluded that it would be dishonourable and unprincipled to do so."

His words are being interpreted as paving the way for a Labour leadership contest,

with former deputy prime minister Angela Rayner, Mayor of Greater Manchester Andy Burnham and Energy Secretary Ed Miliband among his other expected rivals.

While some indications are that this process may not be triggered any time soon, Starmer's future as Labour leader is looking extremely tenuous if the party's National Executive Committee (NEC) gets involved in a formal election process.

Meanwhile, Rayner issued a statement earlier to confirm that she had been cleared by the UK tax authorities of any wrongdoing over her financial affairs that had forced her to step down from the Cabinet last year.

"I took reasonable care and acted in good faith, based on the expert advice I received, and HMRC [His Majesty's Revenue and Customs] has accepted this," she said.

This is seen as her declaring her intention to be ready to join the fray, should a Labour leadership election be launched. (PTI)

Hungary summons Russian ambassador to protest attack in Ukraine near its border

BELA SZANDELSZKY/
SAM MCNEIL
■ Budapest

Hungary has summoned the Russian ambassador over a massive drone attack near Hungary's border with Ukraine, marking a stark shift of tone by new Prime Minister Peter Magyar toward Moscow after years of cozy relations with the Kremlin under former Hungarian leader Viktor Orban.

The ambassador, Evgeny Stanislavov, is expected to arrive at the Foreign Ministry around noon Thursday to speak with Hungarian Foreign Minister Anita Orban about strikes that hit the Ukrainian region of Transcarpathia on Wednesday.

The region is home to a sizeable Hungarian minority. "The Hungarian government strongly condemns the Russian attack on Transcarpathia," Magyar said on Wednesday during a press conference in southern Hungary when he



Prime Minister Peter Magyar

announced the summons.

"She will tell him the same and ask for information on when Russia and Vladimir Putin plan to finally end this bloody war that began more than four years ago," the prime minister added.

The Russian government has not made any public statements on the summons. Russia fired at least 800 drones in a massive daytime barrage on Wednesday targeting about 20 regions of Ukraine, including Transcarpathia, Ukrainian President

Volodymyr Zelenskyy said. It killed at least six people and wounded dozens, including children. Lasting hours, it was one of the longest-lasting attacks by Moscow in the war now in its fifth year.

Zelenskyy called the summons in Budapest an "important message" and thanked Magyar for his comments. "Moscow has once again shown itself to be a common threat not only to Ukraine, but also to neighbouring countries and Europe as a whole," Zelenskyy said on social

media. After defeating Orban in a historic vote in April, Magyar has vowed to undo much of the legacy built during Orban's 16 years in power, with a particular focus on alleged corruption.

The summons marks a stunning change after years of close relations between Hungary - both a member of the European Union and NATO - and Moscow, even following the 2022 full-scale invasion of Ukraine.

In March, the Russian ambassador Stanislavov posted on Facebook an open letter to Magyar denying Moscow was involved in helping long-time Kremlin ally Orban. "It's really not worth scaring Hungarians with imaginary Russian threats," he wrote.

"The embassy has clear objectives: to ensure the maintenance of normal bilateral relations, to develop mutually beneficial cooperation in the current situation where possible, and to protect the interests of citizens of Russia and Hungary." (AP)

US-Iran war created significant hurdles for regional economies: Pakistan PM

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Islamabad

Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif on Thursday said that the US-Iran war has created significant hurdles for regional economies, including Pakistan, as he urged people to make concerted efforts to transform the country into an economic power.

PM Shehbaz made the comments in his televised opening remarks at the federal cabinet meeting, where he also talked about May 28, 1998, when Pakistan carried out nuclear tests.

Referring to the US-Iran conflict, he said that while a temporary ceasefire was currently in place, the war had created significant hurdles for regional economies, including Pakistan.

He said that the government's economic team had made collective efforts over the past two years. "This is a long and difficult journey. However, nations that commit to facing and over-



Shehbaz Sharif

coming their challenges are the ones that ultimately meet with success," he said. He said that just as Pakistan had become a nuclear power, "we have to turn it into an economic power with the same commitment and hard work".

Shehbaz also said that Pakistan gained a power that would remain a "defensive asset" of the country.

"It is our national narrative that this asset is for defence, not offence. And this is the reason that the world knows Pakistan as a

responsible nuclear power," he said.

The premier also paid tribute to those who contributed to efforts for making Pakistan a nuclear power, particularly mentioning late prime minister Zulfikar Ali Bhutto and former prime minister and the Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz (PML-N) chief Nawaz Sharif.

Shehbaz also spoke about the four-day conflict with India in May last year and said Pakistan's armed forces fought bravely and courageously. (PTI)

Philippine senator wanted by ICC flees from Senate

JIM GOMEZ
■ Manila

A Philippine senator wanted by the International Criminal Court (ICC) for an alleged crime against humanity has fled from the Senate, where he sought refuge to evade arrest, officials said Thursday.

Sen. Ronald dela Rosa's exit from the heavily guarded Senate came after volleys of gunshots were fired Wednesday night by the building's security personnel during an argument with a government agent, sparking chaos that apparently helped the senator to slip out.

President Ferdinand Marcos Jr made a late-night TV statement to ask the public to remain calm. A police investigation was underway, including into suspicions that the incident was instigated to provide dela Rosa a cover to escape.

"There is no obstruction of justice," Senate President Alan Cayetano said of dela Rosa's escape while in the Senate's protective custody.

He told a news briefing that he did not see any ICC warrant of arrest against dela Rosa and the senator was free



to leave the premises.

Critics, however, said Cayetano and the Senate's security chief should be held responsible for dela Rosa's escape. Dela Rosa, 64, served as the former national police chief of Rodrigo Duterte, who was president from 2016 to 2022. Duterte was arrested in March last year on a ICC warrant for alleged crimes against humanity in connection with deadly anti-drugs crackdowns he launched and for which he is now facing a trial in The Hague.

A warrant unsealed Monday by the ICC charges dela Rosa with the crime against humanity of murder

of "no less than 32 persons" between July 2016 and the end of April 2018, when he led the national police force under Duterte and enforced his bloody crackdowns.

Dela Rosa and Duterte have separately denied authorising extrajudicial killings although the former president has openly threatened drug suspects with death while he was in office.

Dela Rosa's legal predicament came as political disputes escalated between the Duterte family and Marcos. Vice President Sara Duterte, the former president's daughter, has blamed Marcos for what she said was the "kid-

Bangladesh police arrest six Chinese nationals over cyber fraud

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dhaka

Six Chinese nationals were among nine persons arrested on charges of cyber fraud and illegal online financial transactions in Bangladesh on Thursday, police said.

"These Chinese nationals are mostly young and possess advanced IT knowledge. They used to target Bangladeshis through different online advertisements, luring them into their fraudulent schemes," Dhaka Police's detective branch chief Shafiqul Islam told reporters at his office here.

Islam said the accused used to collect money through Bangladeshi financial transaction platforms and immediately transfer the funds abroad.

The group, which also included three Bangladeshis, initially offered profits to attract users before exposing them to financial losses.

UAE denies Netanyahu secretly visited the country during Iran war

NATALIE MELZER/
ADAM SCHRECK
■ Jerusalem

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu secretly visited the United Arab Emirates during the Israeli-US war with Iran, further strengthening ties with a Gulf nation that normalised relations with Israel in 2020, his office said Wednesday. The UAE denied any secret visit had occurred.

Netanyahu met with UAE President Sheikh Mohammed bin Zayed Al Nahyan in a gathering that "resulted in a historic breakthrough in relations between Israel and the United Arab Emirates", according to the Israeli statement. The UAE's official WAM news agency posted an article denying the report about a Netanyahu visit.

According to WAM, the country's relations with Israel "are public and conducted within the framework of the well-known and officially declared Abraham Accords and are not based on non-transparent or unofficial arrangements".

The report also denied any Israeli military delegation was received in the UAE. Israel's announcement came a day after US ambassador to Israel Mike Huckabee revealed that Israel had sent Iron Dome air-defence weapons and personnel to operate them to the UAE.

The UAE has faced Iranian missile and drone fire even after the ceasefire was reached last month. It has been trying to signal to nervous investors that it



Benjamin Netanyahu

remains open for business and safe. Last week, WAM reported that Netanyahu was among the leaders who called the Emirati president to condemn Iranian attacks and express their solidarity with the Gulf federation.

It was a rare public acknowledgement of direct talks between the countries that normalised relations in the 2020 Abraham Accords and have strengthened their ties during the Iran war. Iran has criticised that agreement and has repeatedly suggested over the years that Israel maintained a military and intelligence presence in the Emirates. Israeli leaders have made occasional visits to the UAE in recent years after normalising relations.

Iran's foreign minister accused Kuwait of attempting to "sow discord" by detaining four Iranians that the Gulf Arab country accuses of being Revolutionary Guard operatives. In a post Wednesday on X, Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi demanded the Iranians' immediate release and said Iran reserved the right to respond.

"This illegal act took place near an island used by the US to attack Iran," Araghchi wrote. A day earlier, Kuwait said four men were detained and two escaped while trying to infiltrate Bubiyan Island in the northwest corner of the Persian Gulf on May 1. Bubiyan Island is home to Mubarak Al Kabeer Port, which is under construction as part of a Chinese plan to build infrastructure across the world. It also came under Iranian attack during the war.

Prominent Iranian human rights lawyer Nasrin Sotoudeh has been released from prison more than a month after being detained, a rights group and her daughter said Wednesday. Sotoudeh, who is known for defending activists, opposition politicians and women prosecuted for removing their headscarves, was detained by Iranian intelligence agents at her house in Tehran in April.

Her release comes as US President Donald Trump arrived in China for a long-anticipated visit that is expected to touch on the war in Iran. (AP)

Vance set to speak in Maine about fraud investigations

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Bangor (Maine)

Vice President JD Vance is slated to make an appearance in Maine on Thursday to highlight the Trump administration's efforts to combat fraud ahead of the state's primary elections for several high-profile races.

Vance, who chairs the administration's anti-fraud task force, is scheduled to deliver remarks at Bangor International Airport, the White House and the Maine Republican Party announced. The vice president, who is seen as a potential GOP candidate for pres-



JD Vance

ident in 2028, has been promoting the work of the task force as he has campaigned for Republican candidates in recent months. But

Thursday's visit is the first that has been expressly billed as a stop to talk about the fraud-fighting efforts rather than an economic-

focused message he's delivered in other visits.

Vance's pitch on President Donald Trump's economic policies has become tougher in the wake of the Iran war, which has driven up costs of gas and other goods, including food.

The visit to Maine comes after the Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services Administrator Dr. Mehmet Oz said earlier in the year that he was calling for corrective action on alleged fraud in government health programs in Maine, a request characterized by the state's Democratic governor, Janet Mills, as a "political attack."

Malaysia slams Norway for revoking export licence for naval missile system

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Kuala Lumpur

Malaysian Prime Minister Anwar Ibrahim on Thursday condemned Norway's move to revoke the export licence for a naval missile system for Malaysia's navy, warning it could damage confidence in European defence suppliers.

Anwar said he raised Malaysia's "vehement objection" during a phone call with Norwegian Prime Minister Jonas Gahr Støre, after Oslo blocked delivery of the Naval Strike Missile system and launcher components intended for Malaysia's littoral combat ship programme.

"Malaysia has honoured every obligation under this contract since 2018: scrupulously, faithfully and without



Malaysian Prime Minister Anwar Ibrahim

equivocation," Anwar said in a statement. "Norway, it appears, has not felt compelled to extend us the same courtesy and demonstration of good faith."

The missile manufacturer, Kongsberg Defence & Aerospace AS, said export licensing decisions are handled entirely by

Norwegian authorities, according to Malaysian national news agency Bernama. The Norwegian government hasn't made any public comments on the cancellation of the missile system or Anwar's remarks.

Malaysian Defence Minister Mohamed Khaled

Nordin told local media that the government had already paid nearly 95 per cent of the contract value when Oslo blocked delivery in March.

The NSM anti-ship missile system was meant to equip Malaysia's new class of littoral combat ships as part of its modernisation efforts.

Anwar said Oslo's move would hurt Malaysia's operational readiness and "undoubtedly carry broader ramifications for the regional balance."

He questioned the reliability of European defence suppliers if signed agreements could be reversed unilaterally. "Signed contracts are solemn instruments. They are not confetti to be scattered in so capricious a manner," the Malaysian leader said.

PAKISTAN TEST FIRES FATAH-4 CRUISE MISSILE



SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Islamabad

Pakistan on Thursday successfully test-fired the indigenously developed Fatah-4 ground-launched cruise missile capable of engaging long-range targets with high precision, the army said.

The launch was organised by the Rocket Force Command, according to a statement issued by the Inter-Services Public Relations (ISPR), the media wing of the military. "Equipped with advanced avionics and state-of-the-art navigational aids, the weapon system is capable of engaging long-range targets with high precision," the army said. The missile was test-fired to enhance operational efficiency of the troops and validate technical parameters of various sub-systems incorporated for improved accuracy and enhanced survivability, it said.

President Asif Ali Zardari, Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, Army Chief Field Marshal Asim Munir and other services chiefs commended the successful training fire of the missile.

Last month, the Army Rocket Force Command conducted a training launch of the indigenously developed Fateh-2 missile system.

PROSPECT

Arvind Kumar takes charge as Director (Finance) at NFL

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida

National Fertilizers Limited (NFL), a Navratna Public Sector Enterprise under the Ministry of Chemicals & Fertilizers, Government of India, has appointed Arvind Kumar as its Director (Finance).

Before assuming the new role at NFL, Kumar held senior leadership positions in the finance functions of Indian Oil Corporation Limited and Hindustan Urvarak&Rasayan Limited.



Kumar holds a Master of Commerce (M.Com.) degree and is a Fellow Member of the Institute of Cost Accountants of India. He is also an Associate Member of the Institute of Company Secretaries of India.

Ujjivan CMO: Banking’s fight now on reliability, not digital flash

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India’s banking sector is shifting focus from digital interfaces to operational efficiency and service reliability as key differentiators, said Lakshman Velayutham, Chief Marketing Officer at Ujjivan Small Finance Bank.

Customer experience has become table stakes across banks and fintechs, he noted, but true competitive advantage lies in “Business Experience” (BX) — robust backend systems ensuring

consistent service delivery. BX rests on three pillars: employee enablement, compliance strength, and partner ecosystem efficiency.

Process automation can streamline lending workflows, while cybersecurity investments safeguard customer trust. Data-driven decisions will prove vital for serving MSMEs and first-time borrowers. “In banking, reliability trumps flashy innovation. Institutions with secure, efficient, and resilient backends will lead the sector,” Velayutham said.

Art of giving: Global movement for peace, happiness



ACHYUTA SAMANTA

“Art of Giving” or the philosophy of giving, is a way of life that inspires millions across the world with compassion, kindness, love, and social harmony. It helps establish and spread fundamental human values. This philosophy is not a new invention or discovery; it is deeply rooted in human nature, eternal and universal. It represents the awakening and expression of the divinity within oneself. The foundation of “Art of Giving” lies in selfless giving that spreads happiness, peace, love, and joy in society. If every individual embraces this spirit, the world can become more beautiful and liveable.

I feel extremely happy and grateful that the small initiative and mission started by me has now transformed into a major global movement. Beginning on May 17, 2013, this journey has now spread across 222 countries.

Every year, May 17 is celebrated as the International “Art of Giving” Day. The ever-expanding scale, geography, and participation in this movement continue to inspire us. Today, the “Art of Giving” family has over three million active members. From villages to metropolitan cities, across all continents and 222 countries, people irrespective of caste, religion, gender, nationality, profession, or age have become part of this mission. Students, senior citi-

zens, villagers, tribal communities, urban residents — everyone is connected through a common thread that celebrates humanity and life itself. It removes narrow boundaries and invokes the spirit of infinity. Through this, the universal nature of compassion and charity becomes evident. The realisation that the future belongs to light, happiness, and hope fills us with joy.

As I have often said, “Art of Giving” is essentially the practice of an eternal emotion. Long before this movement formally began, the feeling had already influenced me deeply during my childhood and adolescence.

It was not shaped by scriptures but by life itself. I learned this lesson naturally from my life experiences and surroundings.

My childhood and youth were marked by extreme poverty, helplessness, and hardship. At times when I possessed almost nothing to give, this philosophy enlightened me. Whenever I gave even a little to someone — whether emotionally or materially — I never felt poorer; rather, I experienced immense joy and fulfilment, something priceless and indescribable. Gradually, this became part of my way of life. Selfless giving became my life’s mission.

As a child, I had heard the famous Odia line “Deithile Pai” (“By giving, one receives”), and I could truly understand its essence. In reality, giving does not diminish; it multiplies. The practical application and explanation of this realisation during my youth ultimately shaped “Art of Giving” into a people’s movement, which gives me immense sat-

isfaction. Based on my experiences and realisations, a book written by me and published by Rupa Publications titled “Art of Giving – The Way of Life” was released last year, and its overwhelming readership deeply moved me.

Every year, “Art of Giving” selects a theme according to the needs and challenges of society.

- 2014 Theme: Society, Spirituality and Humanity
- 2015 Theme: Compassion: Cloth Bank — encouraging donation of old clothes



- 2016 Theme: Gratitude — encouraging both inward and outward expressions of thankfulness
- 2017 Theme: Psychological Well-being — spreading awareness on health and harmony
- 2018 Theme: “Pyarabhara Pack” — over 20 million food packets distributed nationwide
- Bag of Happiness Initiative: Volunteers shared happiness with underprivileged children
- 2020 Theme: Fight Against Corona — support and assistance to families affected by COVID-19 and frontline workers

- 2021 Theme: “My Mother — My Inspiration” — emotional letters of gratitude written by children to their mothers
 - 2022 Theme: Hope, Happiness and Harmony
 - 2023 Theme: “Helping the Helpers” — showing sensitivity and gratitude towards domestic workers and caregivers
 - 2024 Theme: “Higher Humanity — In Thought and Consciousness”
- Current Theme: “Share to Shine” — prosperity through participation, mutual love, empathy, and harmony leading to individual and social upliftment.
- I hope this movement will inspire self-reflection, self-realisation, and collective awakening globally. Generosity, which is the soul and spirit of “Art of Giving,” is a priceless treasure of our culture. Charity has been glorified in every religion and faith.
- The Bhagavad Gita says: “Datavyam iti yad danam diyate anupakarine,
- Deshe kale cha patre cha tad danam sattvikam smritam.” Meaning: Charity given selflessly at the right place, time, and to a deserving person without expecting anything in return is considered pure and noble charity.
- According to the Gita, working for the welfare of others, remaining cheerful, and considering the donated object as belonging to the recipient, are all forms of true giving. Charity done for selfish gain reflects a lower nature. It is often said that one virtuous act of charity earns a thousandfold merit. Great donors like Karna and Harishchandra are remembered

forever for their generosity. Islam emphasises Zakat, Christianity teaches charity, Buddhism advocates compassion, Jainism encourages spreading knowledge and protecting life, Judaism and Zoroastrianism promote helping the poor.

Thus, “Art of Giving” is the modern expression of these timeless ideals and values. It is not merely a one-day celebration but a continuous celebration of life. It encourages service and generosity in countless forms. Giving goes beyond material things; it is an expression of emotion and humanity. One may help through a smile, comforting words, emotional support, or kindness. This spirit can manifest through countless means and forms. That is the essence and goal of “Art of Giving.”

“Art of Giving” is not run through any institutional structure or administrative system. It is entirely voluntary and driven by individuals. The inspiring aspect is that volunteers throughout the year continue to implement this spirit through various activities. This news strengthens our faith and motivation further.

On the occasion of the 13th International “Art of Giving” Day, I pray that the timeless journey of love, respect, compassion, cooperation, goodwill, and humanity becomes stronger and more fruitful across the world. May the spirit of generosity inherent in human nature shine ever brighter.

The writer is a Founder of KIIT, KISS, KIMS and Art of Giving

IRFC posts strong FY26 performance, diversification push drives record AUM, higher margins, robust PAT

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Indian Railway Finance Corporation Limited (IRFC), a Navratna CPSE under the Ministry of Railways, reported a strong financial performance for FY 2025-26, marking its first full year of strategic diversification.

The company recorded a 7.80 per cent rise in annual profit after tax (PAT) with positive revenue growth, net worth raising to all time high at ₹56,748 crore and assets under management (AUM) crossing an all-time high at ₹4.85 lakh crore.

The diversification-led expansion resulted in improved spreads and a consistent rise in net interest margin (NIM), while IRFC

maintained its pristine zero NPA status.

The company indicated that a steady pipeline and emerging opportunities in sectors such as metro and parts are expected to further accelerate growth in the coming financial year, following its whole-of-

Government approach.

Commenting on the performance, Manoj Kumar Dubey, Chairman & Managing Director, IRFC, said, “FY26 has been a defining year for IRFC. We have successfully built a diversified infrastructure financing platform while remaining firmly aligned to our core mandate of supporting infrastructure within the railway ecosystem. Our diversification strategy is now translating into stronger spreads, improved margins and enhanced shareholder value. IRFC has demonstrated its ability to compete effectively in the broader infrastructure financing market while maintaining financial prudence and its long-standing record of zero NPAs. As a Navratna CPSE,

IRFC has been entrusted with a larger responsibility in supporting nation-building infrastructure, and we are well-positioned to play a bigger strategic role in India’s infrastructure growth story.”

“The audited financial results for the quarter and year ended March 31, 2026 reflect a structural shift in IRFC’s business model, from a traditional railway financier to a diversified infrastructure financing institution keeping Railways at its Centre”, added Dubey.

Established in 1986 primarily to mobilise funds for Indian Railways, IRFC has, over the past year, recalibrated its operations in response to reduced reliance on its traditional lending model.

New Era Cleantech emerges as flagbearer in coal gasification

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As India accelerates its push towards energy security and industrial self-reliance, New Era Cleantech is emerging as one of the early frontrunners in the country’s coal gasification sector, buoyed by the Centre’s recently announced ₹37,500 crore support package aimed at boosting the industry.

The company is developing a large integrated coal gasification and carbon capture, utilisation and storage (CCUS) project in Chandrapur, Maharashtra, positioning itself at the heart of India’s next-generation clean manufacturing and fuel transition strategy.

The ambitious project, launched during a groundbreaking ceremony attended by Maharashtra Chief Minister



Devendra Fadnis and Union Coal and Mines Minister G. Kishan Reddy, is being developed in two phases with an estimated investment of nearly \$3 billion.

Founded and led by Balasaheb Darade, the company is positioning coal gasification not as a conventional fossil fuel project, but as a future-oriented industri-

al platform capable of converting domestic coal into methanol, hydrogen, synthetic fuels, fertilizers, chemicals and other strategic industrial feedstocks.

The development comes at a time when India is seeking to reduce its dependence on imported energy and industrial raw materials amid ongoing global supply chain disruptions and geopolitical uncertainty.

According to the company, the Centre’s policy push on coal gasification could help India reduce nearly ₹1.5 lakh crore worth of annual imports spanning LNG, methanol, fertilizers and industrial chemicals, while strengthening long-term industrial resilience.

Speaking on the opportunity, Balasaheb Darade described the government’s

coal gasification mission as a potentially transformative moment for the country’s industrial future.

He said the initiative could play a role comparable to the Green Revolution by helping India secure its energy, fertilizer and manufacturing ecosystem through large-scale utilisation of domestic resources.

New Era Cleantech has already secured nearly 1,650 acres of land for the Chandrapur project, along with access to a pit-head coal linkage, a critical factor in ensuring long-term fuel availability and cost efficiency.

The company has also received ₹1,100 crore in viability gap funding support from the Ministry of Coal under the Government of India’s coal gasification incentive scheme.

Saudi, UAE receive export consignment valued at ₹2.35 crore from Assam

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Assam has marked a significant milestone in its agro-forest economy with the first legally approved export of agarwood chips to Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates, opening a new chapter for an industry with vast global demand and strong revenue potential.

The consignment, comprising 100 kg of agarwood chips to Saudi Arabia and 12 kg to the UAE, was dispatched from the cargo terminal of Lokpriya Gopinath Bordoloi International Airport on Wednesday. The shipment was valued at ₹2.35 crore.

First export with full regulatory approval

The consignment was exported after securing all statutory clearances, including a CITES permit and a restricted export licence from the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT). The shipment was flagged off by Founder Chairman, MJI Group and Chairman, All Assam Agarwood Planters & Traders Association Dr Jehirul Islam, who described the event as a historic breakthrough for Assam’s indigenous agarwood sector. “This achievement is the result of years of research, policy advocacy, farmer engagement, plantation development, processing innovation and international compliance efforts,” Dr Islam said.

Premium product in global demand

Agarwood, also known as Oud, is one of the world’s most valuable aromatic raw materials and is widely used in luxury perfumes, incense, cosmetics and traditional prod-



ucts across the Gulf, Europe and Southeast Asia.

Assam-grown agarwood is highly valued for its superior quality, rich aroma and high oil content, giving the state a strong advantage in international markets. Industry stakeholders believe organised exports can generate substantial opportunities for farmers, nursery owners, distillation units, traders and small enterprises across Assam and the wider Northeast.

Policy support boosts organised trade

Dr Islam credited the Government of Assam and Government of India for facilitating the export and thanked Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma for supporting the implementation of the Assam Agarwood Promotion Policy, 2020.

The policy was introduced to legalise and regulate cultivation, processing and export of agarwood while creating a transparent and farmer-friendly ecosystem.

Move expected to curb illegal trade

According to Dr Islam, the policy framework will help curb the illegal movement of agarwood, which for years deprived local growers and entrepreneurs of fair returns. He said regulated exports would enable producers in Assam to directly access global buyers instead of depending on informal channels and intermediaries. Industry can generate ₹50,000 crore annually.

Dr Islam said the Agarwood industry has the potential to generate up to ₹50,000 crore in annual revenue for Assam if cultivation, processing and exports are scaled up in an organised manner.

He said the sector could emerge as one of the state’s leading foreign exchange earners, driven by rising international demand for agarwood chips, oud oil, perfumes and other value-added aromatic products.

Major boost for rural economy

Experts believe the organised agarwood sector could

transform Assam’s rural economy and become one of Northeast India’s most significant export industries.

Beyond raw chip exports, the sector offers considerable scope for value-added manufacturing, including oud oil, perfumes, bakhoor, incense products, cosmetic ingredients and aromatherapy products.

Expansion of plantations and processing facilities is expected to generate employment opportunities for rural youth and strengthen Assam’s agro-based industries.

Expansion plans underway

MJI Group and MJI Aromatics Pvt Ltd plan to expand plantations, establish advanced processing facilities, build a global brand for Assam oud and train farmers to meet international standards. Industry leaders say the successful export positions Assam to emerge as a global hub for agarwood, oud and fragrance products, transforming a traditional forest resource into a modern export-driven industry.

DAILY SUDOKU

		4				5	1	
	6				5			4
2				4	3			
4	7			9	1			
3								8
								2
			6	3		7		
			8	7				1
9		5					3	
	4	5				2		

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (14.5.26)

5	6	1	4	3	7	9	2	8
3	9	8	2	6	5	7	1	4
4	7	2	1	8	9	3	6	5
6	5	9	3	7	1	4	8	2
2	8	4	5	9	6	1	7	3
1	3	7	8	4	2	6	5	9
9	2	3	7	1	8	5	4	6
8	1	6	9	5	4	2	3	7
7	4	5	6	2	3	8	9	1

DOUBLE CROSSWORD FRIDAY| MAY 15, 2026

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
		9					
10						11	
				12			
13	14					15	16
17					18		
			19				
20	21						
24						22	23
			26				
27						28	
30							31

ACROSS

1 Velocity back in deep space (5)

6 Get up around noon and wash (5)

9 Go down as the originator (7)

10 Go along to the doctor to get fit? (5)

11 OK for audio (5)

12 Round bird? (5)

13 Fight to get a comic character to the top (5-2)

15 Sausage ingredient that'll make you look tired (3)

17 Anger, possibly hate (4)

18 It's good, say, for carrying water away

DOWN

2 Go after a cash prize out of turn (6)

3 Follower of a cause (6)

4 Point raised in talking to doctors (3)

5 Show unwelcome interest in spoon bending (5)

6 Is left to regret being excluded from the side, perhaps (7)

7 How hard I am on little Ronnie! (4)

8 Pronouncedly the sweet of the week? (6)

12 Rugby Union name for Australian football (5)

13 In short, it's of graphic significance (5)

14 Did Adam have one? (5)

ACROSS

3, Skril

8, Locum

10, Lovat

11, Wag

12, S-rag

13, Banck-OK

15, M-iser

18, L-i-le

19, Fac-i-le

21, Te-di-es

22, Moor

23, War-d

24, Decimal

26, Stayer

29, Nat

31, Ho-Less

32, P-erle-d

34, Minus

35, How

36, O-ide-r

37, Deat-h

38, Necks

DOWN

1, Ro-W-an

2, Juggler

4, Kick

5, Llamas

6, Lo-g-ic

7, Babel

9, Can

12, Solidier

14, K-i'd

16, Sisal

17, Read-y

19, Fel-lines

20, Amish

21, Total

23, W-atches

24, Des-ire

25, Mar

27, Too-Ls

28, Ye-me-n

30, He-w-its

32, Puck

33, Hop

BRIEFLY

Strasbourg beats Brest by 2-1 in Ligue 1



Strasbourg won 2-1 at Brest ahead of Paris Saint-Germain's potentially title-deciding Ligue 1 clash with Lens later on Wednesday.

PSG coach Luis Enrique selected a full-strength team at Stade Bollaert-Delelis even though his side only needed a draw to clinch a fifth consecutive Ligue 1 crown and a record-extending 14th overall. The match was rescheduled from April 11 by the French league to help titleholder PSG's ambitions in the Champions League. Although the postponement was strongly contested by Lens, coach Pierre Sage's side had no say in the matter.

Scottish race goes to last game



Celtic scored a penalty in the ninth minute of added time to clinch 3-2 win against Motherwell and set up an epic final day in the race for the Scottish title.

League leader Hearts beat Falkirk 3-0, meaning the title will be decided when the top two meet at Celtic Park on Saturday. Hearts stayed one point ahead of Celtic and will need at least a draw to finish in front.

But it looked to be in an even better position and closing in on its first title since 1960 until the late drama at Motherwell.

Ochoa's energy is rubbing off on Mexico teammates



Every chance he gets, Mexico coach Javier Aguirre is quick to highlight the leadership of Guillermo Ochoa, who is preparing for his sixth World Cup. The 40-year-old goalkeeper's teammates are happy to have him around, too.

Ochoa joined the Mexican national team's training camp this week as they prepare for their World Cup opener on June 11, and his impact on the locker room was immediate.

"It's fantastic for us to be able to share the field and the training camp with him," striker Guillermo Martinez said on Wednesday. "You can feel the energy of how he's experiencing this; he's someone we admire." Ochoa, an unused backup in Germany in 2006 and South Africa in 2010, could join the two biggest stars in the game – Lionel Messi of Argentina and Cristiano Ronaldo of Portugal.

Inter Miami rallies for 5-3 victory over Cincinnati

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Ohio

Lionel Messi had two goals and an assist, German Berterame had the go-ahead goal in the 84th minute and Inter Miami rallied for a 5-3 victory over Cincinnati, extending its road winning streak to seven.

It is the third time this season the Argentine superstar has had at least three goal contributions in a match. He is second in the league with 12 goals. Mateo Silvetti evened it at 3-3 in the 79th minute on Wednesday after coming on as a substitute.

Kevin Denkey, Pavel Bucha and Evander scored for Cincinnati. It is the first time in 64 matches since Pat Noonan became coach in 2023 it lost when it had the lead after 75 minutes. Messi gave Miami a 1-0 lead at the 24-minute mark after he deflected a shot that went off Cincinnati's Matt Miazga near the



Chris Wood to lead New Zealand at World Cup

STEVE MCMORRANAP ■ Wellington

Nottingham Forest striker Chris Wood has been selected to lead New Zealand's 26-strong World Cup squad despite an injury-disrupted season in the Premier League.

Wood and 36-year-old defender Tommy Smith, who has been recalled from England's fifth-tier National League to join the All Whites squad for the first time since late 2024, will become the first New Zealand men to play at two soccer World Cups. Both were part of the New Zealand squad for the 2010 tournament in South Africa.

As skipper, Wood follows Steve Sumner, who captained New Zealand to the World Cup in Spain in 1982,



and Ryan Nelsen, who led the team in 2010.

The New Zealand squad was announced on Thursday by coach Darren Bazeley in Auckland. Bazeley said he faced a difficult task in paring

Thomas Cup exposes India's sporting might



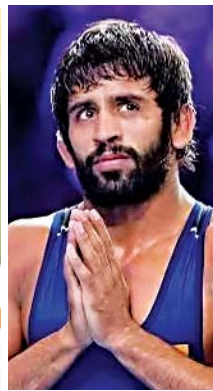
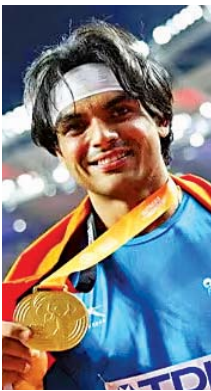
SHAKYA MITRA

India's bronze medal at the latest edition of the Thomas Cup once again underlined the country's growing stature in international badminton. While it did not replicate the historic gold medal triumph of 2022 compared by many observers as Badminton's equivalent to India winning the 1983 Cricket World Cup, the podium finish reinforced India's strong standing in the world game at the highest level.

Yet, this bronze medal, a credible feat in its own right, quickly gave way to a familiar debate about India's sporting culture.

Leading doubles pair Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty, both recipients of the Khel Ratna award, expressed their disappointment over social media on the relatively muted reception this feat received in India. This disappointment brought back a consistent theme that is so prevalent across Indian sports, are we truly a multi-sports nation.

The sentiment is hardly new. Two years ago, Indian hockey player Hardik Singh recounted an incident on a podcast. A member of India's bronze medal-winning hockey teams at both the 2020 Summer



Olympics and the 2024 Summer Olympics, Hardik described how public attention at an airport was directed more towards a social media influencer than athletes who had represented the country on the Olympic stage. The anecdote captured a frustration many non-cricket athletes have shared, many quietly while some have been vocal about it.

At the same time, cricket's dominance did not emerge by accident, nor overnight. Its rise was built over decades through sustained success, expanding media access and unmatched commercial growth. India's victory at the 1983 Cricket World Cup is rightly remembered as a transformative moment, but it was only the beginning. The triumph at the 1985 World Championship of Cricket, the spread of satellite television in the 1990s and the emergence of icons such as Sachin Tendulkar

helped cricket penetrate every corner of the country. Over time, the sport became a commercial powerhouse unmatched by any other discipline in India.

Other sports have certainly produced defining moments of their own, but none have altered the national sporting landscape in quite the same way.

Neeraj Chopra became India's first individual Olympic gold medalist in track and field while maintaining remarkable consistency on the global stage. India's hockey bronze medal at the Tokyo Olympics in 2021 carried immense emotional significance, ending a four-decade wait for an Olympic medal in the sport. The Indian women's hockey team's inspiring semifinal run at the same Games was equally celebrated. Over the past decade, Shooting, Badminton, Wrestling, Weightlifting and Boxing have all produced world

champions, Olympic medallists and landmark victories. India's growing success at the Olympics, Asian Games, Commonwealth Games and various World Championships also reflects a country becoming increasingly competitive across disciplines.

It is fair to say that the performance of the athletes in the above-mentioned sports has not gone unnoticed, Abhinav Bindra, PV Sindhu, MC Marykom, Neeraj Chopra, Saina Nehwal, Mirabai Chanu, Bajrang Punia among others have become well-known names amongst the Indian sports following public due to their exceptional performances. But the popularity of their respective sports has not grown to match that of cricket.

In an ideal scenario, excellence across disciplines would command sustained public engagement and equal recognition. The reality, however, remains different.

Cricket's scale, financial power and relentless visibility continue to dominate India's sporting imagination. This does not mean athletes from other sports are ignored or unsupported altogether. But in an increasingly crowded media ecosystem, public attention is finite and cricket continues to occupy the largest share of it.

The contrast becomes even sharper during years packed with major cricket tournaments. In 2024, for instance, India's victory at the 2024 ICC Men's T20 World Cup ended a long global title drought and generated nationwide euphoria. Barely a month later, the Paris Olympics began. Despite its significance, the focus and attention in the time period leading up to the event was evidently divided between cricket and the Olympics, very much helped by the aftermath of such a memorable and long-due title.

The concerns raised by India's Badminton stars now and other athletes before are not isolated cases but more a reflection of how sporting success is valued across the country. There is little doubt that India today is far more diverse in its sporting achievements than it was a decade ago. The country is producing elite athletes across disciplines with increasing regularity. The challenge becomes in creating a broader sporting culture rather than restricting such triumphs across different sports as one-off celebrations.

Inter seals double with Italian Cup win over Lazio

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Rome

Inter Milan cemented its domination of Italian soccer by securing the league and cup double for the first time in 16 years.

Inter beat Lazio 2-0 on Wednesday to win the Italian Cup, adding to the Serie A title it clinched with three rounds to spare.

Not since Jose Mourinho led Inter to a treble in 2010 – including the Champions League trophy – had Inter won the league and cup in the same season. Inter coach Christian Chivu, who is quickly making a name for himself in the managerial ranks after helping Parma avoid relegation last season, played on the 2010 team.

"What mark would I give Chivu? Ten out of 10," Inter captain Lautaro Martinez said after the final. Chivu is in his first season at Inter after replacing Simone Inzaghi, who left following the disappointment of the end of last season when the Nerazzurri finished one point below Serie A champion Napoli, lost in the Italian Cup semifinals and were routed 5-0 by Paris Saint-Germain in the



most lopsided Champions League final in history. "Doing the double is very important," Lautaro added.

"It wasn't easy to start again after what happened last year but we managed to have a great season in our performances, results and intensity. "I'm happy to finish with another trophy that matters a lot to us." Lazio initiated its own downfall on

Wednesday, gifting Inter both of its goals. Inter took the lead in the 14th minute when Federico Dimarco whipped in a corner from the right and Lazio defender Adam Marusic headed it into his own net.

The second goal, in the 35th, was the fault of Nuno Tavares as the Lazio defender was robbed of the ball by Denzel Dumfries just

outside the area. Dumfries cut inside and unselfishly rolled it across for Lautaro to score one of the easiest goals of his career, tapping it into an empty net from three yards out.

Inter had beaten Lazio 3-0 on Saturday in Serie A in a dress rehearsal for Wednesday's cup final in the same stadium in Rome.

PSG clinches league title

JEROME PUGMIREAP ■ Paris

Paris Saint-Germain clinched a record-extending 14th French league title after winning 2-0 at closest rival Lens on Wednesday. PSG needed only a draw to seal a fifth consecutive Ligue 1 crown and is now nine points ahead of Lens with one game left.

Khvicha Kvaratskhelia scored in the 29th minute and Ibrahim Mbaye added the second goal in stoppage time after Lens missed several chances to score at Stade Bollaert-Delelis. The match was rescheduled from April 11 by the French league to help titleholder PSG's ambitions in the Champions League. PSG takes on Premier League leader Arsenal in the Champions League final on May 30 in Budapest.

Although the postpone-



Manchester City keeps pressure on Arsenal



JAMES ROBSONAP ■ Manchester

The Premier League title race is not over yet. Manchester City cut Arsenal's lead at the top of the standings back to two points after beating Crystal Palace 3-0 at the Etihad Stadium. With two rounds of the season to go it means Arsenal will have to wait another week at least to be confirmed champion.

Mikel Arteta's team plays

relegated Burnley on Monday and a victory would leave City needing to beat Bournemouth 24 hours later to take the title race into the final day of the season.

"We've seen a lot of things can happen on the final day," City forward Phil Foden told Sky Sports.

"I've experienced it many times when the game doesn't go your way, so we just have to keep pushing and doing our part."

Barcelona's 100-point bid ends in loss in Spanish league

TALES AZZONIAP ■ Madrid

Barcelona's hopes of reaching the 100-point mark in the Spanish league ended with a 0-1 loss at Alaves.

Barcelona clinched its second straight league title on Sunday with a 2-0 win over rival Real Madrid at home and needed three wins in its last three matches to reach 100 points. The loss on Wednesday ended an 11-game winning streak for the Catalan club.

"A little bit disappointed about the result, we all wanted to win today," Barcelona coach Hansi Flick said. "But at the end I saw good things, I'm happy with the performance of the team."

Alaves' players provided a guard of honour for Barcelona's team before the



match, lining up and applauding their rivals as they entered the field.

It was a big win for Alaves, which moved out of the relegation zone with the result. It reached 15th place with 40 points, one point clear of the bottom three with two rounds left.

"We are not clear yet, but

it was a big step," Alaves forward Toni Martinez said. Ibrahim Diabate scored the winner from inside the area in first-half stoppage time.

Alaves hadn't earned a clean sheet in 20 straight league matches. Barcelona had scored at least once in 56 straight league matches.

Espanyol wins again:

Espanyol beat Athletic Bilbao 2-0 at home to end an 18-game winless streak and move further away from the relegation zone. Pere Milla scored in the 69th and Kike Garcia in stoppage time to give Espanyol its first win of the year. Its last victory had been in December at Athletic.



Not getting runs eats me up: Kohli

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Raipur

Indian batting superstar Virat Kohli says he is not immune to the anxiety that comes with performance pressure, admitting that consecutive ducks in the last couple of IPL matches had left him a bit nervous.

The 37-year-old roared back to form on Wednesday night with an unbeaten 105 off 60 balls as his team Royal Challengers Bengaluru defeated Kolkata Knight Riders by six wickets to climb to the top of the IPL table.

It was a record-extending ninth IPL hundred for Kohli as he went past Mahendra Singh Dhoni and Rohit Sharma to become the player with most appearances (279) in the tournament. It was also his first IPL century since the 2024 season.

"The fact that I didn't get many runs in the last two games was, it eats me up in a way that I know I can play well and I'm hitting the ball well," Kohli told the broadcaster after he was adjudged the Player of the Match.

"But then, when you don't carry on and you know (that) you haven't created the impact for the team, it bothers you because that's basically been the goal all these years... trying to improve so that you can be the best version for your team when you play out there and make an impact," he added.

Kohli admitted that he was a bit uneasy after being dismissed for ducks in the previous two outings, but also asserted that failures like these also play a role in a player's growth.

"The celebration (after completing the century) was not a big one because we know the importance of the points. It is a conscious effort to contribute more to the team," Kohli said.

There is a reason people say pressure is a privilege — it keeps you humble. Good pressure always helps you improve your game.

A couple of games that do not go your way, you feel a bit of nervousness and that helps you.

Tilak stars as MI crush PBKS' playoff hopes

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dharamsala

Punjab Kings slumped to their fifth straight defeat, seriously hurting their playoff hopes, as Mumbai Indians cruised to a six-wicket win in a crucial IPL clash on Thursday riding on Shardul Thakur's four-wicket haul and a clinical batting effort from Tilak Varma, who smashed 75.

Asked to bat first, Prabhsimran Singh (57) added a 33-ball 50-run opening stand with Priyansh Arya (27) to take PBKS to 55 for 1 in the powerplay and then added 57 runs with Cooper Connolly to go past the 100-run mark in the 12th over.

Shardul (4/39) brought MI back into the game with a four-wicket burst but PBKS managed to pile up 53 runs in the last three overs to post a competitive 200 for 8.

Chasing the target, Ryan Rickelton came out blazing as he single-handedly propelled Mumbai Indians to 59 for no



loss despite Rohit Sharma's scratchy 25 at the other end. PBKS fought back with three wickets for 57 runs between the seventh and 13th overs, but Tilak Varma anchored the chase superbly with an unbeaten 33-ball 75. He first stitched a 61-run stand off 42 balls with

Sherfane Rutherford (20) and then combined with Will Jacks to steer MI home in 19.5 overs.

The defeat severely dented Punjab Kings' playoff hopes as they now need to win both their remaining matches to stay in contention for a top-four finish.

Defending 200, Arshdeep Singh delivered two outstanding overs with the new ball, conceding just eight runs, but lacked support from the other end as Rickelton tore into the attack with four boundaries and four sixes during his explosive 23-ball 48. Skipper Shreyas Iyer

rotated his seamers in the powerplay, but Rickelton launched the assault with a six off Azmatullah Omarzai before hammering Marco Jansen and Xavier Bartlett.

Azmatullah eventually provided the breakthrough by dismissing Rickelton, while Jansen removed Naman Dhir (9). Yuzvendra Chahal then pulled things back briefly with a superb spell, first strangling Rohit for runs and later casting him as MI slipped to 89 for 3.

Tilak and Rutherford rebuilt the innings calmly before shifting gears, targeting Azmatullah for a 13-run over to ease the pressure. Arshdeep nearly provided another breakthrough when Tilak miscued a skier, but Jansen failed to hold on to a difficult chance.

With 72 needed off the last five overs, PBKS turned to Chahal again, but Tilak and Rutherford counterattacked brilliantly, taking 20 runs off the leg-spinner's over.

When you drop Kohli in a chase, it becomes difficult, says Nayar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Raipur

Kolkata Knight Riders coach Abhishek Nayar admitted that dropping Virat Kohli early in his innings proved costly, as the batting stalwart went on to score an unbeaten century and power Royal Challengers Bengaluru to a six-wicket win in their latest IPL match.

Kohli was dropped on 21 by Rovman Powell off Kartik Tyagi, which proved decisive as the master batter went on to strike an unbeaten 105 off 60 to guide RCB to the top of the standings on Wednesday night.



Chasing 193, Kohli and Devdutt Padikkal (39) forged a robust 92-run stand for the second-wicket.

"When you drop Virat Kohli, especially in a chase, it becomes very difficult," Nayar said at the post-match press conference.

Nayar felt KKR had enough runs on the board but the game slipped away from their hands because of small mistakes.

"As I said earlier, the score was fine on this pitch. There are a lot of things that could have been better. Virat's catch was a very tough one. The Angkrish catch, you would expect him to take."

The coach also believed the absence of Varun Chakravarthy, who missed the game due to a toe injury, hurt KKR.

Kohli has silenced doubters: Gavaskar



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Raipur

Batting maestro Virat Kohli proved that the "old generation is still the best" with his unbeaten century against Kolkata Knight Riders, former India captain Sunil Gavaskar said while lavishing praise on the Royal Challengers Bengaluru star for silencing doubters in the ongoing IPL.

Coming off two successive ducks, the 37-year-old Kohli smashed an unbeaten hundred to guide Royal Challengers Bengaluru to a six-wicket win over KKR and move to the top of the points table here on Wednesday.

"Virat Kohli was absolutely outstanding against KKR. He knows how to construct a chase better than most," Gavaskar said on Star Sports' 'Amul Cricket Live'. "While everyone was talking about this being the season of 'Gen Next', Kohli showed he is still around. He silenced the doubters with a century and moved to third in the Orange Cap race. He proved that the old generation is still the best."

Gavaskar highlighted Kohli's staggering consistency in the shortest format and



said his records may stand untouched for a long time.

"When it comes to T20 centuries, he is third on the list with 10, behind Chris Gayle and Babar Azam. But he is the fastest to 14,000 T20 runs and has nine IPL hundreds. Records are there to be broken, but it will take a very long time for anyone to match what Kohli keeps delivering, game after game, season after season," he said.

"This hundred from Virat Kohli was one of those special moments that remind us of his greatness." Gavaskar also pointed to the dropped catch of Kohli by KKR as a decisive turning point in the contest.

"Before this RCB-KKR game, KKR's efficiency with catches was still the best in the IPL this season. But this one hurt badly," he said.

3 IPL captains likely to lose leadership roles after disastrous campaigns

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ New Delhi

Three IPL captains are in the line of fire due to campaigns that have been nothing short of disastrous and they could end up losing their jobs when the season winds up later this month, sources tracking developments in various franchises have indicated.

Axar Patel, Ajinkya Rahane and Rishabh Pant have captained for two successive seasons and failed miserably in their bid to take their respective teams into the playoffs. Only Lucknow Super Giants are officially eliminated, making Pant the biggest fall guy of back-to-back poor seasons.

But for all practical purposes, Kolkata Knight Riders led by Rahane and Delhi Capitals helmed by Axar are also unlikely to be around during the business end of the



high-profile league. Axar's numbers as captain and player make for poor reading. He has scored only 100 runs in nine innings at a strike-rate of 112.50, with 56 coming in one innings and the remaining 44 aggregated across eight knocks despite batting mostly in the top-five.

In 12 games, Axar has bowled only 36 overs, exactly three overs per



game, and picked up 10 wickets at an economy rate of 8.08. While the economy rate looks respectable considering the punishment endured by fellow spinner Kuldeep Yadav, Axar has often under-bowled himself.

With Delhi Capitals having an arrangement of equal owners — JSW and GMR split management responsibilities in alternate cycles



— next season will see Parth Jindal and JSW taking charge of cricket operations.

"With Axar completely failing to prove his leadership worth and mostly being dependant on Hemang Badani and Venugopal Rao for decision making, it will be a miracle if he retains captaincy next year. "The entire coaching staff is

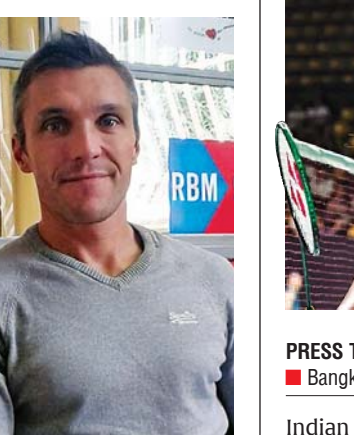
Hockey India names Frederic Soyeze as junior men's chief coach

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

India on Monday officially appointed decorated Frenchman Frederic Soyeze as the chief coach of the national junior men's hockey team, replacing two-time Olympic medallist PR Sreejesh.

Sreejesh, a former star goalkeeper, was removed from his role just after 17 months following the expiry of his contract after guiding India to a bronze medal finish at last year's FIH Junior World Cup in Chennai and Madurai.

In a strongly worded social media post, Sreejesh vented out his frustration, saying his tenure was brought to an end despite winning five medals in as many tournaments during his stint, but Hockey India argued that the decision was taken considering long-term vision of building a sustainable high-performance



ecosystem aligned with India's ambitions for hosting the 2036 Olympic Games.

One of the most accomplished coaches in European hockey, Soyeze brings over three decades of elite coaching experience, including 15 years as an international player for France and over 15 years as a head coach at the highest level.

Sindhu, Lakshya in quarterfinals of Thailand Open, Srikanth out



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bangkok

Indian shuttlers PV Sindhu and Lakshya Sen advanced to the quarterfinals of the \$5,00,000 Thailand Open Super 500 tournament with straight-game wins in their respective matches on Thursday. Two-time Olympic medallist and sixth seed Sindhu needed just 28 minutes to outclass Denmark's Amalie Schulz 21-13, 21-15 in the women's singles second round.

Seventh seed Lakshya, the 2021 World Championships bronze medallist, defeated China's Zhu Xuan Chen 21-12, 21-13 in a men's singles clash that lasted 39 minutes.

Sindhu will next face top seed and world Number 3 Akane Yamaguchi of Japan, while Lakshya will take on Thailand's second seed Kunlavut Vitidsarn. India's top-seeded men's doubles pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty also marched into the last-eight stage with a 21-

12, 21-19 win over Malaysia's Bryan Jeremy Gooning and Muhammad Haikal in 44 minutes.

The world No. 4 Indian duo will next meet the sixth-seeded Japanese combination of Takumi Nomura and Yuichi Shimogami. However, former world Number 1 Kidambi Srikanth crashed out after going down 16-21, 21-11, 18-21 to Chinese Taipei's world Number 47 Su Li Yang in a hard-fought contest lasting one hour and 10 minutes.

Super Chess Classic: Praggnanandhaa to take on Firouzja in opener

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bucharest (Romania)

Indian Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa will take on Alireza Firouzja of France in the first round of the Super Chess Classic here, the first classical event of the year which is as part of the Grand Chess tour.

Left as the lone Indian in the fray following withdrawal of world champion D Gukesh from the classical format this year, Praggnanandhaa drew a favourable number and will get five white games out of nine rounds in the 10-player all-play-all event.

For the records, the total prize pool of the event is \$3,50,000 with an additional \$1,25,000 as bonus. The first prize is \$1,00,000. The Indian is in need of an improved show following a mediocre outing in the last Candidates' tournament in April and has dropped to number 16 in world rankings in live ratings. Fabiano Caruana of the



United States starts as the top seed and is slated to meet informal Jorden van Foreest of Holland in the opener. Van Foreest had sensationally beaten world number one Magnus Carlsen of Norway in the just-concluded Te Pe Sigeman chess tournament and has been quite consistent in recent times and is number 20 in world rankings.

After Gukesh withdrew from main events, the seat was offered to his world championship challenger Javokhir Sindarov of Uzbekistan just before the

Candidates' started. Little did anyone know that Sindarov would dominate the Candidates the way he did and earn himself the right to challenge Gukesh later this year.

Sindarov is currently the most dominating player in the elite circuit with his ability to play extreme complex positions. The Uzbek had won the World Cup in October last year, and had a decent start to 2026 in the Tata Steel Masters and then won the Candidates with an all-time best performance.